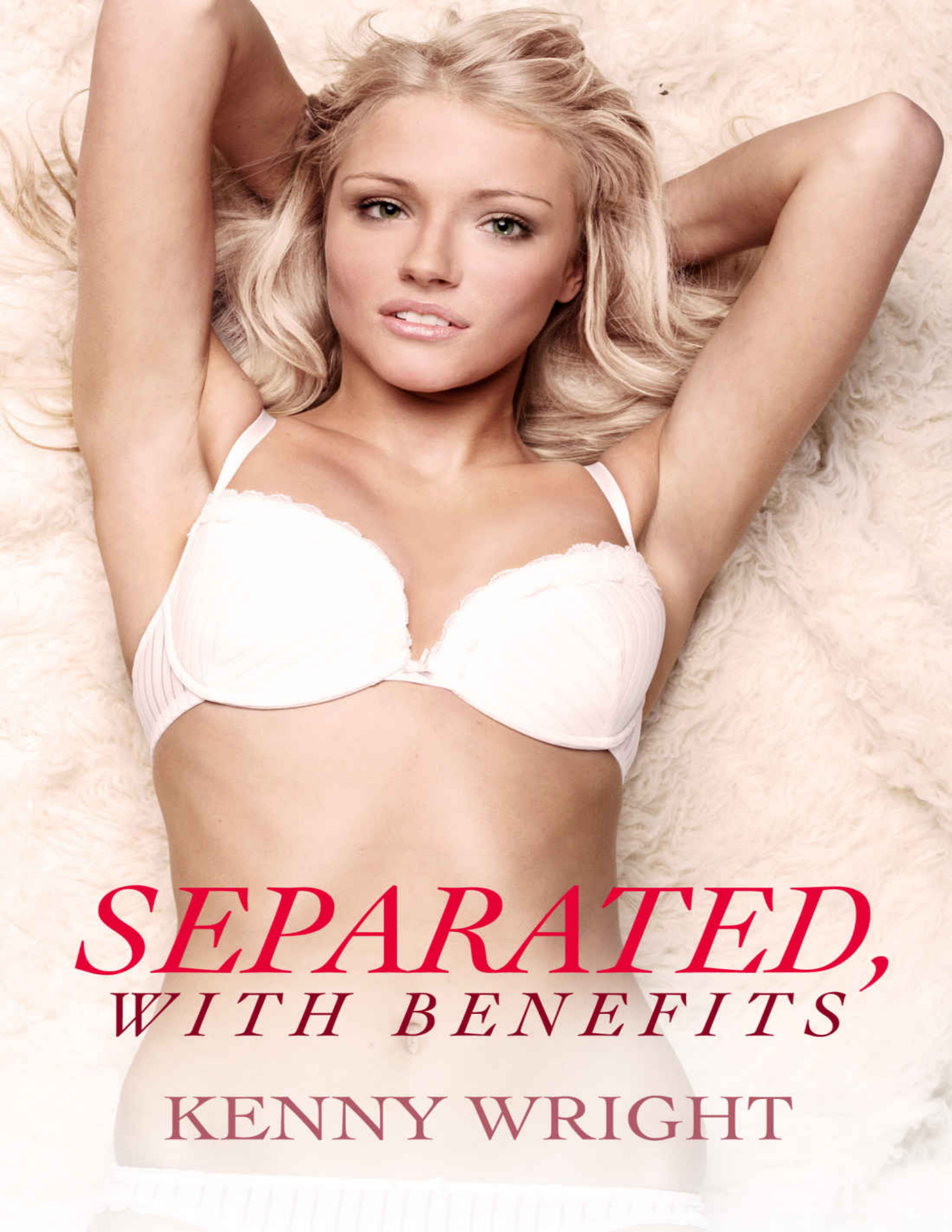




SEPARATED,
WITH BENEFITS

KENNY WRIGHT

not a date

I wiped my hands on my pants and once again wondered why I so nervous. It's not like this was a first date—or even a date, for that matter. This was just me catching up with an old friend who I happened to still be married to, yet hadn't seen in over a year.

Okay, put like that, maybe there was some cause to be a little nervous. This wasn't the first time I'd had this inner monologue, or come to this conclusion, or wondered if maybe it would have been better to cancel and delay for another time. I'd had it when composing the email to Nicole before flying out here. I'd had it again when choosing what to wear for this non-date. I'd certainly had it when choosing the restaurant to meet—a chain restaurant like Chili's, something fancier? I'd picked Green Leaf, one of our favorites back when we were together, and squarely in between Chili's and something fancier.

And now I was doing it here, while waiting for her, wondering if I should take off and delay some more.

This was silly. I was being silly. This wasn't a date. I was a 29-year-old man, and I worked on Capitol Hill, and I had a promising career and was happily single since we'd decided—mutually—to get separated, and I was not babbling to myself in my head because *this was not a date*.

I almost stood and left. I even might have, had I not looked toward the door just in time to witness Nicole make her entrance. I knew the trope about absence making the heart grow fonder and all that, but I almost couldn't believe that this was the same woman who I'd left behind when pursuing my career. She was gorgeous, and I wasn't the only one who took notice of her. The host greeted her with more enthusiasm than he had any other guest, smiling and welcoming. I felt the impulse to be jealous before I realized that I had no cause. She was no longer mine.

The host asked her a question. She answered distractedly as she craned her neck around him, searching the restaurant. For me. When her bright blue eyes found me, a smile lit her face. She tucked her golden hair behind her ear in a way that filled me with nostalgia. She pointed to me, the host nodded, and led her over.

I'd worried so much over what to wear and how to come off. If I dressed up, would she think I was trying too hard, or would she take it the wrong way, or think that life on the Hill had turned me into a douche bag like I knew she'd always feared? And if I dressed down, would it be insulting, or worse, net the same results as above? In the end, just like the Green Leaf, I'd settled on something in the middle—a pair of slim cut jeans and a shirt that I left deliberately untucked.

Nicole had gone for stunning. There was nothing trashy or overtly sexy about her striped and sleeveless dress, although it did cling pleasantly to her lean stature more than the dresses I remembered that she wore. I didn't remember her looking so comfortable in something that short—not that it was all *that* short—or so stylish. Like, ankle boots? Bangles clattering on her wrists? Large sunglasses worn on top of her head, pushing back her honey-blond hair?

“Hey, Ethan. Sorry I'm late.”

Ethan. That was me. Time to stand up and stop staring. Time to hug your ex-wife. Or not-quite-ex-wife. Or—

“Nicole, you look great!” I winced. The first thing I said after not seeing Nicole for over a year was a comment on how good she looked? Not a good start. I covered it up by hugging her. Awkwardly.

All of this was going so awkwardly.

“You look good, too, Ethan. How are things?”

We took our seats, a perfume that I didn't recognize lingering on me. Nicole hadn't worn perfume regularly since we'd first dated, and even then it was a rare occurrence.

I said, “Things are good. Great, actually. This election cycle has us all working like crazy, but I'm making some good contacts.”

“So you haven't joined a lobbying firm. Good.” Her dimples emerged with her smile.

Once upon a time, when I was just a Poli Sci major and Nicole was in nursing school, she'd teased me that I was just in it to make gads of money lobbying. I told her it was government that called me. The joke reminded me of a different life, and the nostalgia was sad.

“I may be a little disillusioned, but I'm not quite there yet,” I said lightly.

“You're part of the Washington establishment now. It's only a matter of time.” Nicole seemed to realize how that sounded and how she was

coming off. She softened. "I saw on Facebook that you got to go to the White House. That's so exciting."

It warmed me to think that Nicole followed me on Facebook. Also made me feel like a jerk for not doing the same.

"Oh, it's not a big deal. The president wasn't even there. We were just meeting some advisors."

"Still..." She trailed off, uncertain of what to say after I'd played the Big Shot card. God, I felt like an asshole, and this wasn't where I wanted it to go. "So how are you? Still at the hospital?"

"Still am. My hours are more regular now, which is nice." She looked down at the menu, but didn't seem to read anything. "Oh, and I repainted the house."

The house we'd shared. The house we'd bought together. "Yeah?"

"Yes. I'm slowly going through the rooms." When we'd bought it, the rooms were all beige, and we had always planned on changing that up, but never got around to. There were so many of those. "You should come by some time. To check it out."

I wanted to read into that. Was she inviting me over for more? Before I could even go down that path, though, our server came to take our orders.

"You two know what you'd like? Or do you need more time?" he asked.

I looked at Nicole, brows raised. We hadn't looked at the menus at all, but we always got the same thing anyway. She nodded to him. "I'll have the spinach salad please."

"Excellent choice," he said. "And you, sir?"

"I, ah..." That wasn't her usual order, and because it wasn't, I was thrown off. "The petite filet. Medium rare, please."

"Right away. Would you like anything to drink? A glass of wine, perhaps?"

"Glass of the house red," I said at the same time Nicole said, "Water is fine."

"So one spinach salad, the petit filet, medium rare, and one glass of house red for the gentleman."

I suddenly wanted to cancel my order of wine, but it was done. It would probably be more conspicuous doing that now, anyway. When the server left, I said, "Switching it up, huh?"

“What’s that?” She pulled her sunglasses off her head and ran her fingers through her hair, shaking it out. It was styled differently than when we’d been together—cut short enough that it didn’t quite brush her shoulders when it was down. It made her look older, more mature.

I remembered that she’d asked me a question. “I thought you always ordered the ahi tuna salad here.”

Nicole nodded thoughtfully, chewing on that. “Not for a while, but yeah, I guess I did.”

We made more awkward small talk as we waited for the food to arrive. She was the same woman that I’d met, but different, and because of that, I swung between being comfortable with her and wanting to impress her.

It was Nicole who broke the ice at last.

“So why are you here, Ethan?”

“Well, Congressman Phillips is setting up a campaign office here. He figured that since I was from his home town, it would make sense that I check up on it in person.”

Nicole shook her head. “That’s not what I mean. Why are you *here*? You and me? It’s been over a year. No contact. Not even a birthday or Christmas card. And then, out of the blue, this.”

She sounded more curious than bitter. After all, she also hadn’t sent cards or called. We’d both chosen to let the past lay dying. I wondered if we ever would have seen one another again if I hadn’t called.

When I didn’t answer immediately, she said, “Do you want to make it official?”

“Official?”

“Divorce.”

Oh. “Oh.”

“I can afford to buy the house out now. Even in the current market. So that’s not a problem.”

“Is that what you want?” I said. It hurt to even ask it. Felt so final.

Nicole read me as easily as ever. “I’m in no rush.”

“So you’re not dating anyone?” I realized that this was the question that I’d wanted to ask since coming out here, but couldn’t figure out how to say. Now that I’d just blurted it out, I wished that I could take it back.

“No,” she said, although her face did flush a little. This was definitely a strange conversation for a husband and wife to have, separated or not. “You?”

“No,” I lied. Or not lied, really, but it wasn’t a complete truth. I wasn’t dating anyone seriously. “This is weird, isn’t it?”

Nicole laughed. It was the same heart-warming laugh that she’d always had, the kind that felt like drinking hot chocolate on a cold day.

“Maybe a little.”

“Heh. Remember that time we thought we were talking to Carrie’s Mexican friends?” I said. Memory lane was a shared place for us, and it was so easy to find myself there.

Nicole laughed again, covering her mouth. “The ones who were actually from India? Oh, God, how could I forget? You kept trying to speak to them in Spanish!”

“To be fair, at the time, I was a little drunk. And in my defense, I also thought something was funny. I mean, they didn’t look Mexican.”

“It’s funny how we can think something, even when we know it’s not true,” Nicole said. “Why were you thinking of that?” She paused, her eyebrows going up. “Oh, God, you don’t think this moment is *that* awkward, do you?”

“No,” I said. Then, “Not quite.”

Nicole’s laughter subsided. “Well that’s good.”

We stared at each other in silence. I took a bite of my filet. She ate her salad. Our forks scraped across our plates. I was suddenly aware of the music filtering through the Green Leaf. Had there always been music, or was that another thing I hadn’t noticed until now? The silence stretched, threatening to get uncomfortable.

“So—” we said at once, then stopped at once.

When we regrouped, I got my question in first. “How’s the old neighborhood? You maintaining the house?”

“Neighborhood hasn’t changed. Same as ever. That derelict house on Broad and Evers finally got bought up by a developer, though. Michael asks about you every now and again.”

Michael had been our neighbor a few houses down, and the two of us had gotten to be friends. “I should stop by sometime. Say hello.”

“I think he’d like that.”

No more talk of divorce. No more talk of our personal lives, or even those shared moments from the past. We stuck to safe and innocuous topics—the neighborhood, downtown, local politics. It was as sterile as an operating room.

And then it was time to go. Nicole glanced at her watch—a delicate, silver piece that I didn't recognize. "Oh wow, didn't realize the time."

I pulled out my phone and checked myself, rather than ask her. It was only 9:15, although that meant we'd been here for almost an hour. Funny, it felt like much longer.

Nicole retrieved her wallet from her purse. "I need to be going," she said. She had cash ready, and peeled off enough to cover her side.

"Don't worry about it," I said. "I've got it."

Nicole shook her head, not having it. "Not worried," she said, leaving the money on the table.

When she stood, disappointment swept through me like a cool breeze. I almost shivered. Instead, I stood with her. "It was good to see you, Nicole."

"It's good to see you, too, Ethan."

When we hugged, I didn't want to let her go. In that hug, I remembered everything that I'd left behind, and none of the reasons that I had. She was Nicole, the girl I'd met on a plane flight headed to college, the girl I'd fallen in love with by the time we'd landed. The girl with the blond hair and blue eyes and the dimples, like she was from the country, rather than Seattle, Washington. In my arms at that moment, she felt the same as ever, soft yet not, her height just right to rest against my shoulder.

But I had to let her go. I'd done it already, when I'd decided to take my job and stay in DC. So I did, as bittersweet as this moment was. And when I did, and Nicole stepped back and smiled, I realized that she wasn't that girl. Not anymore. She was a new woman, and not my own.

"Hey, with the reelection cycle starting up again, I may be back more frequently."

"Oh, yeah?" Nicole's face was carefully neutral. I hesitated, suddenly uncertain if that was good news to her. She disarmed that feeling with a smile. "Then maybe It won't be a year next time. Have a good night, Ethan. And a safe flight home."

"You, too, Nicole."

I watched her walk out, her stride confident. The dress really did cling to her, drawing out the hourglass shape of her body in a way that made me ache. Had she dressed up for me, and I'd squandered the opportunity?

I watched the wake she made on her way to the doors. Guys turned to look at her, seeing her not as I did, familiar and friendly, but the way I may

have had we not shared so much history—as a stone cold fox. I felt possessive of her, biting back the jealousy before I remembered that I had no reason for it.

And then she was gone, and all I felt was alone.

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a white lie

That sense of loneliness accompanied me all the way back home to DC, a lone storm cloud that didn't dissipate so much as I just forgot to notice it. When I landed in the low city that I now called home and made my way to my small apartment in Capitol Hill, I had to remind myself that this really was home. It was like an alcoholic reminding himself that club soda was enough.

Truth was, Nicole had been my home for so long. We'd met on the plane as we both returned to school. It had been the last year of my political science master's, and Nicole's last year of nursing. We'd been inseparable since.

To deal with the storm cloud, I tried to focus on the end and those last couple years. We'd settled in Hempstead, a suburb of Seattle. We had a nice little house with a reasonable mortgage. We had a routine—as good as can be expected with Nicole's job—and friends to share that routine with. We were thinking of getting a dog.

It was a good life. A normal life. A boring one. We'd started treating each other more like roommates than husband and wife. We talked about the mortgage and what color to paint the house. We talked about rearranging the furniture in the den. We didn't talk about us anymore, or stay out late drinking at bars and being irresponsible.

When the congressman from our district got elected and I was offered a job working for him in Washington, DC, I'd actually turned it down. It has been Nicole who convinced me to try it out. She'd seen how unhappy I was, even before I'd been unhappy.

So we'd tried it out, doing the long distance thing. I'd fly back every other weekend. She came out to visit me when she had a break in her shifts. It kind of worked, we told ourselves, even though it really didn't. The trips home became fewer and fewer. The time between grew. And then we had our talk.

"Trial separation," it was called. Not a divorce. Not an end. But a pause. There were a lot of upsides to it. We didn't have to deal with Nicole's very Catholic parents. We didn't have to deal with the house and the mess that came with selling it. And there existed the possibility that

someday, we could un-pause things and we'd go right back to the comfortable life we'd left.

I was long past that now. I'd moved on, and so has Nicole, and I was fine with that. Or so I'd thought until we'd had dinner. It was like tearing the bandage off an old wound, only to find the wound still there.

When I landed in DC, I had a message waiting for me.

—Hope your flight went well. Text me if you want to grab a drink.

My heart leapt for a moment when I thought that it had come from Nicole, and that somehow I'd missed it before going to bed last night. It didn't make sense, and my flash of hope was worth making a mental note of.

[Me]: Not tonight.

[Cate]: :(See you at work then.

I grimaced as a ball of guilt tightened up in my gut. Cate was a fun girl. She also worked for the Congressman and we'd had a casual thing going on for the last few months. I got the feeling, like now, that she wanted to take things to the next level, but I'd been putting her off. I hadn't been ready to start anything serious, and now I knew why.

"You have a good trip, buddy?" a chatty Uber driver asked as he drove me home.

"Not really. I lied to my wife."

"Not a good thing, friend-o. Happy life is a happy wife."

"We're separated now."

"Ah," he said. For a second, I allowed myself to believe that I'd shut the conversation down. Then the man pressed on. "What was the lie? Big or small?"

I considered telling him that it was none of his business, because it wasn't and I was starting to get comfortable with this feeling of self-pity. "Small, I guess, considering the circumstances." I chuckled to myself. "I told her I wasn't seeing anyone."

"And you are, I take it?"

"That would be the lie, yes."

The man found me in his rearview mirror. He didn't look judgmental of me. "How long you been apart?"

"Thirteen months."

The driver whistled. "So why did you lie?"

That was the question, wasn't it? We weren't together. I hadn't flown out there to get back together, or rekindle anything. I'd called her because it seemed like the right thing to do, and if I was going to spend more time in the same town as her, we probably would have bumped into one another at some point, so might as well be on my terms.

So I'd told myself then, so I told myself now. Only after seeing her, it seemed so flimsy.

"Don't know," I said.

"You wanted her to think you were available, right? She pretty?"

"Very, but it's not that." I said it as much for me as for the driver. "Seemed like the right thing to say at the time, I guess. It's weird, you know? She's still my wife. You don't usually tell your wife that you're casually dating."

He chuckled. "No, you do not."

"She said she wasn't dating anyone either, so when she asked, I kind of...lied."

The man nodded, and then, without realizing how profound his next statement was, said, "Maybe she lied, too."

I don't remember anything else we said to one another. I barely remember getting back to my apartment and lugging my bags up the three stories to unit 302. The driver's statement reverberated in my head: *maybe she lied, too... maybe she lied... lied...*

It hadn't occurred to me, and now that it did, I couldn't stop thinking about it. I tried thinking back on the conversation. How had she behaved when I'd asked her if she was dating anyone? Had she answered too quickly? Had she been nervous? She'd blushed—I think—but had that been because of how inappropriate a question like that was from her ex-husband, or because she was lying?

Maybe she lied, too.

I felt dizzy and sick to my stomach and knew that this reaction wasn't fair. But I also couldn't deny it. I was jealous. I felt...betrayed?

I got myself a beer from the fridge and twisted it open. I didn't even bother turning the lights on as I took a big swig of it in the dark.

She'd looked really nice—date-worthy nice. I remembered her dress, short enough to show off her legs, sleeveless to show off her arms. She'd

been so put together—ankle boots, bangles... I couldn't recall her makeup, but in hindsight, I decided that she'd been wearing more than usual.

At the time, I'd thought that maybe it had been for me. Now, thousands of miles away, I had to wonder if it was for someone else. She'd left early—9:30 felt early now. She'd only had a salad. No wine. Did she have plans with someone else after we'd met?

I thought about how that meet up could have gone, picturing some square-jawed doctor waiting for Nicole in another restaurant. I imagined the way his eyes would track her body as she approached, a coy smile on her face.

How did it go with the ex? he'd ask.

Weird. But over now, she'd say.

He'd stand and take her into his arms. *Want to skip dinner and head back to my place? I can make you forget all about it.*

Well, I did eat a little something already...

And they'd laugh and walk out, arm in arm.

I felt the rush of the beer hit my head as my imagination tormented me. I felt something else, too, completely unexpected and unsettlingly confusing. I felt aroused.

I wouldn't have believed it myself if it weren't for the tightness in my jeans where I'd begun to harden. This made no sense. This was shock setting in, my brain dealing with this psychological trauma in a really weird way.

And yet each time I thought of that square-jawed M.D. pulling Nicole into his arms, my heart convulsed and a wave of nausea mixed with excitement pulsed through me.

"Get a hold of yourself, man," I said aloud. "She didn't lie. Why would she lie?"

Even as I said it to myself, I felt the almost irresistible pull to check up on her on Facebook, to scour her feed and friends for who my imagined doctor could have been. I resisted the temptation because I didn't know how I'd react if I found him.

Instead, I finished my beer, ordered pizza, and turned on Netflix. Two shows in and I was able to forget all about my trip and my ex and what she might be doing right now.

Even still, the next day I broke things off with Cate for good.

Michael

I was back in Hempstead two months later, once again on behalf of the Congressman. Not for the first time did I think about the compressed life of a U.S. congressman. He'd been in office for barely a year, and he was already contending with reelection. And he was in a relatively safe Democratic district.

Not that I was as disillusioned as many of my colleagues. They'd come from other offices with a lot more experience than me, and had been around the Federal scene for too long. I still loved government, even with all of its bureaucratic problems, and I loved being part of it.

This time around, I contacted my old neighbor, Michael, letting him know that I had a free night. He'd enthusiastically invited me over to his place, even offered to put me up, before I turned him down in favor of the hotel.

Not that I didn't consider it. And especially not that it had anything to do with being so close to Nicole.

I'd thought about her, on and off again, over the ensuing weeks. Like all things, the intensity of my thoughts faded with time. I could think about her dating without the visceral jab to my gut...and those other, more confusing emotions. Either she was, or she wasn't, and while she probably wasn't—because she'd said that she wasn't—if she was, then good for her. She was still young, smart, successful, and, of course, beautiful. She deserved someone. Even a square-jawed doctor.

"You know what I kept expecting?" Michael said after he pulled me into his arms for a bear hug. "I kept thinking you'd show up in a BMW or something. DC hot shot and all that."

I laughed. It was good to see Michael. "You know that's not what it's like, right? I don't even own a car."

Michael shrugged and waved me inside. "Come on, I just tapped a keg of this sweet, sweet Imperial IPA. It's fucking delicious."

Michael had put on a little weight since I'd seen him last, although he's always been a pretty large man. His home brewing hobby contributed to some of that, but he was also the kind of guy who just didn't care. He was like a giant teddy bear and fuck you if you didn't like teddy bears.

Once we'd arrived at his keezer—a fridge that he'd converted to hold a pair of taps for his kegs—he said, “So if you did own a car, it would be a BMW, right?”

“I'm partial to Audi's myself.”

“Get the fuck out of here!” He turned from the keezer to stare at me and saw my smile. “You're fucking with me.”

“And I'd forgotten how much you swear,” I said.

“What I hear you saying is that you missed me.”

I laughed. I really did miss Michael—and guys like him. The few friends that I'd met in DC were all hyper-attuned to the political scene. It didn't mean that they didn't appreciate a good micro-brew, and I'd even met a guy with a similar setup to Michael, but they were also so aware of the image that they projected, and cultivated it as surely as Michael did his hops.

We drank beer and talked about sports and our jobs. I filled him in on all the work that needed to be done before next November. He talked about how things were going at his startup.

“We got a sweet VC injection last fall. With any luck, we'll have a release out in a month or two.”

“Very nice, man.”

Michael said, “And if that doesn't work out, then I'll have to get my suit out of the closet and make the job searching rounds.”

“You may have to leave the house!” I joked.

“Fuck you, asshole.”

I laughed, but it felt hollow. I felt hollow, like I was watching myself talk and behave while thinking of something else. Michael picked up on it, too, and he even knew what it was I was thinking.

“She's good, you know,” he said.

“Hm?”

“Oh, don't give me that horse shit. *Nicky*. She's good.”

It was like the floor decided to roll up and try to knock me on my ass. “Does she know you call her *Nicky* behind her back?”

“Of course not. And stop trying to change the subject. You should go over there. Say hi.”

“I don't think that would be a good idea,” I said.

I knew this because I'd spent a lot of time imagining just that, and it never ended well. I'd knock and she wasn't home. I'd knock and she'd be

annoyed that I hadn't called ahead. I'd knock, and a man would answer. That last one was the one that I came back to the most, and it was the most crippling.

So no, I wouldn't be going over. So I'd decided long before Michael had made the suggestion.

What I hadn't counted on was just how strong his Imperial IPA was, and just how open to persuasion that it would make me.

"I think it's a great idea. She still misses you, you know."

"She does?" He was probably just saying that, but I felt warmth nevertheless.

"Course she does. She asks about you whenever we get together, like I have a fucking clue what you're doing."

"What do you tell her?"

"That you're driving a BMW around."

I shook my head. "I walked into that one, didn't I?"

"You sure did." He looked at his phone. "Come on, grab your coat and your beer."

"Where are we going?"

Michael didn't answer. Just made his way to the front porch with his drink and a pack of smokes. He offered me one, but I turned it down. I said, "Why are we out here? It's January."

"Well, I'm going to smoke a ciggy, and you're going to finish that drink, then head on over to your old place."

It was certainly a plan that Michael would devise. Me, I still couldn't see it working, but was beginning to come around to trying it anyway. "That's it? Just walk up to her place and knock?" And then, because of the beer, I added, "What if some guy is there?"

I was fishing, and knew it as soon as the words were out. Michael took a slow drag on his cigarette, studying me before answering. "What makes you think she's got a guy over there?"

Does she? I wanted to ask. Or, *Has she ever?*

I couldn't because I didn't want to know. Ignorance was bliss. It let me hold on to the past. It let me ignore this weird and confusing emotion of the present. And as ashamed as I was, it filled my future with hope. What would my cynical Hiller friends think of me now?

"Hard to imagine Nicole alone is all," I said. "But whatever, I still can't just go over there unannounced."

Michael looked past me. “Then let’s announce you,” he said. “Hey, Nick! Look who crawled onto my porch!”

I almost didn’t look. He had to be messing with me. That’s what Michael did. I’d look, no one would be there, and he’d get a laugh out of something that was not funny. But I also couldn’t *not* look. And when I did, there she was.

Nicole was dressed for winter jogging—tight, black leggings and a matching running shirt, accented with bright pink piping, gloves, and a pink fleece band to cover her ears. Her hair was tied up in a ponytail and whipped back and forth, and her face was flushed from exertion and the cold.

At first, I don’t think she recognized me. When she did, her eyes went wide for moment. Was that panic, or just surprise? I wouldn’t have blamed her if she’d run past us. Maybe a part of me hoped that she would.

But of course she didn’t. Nicole wasn’t like that. She was friendly to a fault, and slowed to a stop, making her way up Michael’s walk. I tried really hard not to notice how tight her running clothes were on her. I think that I did a pretty good job.

When she got within earshot, she shouted, “Who is this guy? I don’t recognize him, but he’s pretty cute.”

Michael said, “This is my friend, Ethan. He’s kind of an asshole. Drives a BMW and all.”

“I don’t drive a BMW,” I said.

Michael pressed on, ignoring me. “You’ll have to forgive him. He works in Washington, DC.” As if to say, he’s a liar. Which reminded me of my real lie last time, which reminded me that maybe Nicole had, too.

Nicole met my eyes, looking suddenly shy. “Hey, Ethan. How’s it going?”

“Pretty well. Kind of drunk.”

Michael clapped me on the back. “We were just talking about you.”

I could have killed him.

“Yeah?” Nicole asked.

“Well, about the house, really. I was trying to explain the color you painted the kitchen, but I just couldn’t do it.” Speaking of liars...

“Tuscan Sun,” Nicole said. “It’s pretty common. Why do you hate it so much?”

“Because it’s pretty common? Anyway, mind if Michael checks it out? Someone else needs to validate that it looks like the sun vomited all over your walls.”

Nicole rolled her eyes. She knew what he was trying to do. Worse, when she looked at me, I realized that she thought that I was in on it. I think that my face could have passed for Tuscan Sun after that. I started to shake my head and deny when Nicole cocked her head.

“Sure, why not. Give me about twenty minutes to clean up.”

And with that, she turned and jogged off. I was so stunned that I barely noticed how good her ass looked in her running leggings.

Michael led me inside, taking my unfinished glass from me and finishing it off himself. “Well, that went pretty well.”

“Why am I your friend again?”

“Don’t know. A couple years ago, I’d say it was because you’re a decent guy and I was your neighbor, so it was out of some sort of duty. Now? Maybe because you were hoping I’d do what I just did.”

“No way,” I denied.

Michael wasn’t buying it, but didn’t call me on it. “Come on, let me fill you a growler of the Imperial. It would be rude to make a house visit without a gift.”

“I didn’t bring you a gift,” I said flatly.

“And I forgive you, sweetheart.” He filled his growler when something occurred to me.

“You know Nicole’s running schedule?”

Michael turned back to me, his grin entirely unapologetic. “Your wife has one fine ass. What can I say? Now get out of here. See you around. Maybe next time, you can take me for a ride in your Beamer.”

I should have stayed in at the hotel.

home

Nicole's house—my old house—was just two houses away from Michael's. The walk felt like two miles, and yet it still felt too short. I'd been nervous two months ago, when waiting for Nicole to arrive at the restaurant. We'd been on neutral ground. Either one of us could get up and leave if things got too weird. Also, and possibly more importantly, I'd had time to mentally prepare for the meeting.

Now, I was not only entering her turf—whether I owned half of this house or not—but I had about three minutes to get my head right. It wasn't even close to enough time.

Our front door was the same, buttery yellow that it had always been. The plants beneath the awning were also the same. The walk could have used some edging, but beyond that, it was like I'd never left. But I had, and things were different.

Taking a deep breath, I knocked. Then continued to hold that breath. What if a guy really did answer the door? Her boyfriend. Her *live-in* boyfriend. The idea of it twisted in my gut. I reached out, bracing my hand on the door frame when the door finally opened.

"Oh, hi there," Nicole said, surprised to come face to face so close.

I realized how this must look, how I was hanging onto the door like some brash suitor. The only other thing that was needed was a sparkle in my smile.

"Um, hi." I snatched my hand away from the door frame and stepped back. I lifted the growler. "Michael sent me over with this."

"What a thoughtful man," she said, taking it from me. "Come on in."

If this was weird for Nicole, she didn't show it. If anything, she was acting like this was perfectly normal. I needed to copy that.

Judging by her damp hair, she'd showered since she'd run by. Showered and changed, although she'd put on another pair of black leggings that conformed to her legs and butt just as nicely. She wore a plain, pale pink t-shirt and a short, black cardigan. Casual, in other words. Deliberately so? Or was this how Nicole normally hung around the house when she was alone? I seemed to recall rattier jeans and sweatshirts.

I followed her in before she caught me staring at her ass.

The house looked different than the one I remembered. All the furniture was new, for one. Gone were our IKEA furnishings, replaced by a more adult sectional, more polished coffee and side tables, artwork that I didn't recognize but immediately felt like Nicole.

"So this is the color that Michael finds so objectionable," Nicole said.

I looked away from the new furniture and into the kitchen. Gone was the tired beige it had been when we'd bought it. Nicole had painted it a rich, orange-red, textured by a sponge to make it look like stucco. It reminded me of the Italian cafes that Nicole had always wanted to visit.

"Well?" she said.

"I don't understand why he hates it," I said.

Nicole retrieved a couple pint glasses and set them on the counter. "So does that mean you don't hate it?"

"I love it. It's very...it fits you."

"So I'm like a...how did he put it? A sun that vomited on the wall? Am I the sun? Or the vomit?" She popped the hinge-top of the growler and filled the pint glasses.

"Definitely the sun. You smell too good to be the vomit." It was the previous drinks talking, but now that I'd said it, I realized that she really did smell good. She wasn't wearing perfume like the not-a-date, but she must have switched shampoos to something fruity.

"Well, cheers to not being vomit. This stuff any good?"

I touched my glass to hers. "It's certainly strong."

Nicole laughed, then took a sip. "Not bad. Not bad at all. But yes, I can taste how strong that is. How many did you have?"

"I can't remember." I laughed.

"That many, huh? Did you eat dinner?"

I had to think for a moment before answering. Had I downed something at the hotel? "Nope."

"Oh, Ethan, how irresponsible. Is this how you live your life now?" She smiled, making the scolding seem like flirting. "I've got some leftovers. I'll heat them up. You go easy on that glass."

She turned to the fridge, opening it and crouching down to grab some Tupperware from the lower shelf.

"You don't have...to." I stuttered when her black leggings pulled tight and low on her ass, and the black band of her thong peeked out.

I moved sideways, putting the counter between me and her and the thong. It was the only way I would be able to stop looking. In all the years that we'd been together, Nicole had only worn a thong a handful of times, and always with dresses that required them. Never had she ever worn them around the house like this. Never so casually.

Or maybe that was for me?

"Here we go. Lamb kabobs okay?" She popped up and set the plastic container between us.

"Perfect," I said. "But seriously, you don't have to."

"I'm hungry too, and I need to get these out of here." She turned and popped them into the microwave. "So you didn't let me know you were coming into town."

I stared at her ass, thinking about her racy underwear when she turned back to me. This time, she caught me. She smiled but didn't say anything.

"Yeah, I'm sorry about that." Then, again because I was a little tipsy, I added, "I wasn't sure you'd want to...you know. After last time..."

"Last time?" I couldn't tell if she was playing coy with me on purpose, or was actually confused.

"Wasn't sure if you'd be busy or something," I said lamely.

"Only way to find out would be to ask," she said. The microwave beeped behind her. She turned away from me again. "But you're acting strangely. Maybe you didn't want to see me."

"No, not that," I blurted. "Actually, I was worried that *you* wouldn't want to see *me*."

"Really? Why's that?" She didn't bother with a plate. She just grabbed a couple forks and placed the steaming plastic container before us.

"I don't know." Because you had a date after, I didn't say. "It's kind of weird, after...you know. The separation."

"A little," Nicole conceded. "Wait, it must be really weird being here, then. For you, I mean."

"Not for you?" I asked.

"I guess some. But it's not a bad weird." She forked a chunk of lamb and bit into it as she thought about it. "It helps that you're kind of drunk. Makes me feel like I've got the upper hand. You always were a fun drunk."

I said, "Should I be worried about being taken advantage of?" The question registered with a twitch between my legs.

When she smiled at me and didn't say anything other than to take a long sip of her own beer, that twitch turned into something real and rising.

"I like the new furniture," I said, changing the subject.

Nicole brightened. "Thanks. After we decided to separate, I decided that I needed a fresh start, you know?"

The way she mentioned the separation like she was referring to last week's snowstorm should have been off-putting. Instead, it helped me relax. It was a thing. It had happened, and we were adults who could move past it.

Also, though, deep down, her casualness hurt. I kept that emotion bottled up. It was embarrassing.

"Well, you've got good taste. I should have let you decorate my place in DC."

"Oh, God, let me guess, black leather sofa?" I winced, and Nicole laughed. "You did not!"

"Afraid I did," I said.

"Was Michael serious about the BMW?"

"Does that sound like me?" I said defensively.

"Fair, fair." She went over to the stereo system—at least that was from my time—and turned on some music.

"The Cranberries?" I asked.

Nicole shrugged. "Since we got together last, I've been going through a phase. Everything that's old is new again."

I remembered how much Nicole loved the Cranberries when we'd first started dating. "Did you pull out the Ani DiFranco albums?"

"That was so last week, Ethan."

We laughed together. It felt good. It felt...like home. Or at least the memory of home.

"So I also replaced most of the furniture upstairs," she said.

"My grandfather's desk chair?"

"That's still there, goof. So is your desk." She finished up her pint. I looked at mine, barely a quarter of the way down. She must have been chugging hers.

That's when I saw the nervousness in the way she couldn't quite hold my eyes. Interesting.

"Got a new bed, though. A queen."

My heart kicked up a notch. "Yeah?"

"Want to see it?"

This wasn't what I was expecting, and yet somehow exactly what I dreamed. "Yeah, I do."

Nicole seemed to let go of something she'd been holding on to—nerves, anxiety, fear of rejection. She came around the counter, trailing her fingers along its edge. She'd painted her nails the same pink as her t-shirt, and she wore a number of rings that I didn't notice, including one on her thumb. But her wedding rings were gone. It shouldn't have felt like the gut punch that it was. After all, it had been a long time since I'd worn mine. Still, it did.

"You look good, Ethan," Nicole said. I tore my eyes away from her hand as she reached out to me. She touched my chest, spreading her fingers up to my shoulders. "You're keeping in shape."

"So are you. Running even in the winter."

Nicole shrugged. "It's a routine. Keeps me thinking about...other things. You know?"

I didn't, but also couldn't find the courage to ask. My mind was too busy filling it in with all kinds of crazy things—she'd turned into a nymphomaniac and spent her free time prowling for men; she'd gotten into online sex chat rooms; the square-jawed M.D. wormed himself in there.

"Ethan?"

"Hm?"

"I don't want you to read anything into what's about to happen, okay?" She really did look nervous. It made me see her the way I had when we first crossed this line. It was thrilling to be able to do that again.

"And what do you think I'd be reading?"

Nicole sighed. Like, *this is a mistake* sighed. Like, *we shouldn't do this* sighed. But what she said was, "I know how things are between us. How they stand. I'm not trying to lure you back. I know the past is past. But right now..." She blew out some air, looked away for a split second, then back. "Right now, I need you."

I didn't let her twist in the breeze. Not even for a second. Before she'd even finished saying *you*, my lips were on hers.

Like so many other things in this surreal return to my past life, our kiss was both familiar and powerfully new. Her lips felt the same, and the way she accepted the kiss was as I remembered. I pressed with my tongue, parting her lips; she accepted and then, after a playful moment, pressed back.

Only this time, she pressed a little harder than I was expecting. Or maybe I just remembered wrong. Maybe she'd always been like this, and I'd just forgotten. Whatever it was, it felt different, and because of that, the new overwhelmed everything else.

When I pulled at her cardigan, she stopped me. "Upstairs. It'll be more comfortable."

I nodded. Upstairs. Right. The bedroom. My heart skipped. The bedroom!

Nicole laughed, taking my hand and pulling me toward the stairs. How many times had we made this trip together in the past? How many times had things started heating up in the kitchen before we'd quickly taken the stairs? Not enough. No where close to enough.

And it had never felt so charged as now. My teeth practically chattered as I followed her up the stairs, watching her ass, tracing the toned lines of her runner's legs. This didn't feel domestic. This didn't feel like just another Saturday night.

Nicole shed her cardigan before we entered the bedroom. It smelled like the shower, fresh and clean. Nicole moved to the new dresser she'd purchased, her footsteps light across the plush, new area rug. I looked around. Everything was different here, from the bed to the paint on the walls to the photos.

"What do you think?" she asked, following my eyes to the black and whites over the headboard of the bed.

"Yours?" The images were close-ups of things I recognized once I was looking—the sign over the general store downtown, the lattice work along the old courthouse, the stone fountain in the park.

"Yeah, just playing around." She turned on some music, sensual Spanish guitars layered over a soft yet driving beat. "Most were duds, but I liked those."

"I love them."

"Thanks."

I heard the whisk of clothing. My heart raced even faster. Shyly, I looked.

Nicole had removed her shirt and had just pushed her thumbs beneath her black leggings. She'd left her bra on, black and basic, but by no means not sexy. As she bent forward to guide the leggings down her thighs, her arms pushed her breasts together, accentuating her already deep cleavage. I

couldn't not look. Judging from the way Nicole smiled, she knew what she was doing—and that made the whole thing even more sexy.

I wouldn't say that Nicole was unaware of the effect that she had on men—she was beautiful and knew it—but she'd never harnessed the full power of her sex appeal. Even with me. Even at our most intimate. In our past, I usually initiated the sex, and I could count the number of times that she'd actively seduced me on one hand.

She was actively seducing me now.

Not that she could keep it up for long. She kept a straight face until she had her leggings around her ankles, then broke into a smile. "You're looking at me like you've never seen me before."

"Well, it's been a while..."

Nicole straightened up, and while her cleavage wasn't so obvious, she still looked amazing. She'd been blessed with good genes—her hips were wide enough and her tits were full enough to give her an elongated S-shape without having to put much work into it. Apparently she was now putting work into it, and it showed.

She stepped out of her leggings and sauntered over to me. She didn't even bother exaggerating the sway in her hips. It was there, and I followed it.

"Your turn," she whispered, fingering the bottom of my shirt. "It's been awhile for me, too."

Together, we pulled off my shirt. Judging by Nicole's sharp intake of breath, she approved. Like her, I'd filled my spare time with trips to the gym. I'd joined a morning bootcamp group. I was in better shape now than I'd ever been in my life, and when Nicole ran her hand through the sparse crop of dark hair on my chest, she traced the swell and rise of my pectoral muscles.

"Well, I think I've found at least one good thing about this separation," she said. Her lips found mine again. It was just as deep and even more urgent. The feel of her soft bra and warm skin against my bare chest helped, but I wanted more.

I filled my hands with her ass cheeks, left bare by the thin thong. When I squeezed, she kissed me harder.

"This really happening?" I said between kisses.

"Only if you want it to."

"I do."

Nicole smiled. “Good. Me too.”

Then she did another thing that surprised me. When she went back to kiss me, it was along my jaw and down my neck, down my chest, down along the underside of my pecs. She sank to her knees, trailing kisses the whole way, as her hands went to work on my belt.

We weren’t strangers to oral sex, and when we’d first started dating, what Nicole didn’t have in experience she made up in enthusiasm. She’d always maintained that she loved making me happy, and a blowjob clearly made me happy. But since we got married and things settled, the blowjobs were few and far between, and when it did happen, it was just a means to get me up enough for the final act.

When Nicole freed me from my pants and wrapped her hand around my full cock, there was no getting ready needed. I was as hard as I’d been in a long time. Hard enough that I needed to be careful about finishing too quickly.

Nicole looking up at me from her knees as she tilted her head and ran her tongue along my shaft certainly didn’t help. Even back in our dating days, I don’t think it was like this. I don’t remember the eye contact—or if it was there, her blue irises hadn’t been filled with the same...need. This may have been about my pleasure, but that wasn’t the only thing. I saw it in the shortness of her breath and her slightly unfocused pupils. She was excited.

And then, when she’d slathered my cock with her tongue, she readjusted and enveloped me whole. I think I yipped. I definitely sniffed hard and fought back the intense temptation to just let go. Instead, I tore my eyes away from her and looked at the ceiling as she began to bob along my length.

It was the absence that made this feel so good, I told myself. It was time making me forget how good it had been. It was a rekindling of an old flame. She hadn’t learned anything new since we’d broken up. She certainly hadn’t practiced on another man—

“Oh, God...” I grunted. Nicole had taken me deeper than ever. I felt myself pass into her throat, however briefly, and it nearly undid me. I clenched my jaw, and somehow, didn’t come. Somehow, despite the fact that she’d *never* done that before. She’d never even tried.

She did it again, a brief, tight caress along my head with her throat. I groaned again and looked back down at her. She was still looking up at me,

her eyes playful. *You like that?* they seemed to ask.

Where did you learn that? I wanted to ask. I couldn't. Instead, I held on and tried to stave off the orgasm as Nicole did everything she could to coax it from me.

"Nicole, you need to... lay off..."

She pulled back, but continued to pump me with her hand. "I don't mind," she said.

I shook my head. I didn't, either, but I also didn't want this night to end so quickly. I reached down and pulled her up to her feet. We kissed, her lips and tongue moist and hot with what she'd been doing. I reached behind her and twisted open the clasp of her bra with one hand.

"Still got the touch," she said. She stepped back and shimmied her shoulders, freeing the bra from her body.

I loved Nicole's breasts. They were definitely on the larger side, and best of all, they were completely natural. They hung round and ripe, slightly sloped outward and capped with tiny, perfectly circular nipples.

I dipped low and took one into my mouth, unable to help myself. She sighed, wrapping a hand around around my head to pull me closer. "Definitely still have the touch," she sighed.

Together, we stumbled to the bed. Nicole fell onto her back. I was right with her, not wanting to release those hard nipples for long. She stretched out on the new mattress, her hands above her head as she let me explore her body like it was something brand new. In so many ways, it was.

It was my turn to kiss down her chest, her stomach, the indentation of her navel. Her skin was soft and warm, and I could feel her muscles working with each short breath. Lower still, I came to the band of her thong, black and unlined. I could smell her excitement and feel the heat against my lips.

She twisted above me as I kissed her mound through her panties, moaning happily. I ran my fingers along the edge of the smooth fabric, pulling it aside to uncover her pussy. I gasped. I'd expected to find the familiar blond curls of her pubic hair. Instead, there was nothing but bare skin.

I tongued the skin, half-expecting to learn that I was hallucinating. When my tongue confirmed that she was indeed wickedly smooth, I had to explore more. Grabbing her thong at the hips, I pulled them away. She lifted

her butt, helping me, but I was so focused on this new discovery that I hardly noticed.

Nicole, the sweet woman who I'd fallen in love with and married, had never done more than trim and shape her bikini line in the summer. This Nicole, in the heart of winter, was completely bare.

So many things went through my head at the same moment. It was so hot, so unfamiliar, so unlike Nicole, so inherently sexual. But the thing that I kept coming back to, the thing that turned my insides molten, was this: *who* did she do this for? For me? Or herself? Or for another man...

That last one unleashed something inside me. I dove back in between her legs, exploring the smooth landscape of her pussy. And it was smooth. Fuck, was it smooth. I pressed two fingers inside of her and she gasped somewhere above me. I twisted, I fingered, I licked her clit as she shook and came in a violent convulsion. I barely gave her enough time to recover before I went back in, unable to get enough of her new look.

"Ethan, oh, Ethan," she moaned, squeezing my head between her thighs as another orgasm built on the heels of the first.

I thought of the thong, the workouts, her bald pussy, and it got me thinking of other things—again. She was a different person, more self-assured, more self-aware. She handled herself with more confidence than ever before, and I began to realize that the way she'd moved through the crowd at the Green Leaf was no aberration.

Why?

Or better yet, who?

The question should have crippled me. Part of me was. Part of me hated the idea that she'd done something for another man that she'd never entertained in seven years together with me. Part of me was green with jealousy and red with anger.

And all of that just made me want her more—to prove myself, to compete, to reclaim. Whoever he was, I was better. Whatever he did to her, I did better.

I had an advantage, too. I *did* know her better than my imagined rival. I wasn't her first lover, but I was the one that she'd blossomed with. We'd explored. We'd learned how one another ticked. So maybe after several years of just that, things got boring. I just figured that's how marriage went. But I still had the inside track to what turned Nicole on, and I pulled out all the stops.

I pressed two fingers inside of her, twisting them with each thrust. When I found her g-spot, I timed each rub with a flick of my tongue across her clit. Thirty seconds of that and she was ready to go...so I backed off. She whined above me, contorting her body to press her pussy into my face.

The more she pushed, the more I teased. I skirted her clit, exploring the strange, smooth mound. If she'd shaved, then she must have *just* shaved.

"Please, Ethan..." she begged.

I looked up at her. Her eyes were closed, her mouth open as she panted. She was tracing her nipples with her thumbs—another thing that was new, and made even sexier because it was.

"Please make me come."

I would have anyway. The plea in her voice made me pull out all the stops. I fingered her again, this time adding a third to the mix. She rose up off the bed even before my tongue joined the fray. When it did, flicking the exposed and slippery bead that was the nexus of her everything, she screamed.

At least, I think she did. Her thighs clamped down around my head, cutting off sound. Cutting off air. I kept licking and fingering, riding the storm and hoping that I wouldn't pass out. I saw stars. I kept going, pushing her as she bucked up into me. The stars closed in. Panic laced through me. I started to pull away when she was suddenly pushing me away.

"Too much. Too much," she groaned through the mess of pants and gasps. Her body was coated in sweat. Her golden hair clumped and beautiful.

"Oh... my God..." she sighed, bonelessly flopping onto the mattress.

I crawled up her body, kissing her as I went. Each time my lips touched her skin, she shivered.

"Was it always that good?" she said. Her throat sounded raw.

"I like to think so."

She laughed. "You seemed particularly...enthusiastic. See something you liked?"

I touched her bare mound. I almost asked why she'd shaved it. I couldn't ask for whom. "I definitely saw something I liked. It's very sexy."

"It felt amazing, too." She'd been looking at the ceiling, but then she turned to look at me. "Want to take it for a ride?"

I was definitely hard enough. We kissed again as I climbed over her. She curled her hands over my biceps and lifted a leg over my back and I placed my cock against her pussy. She was so wet, and so smooth, and despite all that, when I sank into her, she was familiar.

Home. I was home.

“Uh, yes, Ethan,” she sighed.

“You’re so wet.”

“Kind of your fault.”

I stroked her, long and slow at first. She was tight, but wet enough that she’d adjusted after a couple gentle thrusts. Should she have been tighter? It had been over a year since we’d had sex. Or did she have someone working out this part of her body, too?

I did my best to quiet those mutinous thoughts. They had no place in our bed and in this moment. This was about where the past met the present, and everything was sexy again.

“Turn over,” she said. “I want to be on top.”

I obliged, and together we rolled. As much as I loved the control of missionary position, when you’ve got a wife as sexy as Nicole, having her ride you is a sight that never got old. Or shouldn’t have, even though it did. She tossed her blond hair and straddled me, feeding my cock back into her. I watched it sink into her shaved sex, the sight alone enough to almost set me off.

I looked up at her, meeting her eyes. She smiled down at me. I smiled back. The lamp light hit her hair in such a way that I thought of the sun. I almost said it aloud, something cheesy about how she really was the sun. I managed to hold my tongue. I wasn’t that drunk anymore.

“I’m glad you came over,” she said.

“Me too. You’re a very gracious host.”

Nicole rolled her eyes. “You know I don’t do this for all my guests, right?”

Something about that statement—not *all* my guests—implied that she did it for some. Or maybe I was just reading too much into it.

Then she added, “Sometimes we drink wine instead of beer to kick things off.”

I laughed, but beneath the surface, the joke cut deep. To mask it, I reached up and pulled her down to me for another kiss. This time, when our mouths met and opened, I couldn’t shake the doubt that crept in—the idea

of her doing this with another man. Did her hips move differently than before? Was each undulation always that forceful, or was that how her square-jawed doctor friend liked to get fucked?

My balls tightened, and this time, there was no way to hold back. I'd denied myself one too many times. I'd been on the brink for far too long. One minute, she was rippling over me; the next, my body seized up. I thrust up, burying myself as deep as I could go—but could he go deeper?—and exploded before I could even get a shout out. The shout did come, though, a moment later, warlike and frightened and agonizing and ecstatic all at once.

I'm not sure if she joined me. I think she did, quietly, her face contorting as she bowed over me and rested her forehead against my own. "Yes," she hissed. "Come, baby."

Come, baby. Words she'd never used with me. Words she used with her lover?

When the moment subsided, so did my paranoia. So did everything. The house. The room. The new bed. The fact that I'd been gone for so long. The fact that we were separated and all of this was separated. As I sank into Nicole's new mattress and she arranged her soft, sweaty self over me, I forgot that this was all just a waking dream. I pretended that we were together again.

"That was nice," she said. Thinking the same thing I did?

"Yeah..." I knew there was more to that statement, but I couldn't put it into words, so I repeated it. "Yeah."

We cuddled for a couple minutes—long enough that I began to wonder if Nicole had fallen asleep and I began to think about the logistics of getting home. I had a flight in the morning, and all of my things were still at the hotel.

Nicole stirred, as though realizing where this was headed. She sat up and turned to look down at me. Her hair fell around her face, stopping just below her chin. So much shorter than my memory of it. She said, "Next time, give me some advanced notice before you come. I don't mind spontaneity, but you know...planning isn't bad, either."

She didn't mind spontaneity?

"I should have called first."

Nicole shrugged. She climbed out of bed and padded over to her dresser, still naked. There was no shame or embarrassment. "A text is fine, too. Doesn't need to be a whole thing."

Was my wife—ex-wife—telling me it was okay to make a booty call?

Out of the dresser, she pulled out a new thong, this one white and lacier than the last. I watched as she stepped into it, mesmerized. Even though I'd just seen them, just filled my hands with them, the peek at the swells of her breasts around the side of her slim torso had me getting excited again.

"It's late," she said, "and you know how long it takes to get a cab out here. I can drive you back to your hotel."

I stopped ogling her before she noticed. Right, she'd drive me. It was the nicest way I've ever been kicked out of a girl's bed. I slipped out of bed and grabbed my pants, pulling them on. "I can Uber. It's fine."

Nicole pulled her t-shirt on without bothering with a bra. Her full tits looked ripe and tempting as they pressed the shirt out. Must. Keep. Eyes. On. Face.

"Stop being all macho. It's fine. Really."

I knew that look. It was straight out of the past. It was her, *Stop being an asshole* look. It was her stubborn streak that always surprised me whenever it bubbled up. When we'd been together, it had annoyed me. Now, it made me sad.

"Thanks. A ride would be great."

It wasn't great, of course, but it was better than awkwardly waiting around my old home for a taxi or an Uber car to arrive. On the ride back into town, we talked about the campaign and my plans for returning. Now that it was the new year, I'd be back more frequently. There were the primaries to contend with—and a strong, grassroots challenger for the Congressman's party—and after that, the general election.

"It suits you, you know?" Nicole said.

"What's that?"

"Politics, I mean. It suits you."

I laughed softly. My throat was still raw from the sex. "Is that a back-handed compliment?"

"What?" She thought about what she'd said, then laughed herself, heartier than me. "Oh, no, I didn't mean it like that! I just meant...you seem happy. You like what you do."

"I like what it stands for, anyway." Just that so many of my colleagues didn't feel the same, I didn't add. "It's a good experience, seeing how it works."

“Good contacts, too, yeah? K Street next?” The smile suggested that she was teasing again, but I saw the truth that she wanted to keep hidden. She thought that it was inevitable that I’d join a lobbyist firm, and she didn’t approve.

“You really think I’d sell out like that?”

She stopped the car. I realized that we’d arrived at the Hilton—by far the nicest hotel in downtown Hempstead. Her smile grew thoughtful. “I think it’s 50/50. You’re getting to a crossroads, Ethan. I’m curious how it goes.”

It was a statement free of judgement, like watching a lion stalk a gazelle. She didn’t begrudge the lion. She didn’t fear for the gazelle. What happened next would happen.

“Thanks for the lift,” I said, shaking that off. “And...the rest of the night.”

I could tell that Nicole flushed, even in the darkness of the car. It made me feel like I still knew her, even though I was learning how little I did. “Thanks for coming by. We should do it again.”

I thought about leaning over and kissing her, but for some reason that struck me as really awkward. “We should,” I said instead, then got out of the car.

“Have a safe flight home,” she shouted. Then off she was, into the night. Once upon a time, she would have asked me to let her know when I arrived. We weren’t in that place anymore. We were in a much stranger one.

We should do it again. I scratched the back of my neck, considered the offer, then laughed out loud. It could have been a lot worse.

suspitions

Back in DC, alone in my small apartment, the doubts were back. I didn't need to have an unlikely conversation with my cab driver to be reminded that maybe, just maybe, Nicole wasn't telling the whole truth about her post-separation life. There was just too much that I couldn't reconcile.

Over the nights and days that followed, I catalogued those changes, over and over. There were the big things, of course, like the way she deep-throated me and shaved her pussy, to the much smaller ones, like her new haircut, the jogging routine, the fact that she owned at least two thongs when before she had none. But most of all, it was her confidence that felt so new.

Then again, who was I to judge what she did, or who she was anymore? The separation may have been mutual, it may have been for the best, but in the end, it had been me who'd left. She didn't owe me anything. If anything, I should have been happy for her and her newfound assertiveness. She'd grown, whereas I'd...just put my life on hold.

I seemed to swing between these two states: the jealous ex and the more altruistic one. I liked to think that I was the latter, but too often, I fell into the trap of the former.

Like when I finally did look through her Facebook feed and friends, searching for the man who could have unlocked her newer side. My more selfless state pondered why it had to be some guy who was behind it; why couldn't it be just the virtue of being on her own once again?

I had an answer to that, but I didn't like it. Why did it have to be some guy? Because that self-pitying side of me wanted there to be another guy. I wasn't proud of it, and I certainly didn't understand it, but as I scrolled through her friends, clicking on every guy that I didn't recognize, I found myself growing...aroused?

No, that wasn't quite right. It was more complicated than that. I was jealous, guilty because I was jealous, upset that she'd lied, happy that she was happy, and turned on because...because why?

Her Facebook feed was inconclusive. There was nothing incriminating in her photos, her posts, her friends. I found a few guys who could have fit the square-jawed M.D. persona I'd crafted—one even was a square-jawed

M.D. at the hospital where she worked—but other than the friend connection, there was nothing. She didn't comment on any of their posts, and they didn't on hers. There wasn't so much as a Like.

I considered checking the dating sites, but even for me in my state, that was taking things too far. I didn't get beyond the signup screens. I was being paranoid over a thing I shouldn't care about, anyway.

What I did do, though, was call up Michael. Or rather, he called me, and once we were talking, I couldn't help myself.

"Hey, man, you never came back after going over to Nick's. Happy reunion, I take it?"

I thought it was weird to talk on the phone with anyone these days, but Michael had never been a texter. "That's none of your business."

Michael laughed. "So that mean you're back together?"

It made me smile, hearing the hope in the question. I didn't want to mislead him, though. "Not exactly. I think I'm just a booty call right now."

"Lucky mother fucker. It's a new world, I guess. When my folks split up, they couldn't go five minutes without throwing shit at each other."

"Hey, Michael?" My heart starting racing as I worked up the nerve to ask this next thing.

"Ooh, my name. Must be serious. You dying?"

This asshole couldn't take anything seriously. I soldiered on, ignoring him. "Is she seeing anyone else?"

"Not that I'm aware of."

Did he hesitate before answering? Or did I just imagine that. "You'd tell me if she was?"

"I'll do better, if you'd like. I can investigate it a little for you. Truth is, I don't see her all that much. She works a lot, and we both have weird schedules, you know?"

My heart fluttered faster. "So it's possible?"

"Guess so. But I don't think it's serious, else I'd have seen a car outside her place." He chuckled. "Maybe you're not her only booty call."

Worst thing he could have said.

"Thanks, asshole."

"No problem, fucker. Call me when you're coming back into town."

third visit

Once the campaign headquarters had been fully set up and staffed a month later, I was back in Hempstead. I wavered between announcing my visit and staying incognito. Incognito had a lot of merits: I could sneak around, follow her from work, see if she met up with anyone, and be a general stalkerish creep.

I ended up texting her once I realized that none of the merits were actually merits at all.

[Me]: In town for just a night, next Friday. You free?

I felt skeezy just typing that, but I hit send anyway. I wasn't the type who made booty calls. Then again, I didn't think my wife was the type who accepted them.

When she texted back with a:

[Nicole]: Bummer! I'm not free that night. :(

...my head immediately jumped to all kinds of sordid reasons why she wasn't free. I almost asked her what she was doing before I caught myself. The last thing I needed was for her to think I was a jealous ex. No, I was the cool ex who had casual sex with her.

I sighed.

[Me]: Next time then.

All she sent back was a smiley face.

Now, of course I jumped right to the conclusion that she had a date Friday night. It was Friday night, after all, and if it were anything else—say drinks with a girlfriend, or happy hour with coworkers—it wouldn't preclude a late night booty call. No, for her to be busy meant she was doing something that went into the night, and that *had* to mean another guy.

Right?

Thing was, none of this jived with the Nicole I'd married, and as much as I knew that she'd started to change, I also knew that no one really changes. Not this much. Nicole was a serial monogamist. She'd had a couple long-term boyfriends before me, but had never dated around. She'd never had a one-night stand. She'd never had a fuck buddy.

Yes, I acknowledged that I was evidence that things were different, but even I could be explained away. We'd been married. Technically, we still *were* married. Fooling around when I was in town was kind of an extension of what once was.

But it also meant that it was hard to believe that she had another guy back home. For that to be true, it meant that she'd become a lot more casual about sex and relationships, and once again, I couldn't reconcile that.

Only, she had plans Friday night, and I couldn't come up with any better explanation for what that could mean...

*

Downtown Hempstead wasn't much. Quaint was definitely a word for it, although it had grown up in the last year, as the recession lifted. Most of the storefronts along Main Avenue were occupied now, some of them having turned over since I'd started working in Washington, DC. It had been written up in the *Seattle Times* as *the* place to live if you wanted the convenience of having a large city close by, but wanted the niceties of a smaller town. Ever since then, people had started moving in, and things were looking prosperous.

The Congressman had leased out one of the storefronts for his campaign office. It was a nice, short walk from the Hilton, and was close enough to the few bars and restaurants that the town had to offer. I landed early Friday, left my things in my hotel room, and went right to the campaign office.

This was my third trip back to Hempstead in the last few months, and for the first time, I realized that I was just a visitor here now. I sat on a couch near the front of the office, going through all the strategic documents that the campaign manager had provided. It was a sunny day in Washington State, and it filled the front of the office with hazy light.

I found myself watching the people pass by outside, more than read the papers. I didn't recognize very many, although I kept expecting that I would. It wasn't like Hempstead had ever been small, but now it felt big. Or *bigger*, anyway.

Every now and again, I'd spot a flash of blond hair pass by the window, and every time I did, my heart would jump and I'd look up, looking for Nicole. There were even a couple times when I'd look up to see

the blonde holding a man's hand, only for me to realize that she wasn't my wife after all.

Nicole was on my mind, of course. She'd been on my mind since I'd texted her and received a rejection. Or a postponement. Or whatever.

"Jet-lagged?" Mitch said, taking a seat at my side.

Mitch Saffer was the Congressman's campaign manager, and a nice enough guy. If anyone was headed for K Street, this was the guy. Guiltily, I found that all the more reason to get on his good side. I didn't want to be a lobbyist, but I also didn't want to shut off my options.

He'd asked me a question. Right. "Not really. Do I look tired?"

"You look distracted."

"It's just strange being back here."

I recognized the look that passed across Mitch's face, the kind of wariness reserved for someone who'd revealed himself as unreliable. It was the last thing that I wanted.

"Probably jet-lagged, too," I added.

"This hopping back and forth between coasts is rough," Mitch sympathized. "We're going to go out and grab a couple drinks tonight. Was going to invite you, but if you're jet-lagged..."

There was no way I could *not* go. This was as much a test of my fortitude and capabilities as any. "Sounds good. A little coffee and I'll be fine."

"You're from around here. Recommendations?"

There were only a couple bars downtown, both of them Irish pubs, plus a handful of restaurants that had bars in them—spots where dates could move from dinner to drinks and on and on into the late hours. Especially on a Friday night. Places like—

"The Green Leaf's got a great drink menu," I said before I could help myself.

I tried to tell myself that I wasn't thinking about sitting at the bar as Nicole strolled in with her date. I tried all afternoon long, somehow getting a grasp of the campaign strategy enough to speak intelligently enough about it at the end of the day.

And then we were on the way for drinks at the restaurant that had once been a favorite of Nicole and me.

Talk about being distracted. The Green Leaf was busy by the time we got there in the second half of the dinner hour. The guys headed to the bar

as I lagged a couple steps behind, scanning the bustling restaurant portion of the Leaf. Like my people-watching of the afternoon, my heart would skip each time my gaze passed over a blond woman. She wasn't here, and that left me confusingly disappointed.

I shifted to the group at the bar, seeing them—*us*—for what we were: a bunch of slick, beltway suits invading this quaint town in the Pacific Northwest. It made me feel oily by association, and self-conscious when I joined them.

But I joined them, because that's who I was now.

"So you're from here," one of the campaign guys said. With the exception of Mitch, they were all younger than me. "I can see why you left."

"Nah, not from here, but I did live here for a few years." I hated myself for saying it that way, for copping out of defending a place that had given me so many good memories. I hated that I had to come off as cool to these guys. "But it's not so bad."

The guy, Tony I think his name was, said, "Why would you live all the way out here when you could live in the city?"

Okay, so while I wanted to remain cool, that was getting harder and harder. It was Mitch who spoke first. "Buddy, what the fuck are you doing?"

I blinked, confused. When I realized that he wasn't talking to me and felt the pressure come off of me, I followed his line of thinking.

Mitch leaned closer to Tony and said, "You're done. I want you to head back to the office now and clean your shit out."

"What the fuck, dude?" Tony said. He looked from me to Mitch. "I'm just fucking around, right, Ethan? I can play nice with the Congressman's lapdog."

Mitch shook his head. "You don't get it. Ethan, want to explain?"

"You're not just insulting me. You're committing a cardinal sin. You're insulting our constituents." I waved my hand to encompass the crowd. "This place has been owned by the same family for three generations. The man over there, playing the piano, has given lessons to the children of Hempstead for fifteen years. Everyone here has a story. These are the people we're trying to help."

"You mean the ones we're trying to win," Tony said.

Mitch said, "How did you get hired? Get out of here. You're fired."

“Fuck this.”

When Tony stormed off, it became clear that he’d created a scene—and that scene wasn’t confined to just the bar. Almost half the restaurant had turned in our direction, staring and quiet. I’m not sure who started it, but someone clapped, and then another, and then everyone.

Mitch nudged me with his elbow. “Anyone tell you that you may have a future in politics?”

I couldn’t help it. I burst out laughing. Call it adrenaline. Call it relief. Call it waking up after so much time fretting about everything but this campaign, I was finally able to stop, take a look around, and realize just how off-center I’d been these last few months.

“How about a drink?” I said.

And we drank. Turned out, other than Tony, the rest of Congressman Phillips’ team was a good bunch. They were young, yes, but they weren’t even all fresh out of the Beltway. Trisha had a strong grassroots background, and Emory was from down in Portland. Ken may have looked like the living version of Barbie’s soulmate, but he was actually a huge comic book nerd. Even Mitch spent his time not campaigning at home outside of St. Louis. And while they were all here to help Philips win, they also believed in the man and what he could do for this district. Understanding that—plus the alcohol—was really, *really* good for my psyche, if not my soul.

And then, of course, I got The Text.

[Nicole]: You free?

I’ve never swooned in my life, but I think I did in that moment. I clutched the table as liquid fire entered my veins and powered up my cock.

[Me]: I can be.

[Nicole]: Cool, I worked it out so I could get out of my shift a little early. Want to come over? ;)

Work. Of course she had work. I felt like a complete idiot for not considering the possibility.

[Me]: I’ll be right over.

[Nicole]: Can’t wait. xx

Kisses. Not like my wife at all, and yet, I was learning, everything like her.

“Sorry guys, East Coast time is finally catching up with me. I’m going to head out.”

“Take it easy, man,” Mitch said. “And Ethan, you did well tonight. I’m glad that we get to work with each other.”

“Night.”

And into the night I went. I didn’t even want to wait for an Uber. I took the short walk back to the hotel and jumped into one of the waiting cabs there. Looked like it would be a booty call kind of trip, after all.

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booty call

“Oh, Ethan! Oh, yes, right...right there!”

I looked down at Nicole’s naked body, slick with perspiration, sweeping out before me. She was on her knees on the bed, her head and shoulders on the mattress, wreathed in the crown of damp, golden hair.

I held her hips as I pumped her from behind, each thrust punctuated by a wet, meaty slap of skin-on-skin. We’d been at it for over an hour, moving fluidly through various positions. This was the one that was going to end me. I could feel her fingers working her clit, a knuckle occasionally brushing my balls or the slick column of my cock. Sometimes it was intentional.

I shut my eyes, fighting off the orgasm that I’d so stoically held at bay, but I was on borrowed time now. Another brush, another thrust, another sexy moan, and I was another step closer.

I’d actually arrived before Nicole had, to my surprise, and had to wait outside our front door for a couple minutes before her car pulled into the driveway. When she got out, I was surprised to see her still in her nursing scrubs. Even still, the ubiquitous teal-blue looked good on her, setting off her eyes.

“Sorry. Traffic,” she’d explained.

“I must have misplaced my key.”

She’d smiled in a way that said, *You goof*, and then showed me where she hid a spare under the flower pot. “Next time, go ahead and let yourself in. You can wait for me in the bedroom, naked.”

Her forwardness kept on surprising me. No sooner had we entered the house and closed the door than we were all over each other. We stripped on the way to the bedroom. She went down on me again, this time blowing me to completion and swallowing my load.

I returned the favor, discovering that she was just as smooth shaven as ever. Had she maintained that since the last time we were together, possibly for someone else? Or did she touch it up on the possibility of this happening tonight? The latter was more likely. The former, though, got me hard again.

“Are you close?” she hissed.

I snapped back into the moment, once again behind her, once again fighting the imminent orgasm.

“Close. Yes.”

“Do it, Ethan. I want to feel it. I *need* to feel it.”

Everything stretched thin and tight, my body, my muscles, my mind. I gripped her hips tighter, forcing her hips to buck back and forth, harder and harder, humping her in a way that I wouldn’t have been comfortable in the past. She ate it up, moaning and thrashing.

“Fuck my *pussy*, Ethan. I want to feel your come in my *pussy*!”

It was too much. Too dirty. Too hot. I couldn’t hold off any longer. Not with her screaming for it.

I yelled something that could have been *oh fuck*, but was lost in a throaty moan that caught me by surprise. I slammed one last time into her, burying myself as deep as I could, and erupted.

That was the trigger. Nicole pressed her ass up, her body tightening like a cat caught in a perpetual stretch. I saw her face through the curtain of clumping, blond hair. She was beet red, her eyes shut tight, her mouth hung open as she stuttered through her cries and pleasure racked her body.

We collapsed into a heap of gasping flesh. The sheets around us were soaked, as if this whole experience had been some kind of crazy fever. Eventually, Nicole arranged herself over me, resting her head on my chest as I stroked her hair.

“I’ll have to thank Fiona for taking the second half of my shift,” Nicole said.

“Thank her for me, too.”

“Oh, you’d like that, wouldn’t you?”

I heard the playful accusation in her voice without understanding it. “Huh?”

She reached down and stroked my flaccid cock. “Don’t tell me you don’t remember Fiona Banfield. Tall, big-breasted redhead?”

I didn’t until she said it, and then of course I did. Fiona was *the* hot nurse, although I was always partial to Nicole’s more girl-next-door beauty. Still, in the safety of my own head, I could admit that I’d thought about Fiona a time or two.

“I felt that,” Nicole said. She didn’t sound mad, which was...strange. Strange but good. Not that Nicole was ever a jealous person. “Maybe I should have sent her home instead. Would you have liked that?”

“Nicole...” Embarrassingly—and incredibly—I’d begun to harden. Three times in a couple hours was an impressive feat.

She kissed my nipple, then dropped her voice an octave. “This is Fiona, and baby, I can hear your heart beating so quickly. Is that for me?”

“It’s not like that... I don’t need—”

“Mmm, is this for me, too?”

To my utter shock, Nicole moved back down to my cock, still coated in the ruin of our sex, and took the semi-erect shaft into her mouth. She’d never done that before. She’d also never pretended to be another woman doing it.

“Oh, fuck.” The words escaped before I could stop them, thin and breathy and wrought with betrayal. I wasn’t getting hard because I was thinking about Fiona. I was getting hard because Nicole had brought Fiona into this, because *Nicole* was pretending to be her hot, red-headed coworker, and without any prompting from me.

Nicole looked up, her face somehow sultrier. When she spoke, she still affected the deeper, Fiona-voice. “You have a nice, big cock, Ethan. Nicole never told me what a nice *cock* you had.”

I stared down at her, where she rested casually between my splayed legs. Her hair hung over her face, but I could still see her eyes on me, staring at me like a lioness in tall grass. She stroked me back to full length, running her tongue along the crown, before diving back down.

I’d already come twice. A third orgasm was far away. Or so I’d thought until she’d begun the third act.

“You like my tits?” she said. “You like my big, soft tits?”

“Nicole...”

“It’s Fiona, silly. Nicole’s being a good girl back at the hospital. Right now, you’re with the naughty nurse.” She reached out and took my hand. “Come on, go ahead and touch them.”

She placed my hand on her right breast, I touched. I squeezed. I pinched her nipple as she returned to sucking my cock. I didn’t see my wife between my legs, enthusiastically sucking my cock. I didn’t see Fiona, either. I saw the new Nicole, the reforged Nicole who used words like *tits* and *cock* and was open to booty calls.

Thank goodness I’d already come twice. I wouldn’t have lasted more than a minute of this, between the slick sensation of her mouth and the wild thoughts running through my head.

“You want to fuck them?” the sultry temptress between my legs asked. I blinked, following what she was asking but refusing to believe it.

She took my cock and placed it between her tits. “You like the way it feels there, don’t you?”

I did. It was soft and warm and so amazingly wrong. Despite having large breasts, we’d never done this. I didn’t even think the possibility had occurred to Nicole, and I’d been too scared to bring it up.

She put her weight on an elbow and used her other arm to squeeze her tits around me, holding them tight with her forearm.

“Mmm, you’re so hard,” Nicole said. “Go ahead and fuck them. Fuck my big, soft tits.”

I lifted my hips off the bed without consciously choosing to. I just went with it, thrusting in and out of the deep valley. Nicole shifted so that she could hold both breasts in her hands and squeeze. The visual was almost as good as the sensation. The look on Nicole’s face, bright and delighted as she watched my shaft slide through her cleavage, was one I locked away for later. She was into it as much as I was, and that, right there, was the hottest part of this.

“You’ve thought about doing this, haven’t you?” she asked, glancing up at me.

I nodded, not trusting my voice.

She smiled—seemed like she couldn’t stop smiling. She bent down and licked my cockhead as I thrust up. I shuddered, so lost in the moment that I almost missed what she said next.

“Dr. Mann loves them, too.”

I felt like I’d been dunked into a bottomless well of ice-cold water and was being dragged down and down and down. My vision narrowed to that pin-point of light at the top of the well, so impossibly far away. Dr. Mann? Who the hell was Dr. Mann, who loved my wife’s tits, too?

And then I was racing to the surface, so fast that my ears popped and I had to shut my eyes because the light was too bright.

For a split second, I saw an examination room, the kind that smelled like disinfectant and had a table covered in paper that crinkled. A man was leaning on that examination table, his white doctor’s coat open and his pants down around his ankles. Nicole was on her knees, topless, but still in her teal-blue pants, with her tits wrapped around the man’s large cock. *Fuck them. Fuck my big, soft tits.*

“Oh my—” I choked on the violence of my orgasm. The vision vanished, replaced by the much more real one of Nicole, erotically worn from all the sex, with her breasts wrapped around my shaft and her mouth enveloping the head, sucking my come as quickly as it burst forth.

I was in a daze, well after I’d finished emptying my balls—this time they were truly empty—and she’d crawled back into a cuddling position. Dr. Mann. Was that the mystery man? And why did my cock twitch at the possibility that there was one?

“So glad Nicole let me borrow you,” Nicole said. “But I’m going to have to come back some time to feel that thing inside of me.”

“Nicole...”

She blinked, dropping the act, but not the amused smile. “Yes, Ethan?”

“Who is Dr. Mann?”

Did I imagine the look of...something that flickered across her face? When she spoke, she didn’t sound defensive or strange, but was she being a little too casual. “Oh, just the resident heart throb. It’s the Pacific Northwest. Every hospital needs a Dr. McDreamy.”

“So does that make you Meredith Grey?” And then, because this was getting weird and I reach for humor when I get nervous, I added, “You always struck me more as an Izzy.”

“All blondes look alike? I hardly have those curves.”

I felt the Dr. Mann thread slipping away, but was too scared to bring it back. So I said another thing that had been on my mind for a while.

“You seem...different. More confident.” I forced a laugh. “You have anything you want to tell me?”

I hoped my faked casualness implied that we were just two married people having a regular conversation about nothing special. She could tell me anything. No big deal.

Only it was a big deal, and I dreaded what came next.

Honey, I’ve been fucking Dr. Mann since the second you walked out.

Honey, I discovered this great sex club out in Hattiesburg and it’s totally opened my eyes.

Honey, I’ve always felt that you held me back, and now, I’m free...

I realized that she was talking—had *been* talking—as I lashed myself with imagined responses. “...guess I’d always been defined by the man that I was with at the time. Not in a bad way. Just...a way. Like when we were together, you opened my eyes to politics and optimism and this idealistic

sense of civic duty, and that's amazing. But we moved to Hempstead together, and that's how we existed here, and..." She brushed her hand through her hair where it had gotten into her face, and laughed. "I'm rambling."

"You're beautiful."

She glanced up at me, and something in the way she lifted her brow made me think I'd said the wrong thing. I saw her make a mental note before moving past it.

"Anyway, like I said, it's not any one thing. It's all of it, though. I think that for the first time, I'm discovering who I am—the adult me, I mean. I haven't been single for longer than a month since I was sixteen, if you can believe that."

"I think it's good," I said. Something stuck in my mind, though. Something she'd said. But I couldn't parse it out, and right now, I needed to be more in the moment. "As long as we keep having nights like this, who am I to complain?"

Nicole rolled her eyes playfully. "Such a man thing to say." She climbed off of me, cuddle time over. "Come on, let's go find your clothes. I'll drive you home."

I'd half-expected that I was going to spend the night. Was even looking forward to it. Apparently that was a line in the sand for Nicole, and it was one that I could respect. This was no longer my home, and she was no longer my wife, whether the papers said so or not.

It was only when I was back in my hotel room, alone and unable to sleep, that I was able to think through the night. The Fiona roleplay was hot, and the titfuck she'd given me even hotter, but it was something she'd said after that kept the buzz going.

It's not any one thing. It's all of it.

But what were those things? Being single. Living on her own. Being free to pursue her own interests. To pursue...Dr. Mann?

It was a long night.

Dr. McDreamy

I had a name. Or a last name, anyway. Dr. Mann. He should have been easy enough to find on the hospital website, if the hospital website wasn't so terrible. The place that I did find him was, naturally, Facebook. Turned out that square-jawed M.D. who was friends with Nicole was none other than a Mason Mann.

They still showed no interactions with one another, but that didn't mean anything, especially if they saw one another frequently at the hospital. Or maybe they just used Facebook Messenger. Or text. Or Snapchat. If they were being discrete, there was no reason to do anything on Facebook beyond be friends.

If they were being discrete.

So much meaning was packed into that thought. There was the uncertainty that anything was happening, of course. She'd never said that there was, and she'd been pretending to be Fiona when she'd brought the name up. Maybe Mason Mann and Fiona were getting it on.

The thought also implied something secret, a liaison that she didn't talk about openly and would maybe even lie about.

She'd been with someone since she was sixteen, and even then, I knew she only had a handful of boyfriends. When we got married, that was supposed to be it. The end. No more fish in the sea. To suddenly be released from all of that and left alone...

I didn't begrudge her, and it would be hypocritical if I did. I'd played some, after all. I'd been with Cate when Nicole and I had first reconnected, and there had been a couple other one-night stands before that.

Thing was, if I was really honest with myself—something that took a couple bottles of strong IPA in the quiet of my DC apartment—I *did* begrudge her. She could have waited. She should have. We'd be back together one day, and this whole separation thing would be just a blip on our otherwise perfect, married life.

"You're such an asshole," I told myself. Then finished my beer.

I was. Worse, I was an optimistic asshole. We weren't getting back together. If I hadn't shown up last year, we could have gone the rest of our lives without seeing one another again. The divorce papers would have been

handled by mail. The lawyers would have split everything up. And we'd go on our way, separately.

I saw the future stretched out before me, and it was crushing. I didn't want that. I didn't want to lose my wife. And as I looked at the photo of Mason Mann and his too good looks, I wondered if maybe, I already had.

So I had a rival. Even his name—*Mason Mann*—sounded like a worthy man to hate. That was something I could work with, although I needed to keep myself from going creepy. There were some lines I wasn't going to cross. One of them was this: anything I did, I'd need to be comfortable telling Nicole at some point. So while I may have harbored some deeply buried and shameful urge to stalk this guy next time I flew out there, I wouldn't.

But I had Facebook, and all of that was free information, right?

Appearance-wise, he didn't look exactly as I'd imagined, even though he was a doctor and he was, indeed, square-jawed. Firstly, his head was shaved—not skinhead shaved, but shaved in a distinguished, doctory way. He had gray eyes and smile lines around his face, and—at least according to his Facebook profile image—he had a short, scruffy goatee. Facebook didn't provide a year for his birthday, but judging from that photo and the date of his graduation from medical school, I put him in his mid-thirties.

One thing that Facebook did uncover was that he was single and currently unattached. Looking down his life events, he'd never been married, had no children, and had moved to Hempstead just a year before.

I sifted through his photos—again, trying not to get too creepy, but mostly to get a feel for who this guy was. He was well traveled, particularly in what looked like places in Hawaii and California. Some images of him surfing—yes, I looked, and yes, he was pretty fit. Some featured him with someone who could have been a girlfriend, but the woman was different in every setting.

His most recent trip was somewhere snowy, and while there were a couple photos of Mason on skis, most of them were of food wherever he was. And no woman was pictured with him, although clearly he hadn't gone alone.

That pricked a discordant note in me. It was far-fetched, of course, but what if the man had taken Nicole wherever this was? For a moment, the possibility felt so real that I switched over to her Facebook page and scrolled through her posts and pictures during the same time. What I found

was inconclusive—she'd reposted a few things, including a positive political article about Congressman Phillips, which made me feel good, but made no mention of skiing or going out of town.

Still...

I guess that's the problem with paranoia. It's insidious, and has the uncanny ability of turning the most innocuous things into examples of betrayal. I'd read one of his posts where he'd mention looking forward to the summer when he could take his sailboat out, and immediately think about Nicole sunning in a bikini as he brought a drink to her. I'd scroll past a post that simply said, *What a night!* And be filled with the image of his naked body tangled with Nicole's.

I closed Facebook before I went crazy.

I did my best to keep my mind off of Dr. Mason Mann and his relationship with Nicole. After all, there probably was no relationship at all beyond a professional one. She'd called him *Dr. Mann* when mentioning his name, not *Mason*. Right?

Yeah, I didn't believe myself, either.

Things may have been easier if I'd had some kind of contact with Nicole between visits. Instead, I had none. Weeks would go by without any contact, and then, I'd need to fly out to talk to Mitch and the team and would need to make the awkward decision to text her or not.

Because it was awkward, right? Texting my wife for the sole and express reason to have casual sex with her. Not that it was awkward in the moment, when I'd taken a cab or an UBER over to her house and we quickly fell into bed. Even the post-sex stuff, when we'd just lie in bed naked and talk, could almost feel like we'd lapsed into our old lives. No, the most awkward part was all the stuff leading up to that initial text.

I took two other trips to Hempstead before the March 26 Democratic primary, and both times, I'd ended up sending the text, and neither time did I regret it. Nicole was amazing, alive and fun and borderline dirty. She didn't take me between her breasts, but she did suck me back to life for a round two both times, and seemed to have no problem kissing me after I went down on her.

But we never talked about these things afterwards—never deeply, anyway. She'd take me home before things could get serious enough for that, and once I was home, we didn't talk until the next visit. I even offered to take her out to dinner the next time I was back, during the primaries,

when I'd be in town for longer than a couple of nights. She'd demurred with a *maybe*.

I wasn't completely clueless, and I had the advantage of knowing Nicole pretty well. While she was fine keeping things mostly physical with me, she was incredibly wary of anything more. This seemed natural due to our history, but of course, I wanted to blame Mason Mann.

So I did.

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the Tap Room

We flew in a week ahead of the March 26 primaries, although Mitch had the team working the ground game well ahead of that date. The Congressman had already made a number of appearances in the district—once with me, a few times with his other aides—but this was the final push. Polls showed him ahead of his primary challenger, but it was closer than anyone had expected.

It was cold and wet when we landed in Seattle. There was traffic clogging the highway into Hempstead County. It was nearly nine by the time we made it to the hotel—nine going on midnight according to our bodies—and yet the Congressman still gathered us at the campaign headquarters and filled us with hope and enthusiasm.

He went to bed. Mitch and the rest went out, and when they invited me along... Well, I turned them down. At first.

Then they told me where they were going. “It’s this great bar. The Tap Room. Best selection of microbrews in the area,” Emory said. “Could almost pass for a Portland bar. Almost.”

“The Tap Room. I think I know it. By the hospital?” I spoke slowly and deliberately, trying to keep my voice from doing anything funny.

“Yeah, that’s the one.”

Of course I knew it. It’s where Nicole and the hospital staff frequented—for lunches, for happy hours, to commiserate after a hard day at work. In their industry, hard days took on an entirely different and much more morbid quality. The Tap Room did well there.

It was absolutely the wrong place to go. Things had been so busy leading up to this trip that I hadn’t had the energy to fight through the shame to text Nicole for a booty call. That she’d essentially turned me down when I’d asked her on a date played partly into that. Regardless, she didn’t know I was here, so walking into her bar unannounced could come off as awkward at best, and stalkerish at worst.

Bumping into Nicole wasn’t the only possibility. Dr. Mason Mann probably frequented the place. Hell, I knew he did based on a few photos I’d seen on his feed. What would I do if he was there? Worse, what if he was there with Nicole along with him?

“Sure, I’m in.” I wasn’t sure what part of me answered like that, but it sure as hell wasn’t a rational one.

*

The Tap Room was actually a ten-minute drive from the town center, connected to the end of a strip mall near the hospital. Like its name suggested, it served mostly beer, including a few that it brewed itself right in the building. The stainless steel casks as tall as two men standing head to toe acted as a backdrop behind the bar.

An acoustic guitar duet played covers of indie rock songs from a small stage, covering the shrill sirens of the occasional passing ambulance.

The rain had only picked up, but that didn’t seem to faze these people. What was a little rain in a Seattle suburb? I was the only one with an umbrella, I noticed. Even the campaign staff had assimilated to the rain slickers, hoods drawn. I stuck out as the outsider, an irony that wasn’t lost on me. As soon as I walked in, I was immediately noticed.

This wouldn’t have been too bad if Nicole hadn’t been one of those patrons to turn away from her conversation to see the newcomers enter.

Our eyes met from across the way. She blinked, as if trying to decide if I was actually here as I did the same. She wasn’t dressed in scrubs, but street clothes—a loose sweater, skintight jeans, and flats. She also wasn’t with Dr. Mann. I felt relief at that, but also mild disappointment.

She wasn’t alone, though. At her side was Fiona, the redheaded nurse that she’d pretended to be a couple months back. Nicole followed my eyes to her friend, turned back to me, and rolled her eyes. At least she was smiling.

“Hey, Ethan! Over here!” I snapped out of my trance. Mitch was calling.

Nicole tipped her head in their direction. *Better go attend to that*, she seemed to say. And, *have a nice night*. Then, as if we’d had an entire conversation over the distance and were now done, she turned her attention back to Fiona.

I didn’t know what to do, so I went and joined Mitch and the gang.

“So is Phillips always like that?” Trish asked once the server has come by and taken our order.

“Like what?”

“I don’t know... so...”

“Charismatic,” Ken offered.

“Yes!” Trish said. “Like, he talks, and I just want to do whatever he says, you know?”

“Captain America right there,” Ken agreed. It was always funny to be reminded that this generically handsome man was a comic book aficionado.

I said, “Yeah, he’s like that a lot. He’s one of the reasons I went out to DC. Some guys are real leaders.”

“What’s implied there,” Emory said, “is that many aren’t.”

I laughed. It was funny being seen as the senior guy from Washington, even though I was one of the most junior back there. “I’d say most aren’t.”

“And I’d agree,” Mitch said. He raised his glass. “So let’s toast. To the real leaders.”

“To the real leaders,” we said in unison.

I chanced a look toward Nicole. She continued to operate like she didn’t know me, so I followed suit. We could be strangers here. It was only fair to her, since this was her turf, whether I was welcomed or not.

I did get a text after we’d been there long enough that I was halfway through my beer.

[Nicole]: Want me to send Fiona over? :p

I shot a look at the table where the two nurses were sitting, but Nicole wasn’t looking toward me. She was listening to whatever Fiona was saying intently. As if feeling my eyes on her, she brushed a strand of hair over her ear and turned slightly in my direction—enough to spot me out of the corner of her eye. A smile formed, but that was it. Her hair fell back into place as the smile was hidden once again.

“Yeah, man, they’re hot.” It was Ken, who’d followed my eyes to Fiona and Nicole. “They’re nurses at the hospital.”

I froze up. Should I tell him that Nicole was my wife? Probably, but with that came a slew of awkward questions: *why didn’t you go over there when we first arrived? why haven’t you ever talked about a wife? I thought you lived in DC?*

I took the easy route. I played ignorant. “Oh yeah?”

“I know what you’re thinking,” he said.

No, you really don’t, I thought.

“Kind of generic that the two hottest women here are nurses. But actually this place is mostly people who work at the hospital. And they’re all good people. We come here a lot.”

“Ken may or may not have made a pass at one, or maybe both, of them at one point or another,” Emory said.

“Any luck?” Even as I asked it, the question felt fragile.

“Thought so with the blonde before I realized that she was just letting me down easier. The redhead...” He chuckled. “Ball buster. Would not recommend.”

Emory interjected. “Bet she’s great in the sack.”

“I bet they both are,” said Ken.

This conversation seemed to be slowly turning my insides to liquid. I should have walked away, joined Mitch and Trisha and the rest in their campaign talk. But I couldn’t help myself.

“Even the blonde? She’s pretty, but kind of sweet, you know?”

“Oh, I’m sure she’s those things,” Ken said. “But that one knows what she wants. We’ve watched dozens of guys hit on her. She turns almost all of them away, but not before playing with them a little. Even me, I’m afraid. There’s something about the way she carries herself that suggests a really good time.”

Emory said, “Ken’s got a little crush.”

“You do, too.”

“At least I know when I’m batting out of my league.”

I didn’t hear their banter. All I heard was one of the last things Ken had said. *She turns almost all of them away. Almost.* As in, some of them she doesn’t turn away.

“So who are the lucky guys that she keeps?” I blurted, breaking up their brotherly spat.

“Oh, the blonde?” Ken said. “I can’t remember. I don’t really pay attention to the dudes.”

I pushed, knowing that I was in danger of sounding a little crazed. “Were any of them bald?”

Ken shook his head. “Sorry man, I don’t remember.”

I looked to Emory, who shrugged. How could they not remember if a man was bald or not? It was a pretty obvious distinguishing feature.

“Oh, look, here we go,” Ken said.

I looked to see where we were going. Turned out, it was a pair of guys, young professionals and looking too good for their own sake, approaching the table where Nicole and Fiona sat.

“No chance,” Emory said.

“I don’t know, it’s possible,” Ken said, probably because these guys looked more like him than Emory, and he needed a little ego boost.

I watched in silence, like someone had closed his hand over my mouth and held me immobilized.

The guys were very forward. They didn’t go so far as to take seats at the girls’ table, but they did pair off immediately. The darker-hued of the two went to Nicole, actually putting a hand on the table so he could lean against it, inches from her. I thought for sure that she was going to shut this down—and if not her, then Fiona. Instead, the guy said something and Nicole laughed, and my insides melted.

“Huh,” Ken said.

I didn’t like *huh*. What did *huh* mean? “What?”

“Oh, nothing. Just...surprised is all.”

Nicole tucked a strand of escaped hair behind her ear, and turned her head just enough that she could look at me out of the corner of her eye. Oh, I see. She was doing this in spite of me for some reason. That also didn’t seem like Nicole.

It was hard, watching them get played by these guys. It was also making me hard—hard enough, anyway, that I made sure to have the high boy table in front of me at all times.

When she pulled out her phone, Ken actually whistled. “Wow, she’s taking his number already.”

She was! Watching him dictate a number to her as he stood over her, and seeing her carefully enter it into her phone was almost too much. It wasn’t hard to imagine another scene that could play out later tonight. Similar positions, only instead of a phone, she held his cock as she looked up at him with her baby blues.

I couldn’t take it. I pulled out my phone and sent her a text while she was still entering this guys digits.

[Me]: This guy? Really?

I watched as the text arrived onto her phone, and she paused to read it. She blinked, then burst out laughing.

What? the guy seemed to ask, confused yet still happy.
She just shook her head and didn't answer, instead sending me a text back.

[Nicole]: You don't approve? He's got nice, um... shoulders?

She didn't look in my direction, but she was laughing anyway.

[Nicole]: Fiona likes his friend. I'm her wing-woman tonight.

Wow, that was...interesting. I wasn't sure what that meant, honestly. I'd never operated with a wing-man of my own, although I understood the concept: to protect, to even out the numbers, to help the main pilot, or whatever, get laid. Did that mean she was getting laid, too?

[Me]: That's dedication.

And then, because that sounded a little judgmental, I added a smiley face.

[Nicole]: Could be worse.

Why did I read that and hear, *I've been with worse?*

The feeling of jealousy was so crippling that I half considering crawling under the table when no one was looking, so I could curl up and clutch my stomach. I mean, not really, but kind of really.

[Me]: Well, have fun.

She said something to the guy, waving her phone, giving him some kind of excuse as to why she was texting right in front of him. He didn't seem off-put. He had his own phone and was involved in his own chat. I wondered if he was texting his ex, who was in the same room, about the quality of Nicole. Seemed unlikely.

Fiona stood. My blood thickened. The man who'd been chatting with Fiona tossed some money on the table. Nicole rose next. My knees turned to rubber.

No. No, this wasn't good. And yet, watching this random guy put his hand on the small of my wife's back and lead her toward the door was one of the single hottest moments of my life.

Nicole glanced at me on the way to the door, as if to say, *You going to do something?*

I didn't. I couldn't. I had no right. She wasn't mine to put limits on, and if she chose to spend her night fucking some douchey guy, who was I to

tell her not to?

Then I thought of tomorrow, or the next day, or the next month, when I saw her next and wouldn't be able to not think about that guy. And how I'd have lost a little respect for her.

"I'm sorry guys, I need to go," I said abruptly. "Jet lag," I added when everyone looked confused.

They seemed to accept that, going back to the business of drinking.

I had no plans beyond rushing out into the rain. I didn't really have much time to think about it, although I suppose a part of me held a fantasy of stopping the foursome before they got into the car, sweeping Nicole into my arms, and telling her how much I loved her. There would be a kiss in the rain, naturally. And then a happy ending.

When I got out there, there was no car to stop, or the four of them with the arms drunkenly looped over one another. There was no one at all but a taxi idling by the curb.

Well, at least that was a thing. Tired and grumpy and done with being awake, the idea of feeling sorry for myself in the quiet of my hotel room until I fell asleep sounded just about right.

As I approached the taxi, though, I realized that someone was sitting in the back. Well, of course it was too good to be true.

Just as I started to turn away, the door opened. "Hey!" Nicole shouted. "Stop waiting and get in."

I felt dizzy and relieved and the heavy limbs that could have been exhaustion or disappointment or both. The rain pushed me forward. I climbed inside.

"I thought...what about the guy with the shoulders and being a wing-woman?"

Nicole, blanketed in shadow, had a coquettish look on her face that turned the darkness into something warm and suggestive. "You really thought I'd do something with that guy?"

"I...guess I did."

"Oh, Ethan. Why would you think that?"

It showed how tired I was that I didn't even realize that the cab had pulled out of the parking lot, headed to some mystery location. Call it travel weariness, but I wasn't in the mood for this kind of teasing. "Because you implied as much in your texts."

"And did that make you jealous?"

I sighed. Aggressively. “Yes, it did. Is that what you want to hear?”

She studied me quietly as the street lamps slid through the dark. “I’m honestly not sure what I want to hear, but thanks for your honesty.”

The cab drew to a stop, too soon to have made it all the way out to her house. I looked around, surprised to see that we were in the turnaround for the Hilton.

She scooted to my side and gave me a soft kiss on the cheek.

“Good night, Ethan. Text me in the morning and let’s do that date that you suggested last time.”

All the doubt and anxiety I’d been feeling lifted from my shoulders and the heaviness on my chest. Had I been wrong this whole time?

“Or...we could skip the date and just go back to my place...” said Nicole when I failed to respond.

“No, let’s do the date. That sounds...that sounds great.”

“Okay.” She regarded me like a puzzle. “You okay, Ethan?”

I smiled, and when I did, I found it impossible to stop. “I am. I’m great, actually. Good night, Nicole.”

“Good night, Ethan.”

I wanted to tell her that I loved her. The words were poised on my tongue, ready to come, before I lost my nerve. The night really was great, why risk that?

Funny, how such an innocuous phrase like *I love you* could become so scary to say. We’d probably said it hundreds of times to one another over the years. Now, I couldn’t even say it once.

Now, as I watched the taxi drive away, I knew it in my heart to be true. I loved her. That love was different than it had been when we first met, which was different than when we got married, and it probably would change again in the future, but I would always love her.

She hadn’t gone home with the douchey guy. She’d agreed to the date. I felt like jumping up and clicking my heels together. Instead, I went to bed, and quickly fell into a deep and blessedly dreamless sleep.

first date

The first real date that Nicole and I shared was just a couple days before our last year in school. I could still remember thinking, *She could be The One*, and all the warm endorphins that came when checking off the biggest task in my life—find soulmate.

We'd met on the plane heading from San Francisco to Chicago. I was about to start the final year of my Master's program in Political Science, and she in her last year of nursing. We were young, but old enough to think that we weren't, so maybe it was just infatuation. Still, I'd never felt that way before with anyone.

Part of it was attraction and hormones, for sure, and I'd spent an entire plane ride trying not to stare at her long legs in those cheerleader shorts, or at just how much her breasts pushed out her t-shirt. Maybe because of that effort, though, I'd kept forcing the conversation and learned how down-to-earth she was. It had disarmed me enough that when the plane finally landed, I could ask her on a date.

Because of the way our relationship had started, we'd never known our college selves—just the idea of those college selves. She knew me as the guy who got excited about local government and loved *Parks and Rec*. I'd known her as the studious nursing student who religiously, and generically, watched *Grey's Anatomy*. We weren't undergrads. We'd never experienced one another that way.

We had numbers, of course. She'd had three boyfriends and the same number of lovers. I'd hooked up with five girls, but had a harder time figuring out how many girlfriends that I had—somewhere between eight and ten. Her longest boyfriend had lasted for three years, from just after she'd turned sixteen to about half-way through her freshman year in college. My longest had been my college girlfriend, who I'd been with for the last three years of my undergrad program before we graduated and went our separate ways.

But those were just numbers, and numbers could never communicate the true story. I wasn't just thinking about the hookups that didn't end in sex, although I had a few of those—and while she'd never said it, I was pretty sure Nicole did, too. I was specifically thinking about what life itself

was like during those formidable years. About hanging out in the shared space of our dorm's suite, passing a joint as we got philosophical about the nature of the universe. Or about drinking too much at a party and stumbling across the quad on a warm night before passing out in an unkempt bed. Or having to deal with the hangover the next day and still make it to that 8 a.m. class I stupidly signed up for. Or any number of the silly things we did in college when we were adults yet had so few responsibilities.

No, by the time we got to know each other, we were both pursuing post-grad degrees. We'd mostly moved past those carefree days and were thinking about the next stage of our lives, and because of that, our shared experiences were now all about that next stage.

Maybe that's why our second first date, the one that came nearly seven years after the first, felt just as new and exciting and scary as the first.

I took care in how I dressed. Working in DC for a politician meant that I had no shortage of suits, so that wasn't difficult. But once I'd chosen the lighter-than-royal blue suit that paired well with my brown loafers, I had to decide on the tie or not. This was the West Coast, after all, and I was meeting up with Nicole, so maybe a tie was overkill. But I also wanted to represent the new me, and that meant ties and handkerchiefs and patterned socks that made a statement when seen.

It was a far cry from the tucked-in flannel I'm pretty sure I wore on our *first* first date. It was a wonder that she'd agreed to a second.

I'd considered going back to the Green Leaf for the date, but this event seemed to call for something special. So I booked a reservation at Fig & Pear, this French American bistro that was new and well liked on Yelp. Because of my crazy schedule, and Nicole's heavy one, we weren't able to get together until the following Tuesday, and only then at 9 o'clock. I was starving by the time I made it up the long, winding hill to the Fig & Pear.

Nicole was waiting for me when I arrived, looking breathlessly sweet in a black dress printed with small, red roses. Her hair was half back and her bangs were held in check by a headband, giving her a 1960s coed look that made me ache.

The restaurant itself was nice. Located on a small hill on the outskirts of town, it looked out over the cedar-filled landscape, still brushed with snow. The inside was small and romantic, with round, wooden tables and refurbished, wooden chairs that still squeaked when sat in.

“Right this way,” the host said. It being late on a Tuesday, we were among only a few diners.

“Have you been here before?” I asked her, mostly to make conversation.

Nicole said, “A few times, yes.”

Looking around, I realized just how intimate the bistro was. Little, floating candles flickered and filled the space like a caress. Most of the tables were set for two, not a group. A couple times quickly translated into a couple dates, which triggered that now familiar tightness in my chest.

We sat. We got our menus. She opened hers as I watched her, marveling at how beautiful she was. Her small, teardrop earrings sparkled in the candlelight, and her skin turned to warm butter. This is how her dates would have seen her. The thought was unsettling, but also...arousing.

“What?” she asked, looking up to find me staring.

“Nothing, just...”

Maybe she lied, too. Cabbie wisdom from so long ago, back to haunt me. She’d just admitted that she’d been here before, and not just once, but a few times. I wanted to ask her about the guys, but I didn’t because, as weird as it was, I didn’t want to catch her in the lie.

“You look like you’re thinking about more than nothing,” she said.

I sighed. “I thought you said that you didn’t date,” I blurted with more accusation than I’d intended.

Her brows rose just a fraction at that before she spoke. When she did, she was calm, where I’d expected defensive—where I’d almost welcomed it. “I seem to recall that you’d asked me if I was dating anyone at the time. And I wasn’t.”

I felt like the chair had been yanked out from beneath me. It felt so real that I almost rubbed my ass.

She saw my reaction and frowned. When she spoke, she was gentle. “A guy took me here when it first opened. I think it was about three months after the separation, and I’d been putting him off since you’d originally taken the job and moved. I think I’d said yes more to get him to stop than anything. Anyway, it was...” She paused, searching for the right word. Dread rose through me. I held my breath and prepared for a blow. “It was a disaster.”

She laughed, and I relaxed. It wasn’t what I was expecting. She’d been looking away, recalling the night, but now she shifted her attention to me.

“It was so awkward that he left early. I think I may have started crying at some point during dinner. We’ve barely even talked since then.”

I couldn’t help it. I joined her laughter. “I’m sorry you cried.”

She waved it away. “Oh, it wasn’t because of you.” But she didn’t give another reason, so I let the white lie stand. “Anyway, let’s hope this date is a little better.”

“I think I can manage that.”

That was one date, one visit. She’d said that she’d been here a few times. I wanted to know about those, but then again, that was a symptom of the greater problem that I was wrestling with, right? So why not just ask about that one.

“So are you dating anyone now?”

Nicole didn’t say anything overt, but I knew what to look for. She glanced up and away as her brows came together in a soft furrow, and if I looked close enough, I was sure I saw her pull her shoulders back. It all happened in the space of a second, no more than two, but I saw the anxiousness there as surely as I would a billboard. She’d done the same thing when I’d asked her about a new scratch on the car or when I learned that she’d paid the mortgage late.

Before she could answer, though, our server came over and told us all about the specials. I wanted to kill the man. Nicole read my frustration and actually laughed before I shooed him away.

“Don’t take it out on him,” she said with a laugh. “He’s just doing his job.”

“And reading the situation poorly,” I said grumpily.

Her smile didn’t falter, but her tone suddenly got serious. “Ethan, why did you ask me on this date?”

Not the question I was expecting, and certainly not one that I had an immediate answer to. Why did I? I tried the first thing that came to my head, even knowing it wasn’t exactly true.

“Seemed like the right thing to do, after all the...you know...”

Nicole shook her head, although judging by the way she covered her smile with the brush of her bangs, she knew exactly.

I said, “All the casual sex.”

The server came back. He also heard the last thing that I’d said. He had to have, but rather than retreat, he went right ahead with his script. “Are you two ready to order, or do you need more time?”

A nervous laugh burst from Nicole before she could stop it. She released her hair and said, "I'll take the almond-crusted chicken breast, please, with a glass of Chardonnay."

"Excellent. And you, sir?"

I hadn't even looked at the menu yet. I would have told him that I wasn't ready, except for the way Nicole was looking made me hurry up.

"I'll take the..." I scanned the menu. "Just bring me the mussels."

"Would you like that as a starter, or your main dish?"

"What's the difference?" I asked, then realized that a question meant more of him talking. "Never mind, main dish."

"And something to drink?"

I could kill this man! "Same as her," I said. Then, "Please."

"Right away, sir." He repeated our orders back to us, and when I looked over at Nicole, she was staring at me, on the verge of laughter. I wanted to hang on to my impatience, but it was hard under Nicole's smile.

"Thank you. It sounds lovely," she told the server. Finally, he left.

"I thought he'd never leave," I muttered.

She ignored my gripe, and got right back to it. "So you were saying something about casual sex and, I believe the implication was something about making me an honest woman."

Put like that, it sounded...well, terrible. "Maybe that's not quite right," I said. I took a deep breath. "I asked you out because I like you, and more than just as a...as a fuck buddy."

She nodded like this was what she expected. "And if that's all I can give right now?"

I recoiled. "Do you have any other..."

"Fuck buddies? I'm not sure that's any of your business."

"Of course it is. I'm your husband."

"Maybe technically, but you're the one who walked out." She caught herself, but her words were already out. She shut her eyes and took a deep breath. Her eyelids sparkled, her lashes fanned out in dark crescents. "I'm sorry I said that."

I grimaced. "But you did say it."

She opened her eyes, blue and troubled, but didn't deny it.

"I shouldn't have asked you on this date," I said. How silly of me. I didn't think of myself as a romantic, but maybe I should have. Wasn't I thinking about kissing her in the rain just last week?

She reached out and placed her hand on the back of mine. Her palms were clammy. “No, don’t say that. You wanted to, so you should have. I...I accepted. I didn’t have to do that, either.”

“We’re doing a pretty good job making a run at Worst Date Ever,” I said.

Nicole’s laugh came out as half a sob.

“I haven’t cried yet.”

“The night’s still young,” I said.

Her laughter smoothed out, losing its edge. “Is that self-deprecation, or some kind of sexual innuendo? Because you should know that I don’t sleep with anyone on my first date.”

I smiled, and it felt good. “So this counts as a first date? Not a two hundred and fourth?”

“Someone is being a little generous with that number.”

“I’m counting sitting on the couch watching *Game of Thrones* as a date.”

“Please, at least limit yourself to movie nights,” she said with a polite laugh. “But no, this is date number one for you and me. Those others? They were shared between different people. That was then. This is now, and that’s the best we can do.”

“Pretty fatalistic.”

Nicole shrugged. “Life’s thrown me some curveballs. And besides, that couple didn’t work, so why would we want to try to be them again?”

This time, when our server interrupted us to deliver our food, I was grateful. Still, her question haunted me through the meal, even as we shifted to talk about lighter, safer things. It was a good first date, all things considered. I made her laugh, she made me laugh. I learned that she’d taken up camping and the outdoors in a way that I never would have guessed she’d be into. I filled her in on some political gossip that she genuinely was interested to hear. Even if I hadn’t known her for years, I would have wanted to go on another date with her.

When the night ended, she didn’t offer me a drink back at her place, or even a ride back to the hotel. Instead, she gave me a kiss on the cheek and a nice hug.

“I had fun,” she said with a shy smile. It made me think of a younger Nicole, only grown up. Was this what she would have become had I not married her?

“Me too.” My heart began to race. I actually had to work up the nerve to ask her out again. “I’m here until Monday morning. Primary wraps up Saturday night, and I’ve got Sunday free if you are...”

She thought a moment, then frowned. “Sunday’s not going to work for me.”

Disappointment weighed me down. “Ah. That’s cool.”

“But call me the next time you’re back. I’ll make sure to get free.”

Like a roller coaster, I was back up again. “I will.”

“Good night, Ethan. Thanks for...thanks for asking me out.”

“Thanks for accepting.”

She kissed my cheek again, lingering against my ear. “And just so you know, anything’s possible after my second date.”

She stepped away, leaving me in the lingering promise of her perfume. I watched her climb into her car, wave, and drive away.

I decided to walk back to the hotel. It wasn’t close, about a twenty-minute walk, but it also wasn’t that cold and I needed some time to clear my head.

That couple didn’t work, she’d said. It’s funny that I’d never thought of it like that. We hadn’t in the end, but our problems started before I’d decided to move. That was just the catalyst that finally got us moving farther down the track that we’d always been heading. We hadn’t worked, and here I was with this romantic notion to go back to it.

But she was right. Why would we want to try to be them again?

As I got within sight of Main Street and its sleepy, yellow lights and closed-for-the-day storefronts, my phone buzzed.

[Nicole]: Hey, it’s Nicole.

And...

[Nicole]: You free?

I stopped in the road, staring at the texts, my heart beating, my head spinning, excited yet confused.

Then...

[Nicole]: :P

I found my brain again.

[Me]: Thought you didn’t sleep with anyone on your first date?

[Nicole]: Oh, I'm not texting that guy.

I know, it was a wildly irrational thought, but for a moment, I wondered if she'd even meant to text me. Or that she even knew who she was texting.

Weirder still, that thought—to see this secret side of Nicole—was intoxicating.

[Nicole]: I'm texting the hot, DC wonk who sometimes comes over and gives me a nice, hard fuck.

Well, that dispelled my irrational, yet oddly sexy, theory.

[Nicole]: So... you free?

[Me]: Be right there.

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rally

On Thursday night, two nights before the primary, we held a rally event at the Tap Room. The hospital was one of the biggest employers in the district, and because we couldn't hold the primary at the hospital itself, we went to the next best thing—its drinking hole.

Of course, because of the intended audience, I wondered if Nicole would be there, and because the possibility existed, I buzzed with nervous energy. It was the same feeling I got the first time I'd brought Nicole home to meet my parents. Made some sense, although my coworkers were poor proxies for my parents. They'd also met her before—or at least knew who she was as *that hot nurse*. But it was quite a leap from that to *this is my ex* or, dare I think it, *this is my girlfriend*?

That was a strange thought, too. Thinking of her as my *wife*—or even ex-wife—was a routine I'd done so much that I no longer thought about it, like brushing my teeth. Thinking of her as my *girlfriend* was new and exciting. The former made me think of watching television on a Friday night; the latter made my pulse quicken at the thought of our next sexual adventure.

Either way, it was new and different and it made me nervous. Nervous enough that I actually texted Nicole to check if she'd be there.

[Nicole]: Wasn't planning on it. Should I be?

The reply was...disappointing, I'll admit. But she wasn't my girlfriend, regardless of where I wanted things to go, and she had no obligation to come.

[Me]: Nah, just wondering, since the last time I was here, so were you.

I watched Nicole type, waiting for her reply and hoping that she'd change her mind. Or, if not that, then invite me over after for a late night booty call.

[Nicole]: Good luck tonight. Make sure you have plenty of booze. Doctors love to drink.

I chuckled to myself and shut the phone. In many ways, this was easier. I wouldn't have to explain all the complications around our relationship with the team, and I had an early morning, so staying up late would have been irresponsible—although worth it, when it involved having sex with a woman like Nicole.

Instead, I was on my own—Ethan Shaw, just another cog in Congressman Phillips' reelection machine.

The Congressman shined in these kinds of small gatherings where he could mingle and read the room, answer questions, and show that he was a real person who really was listening. The opposing candidate was running against the incumbent on the platform of being an "outsider," which was ridiculous since Phillips had only been in DC for a single term. This rally, and all the rest, proved how ridiculous the accusation was.

I drank too much, too quickly. I'd been so good all campaign long, but something about the venue and the guests being so close to Nicole had me asking for one too many pints too early in the evening. Also, Nicole was right, these doctors could drink—especially when given access to an open bar. We were up in the polls. The mood was good, even among the stressed out campaign team. I went with the flow.

I was so unprepared when I spotted Dr. Mason Mann at the bar. In fact, when I first saw the man with the shaved head and the short goatee, I waved, like we knew one another but I just couldn't place his name. He returned the wave, somewhat confused, before it hit me who he was: Dr. McDreamy, who I'd kind of cyber stalked months back.

My face lit up and the very rational thought that I should stop drinking cut through the fuzziness of my buzz—even as I chugged the rest of my drink and went to the bar for another. That was the thing about drinking, right? Sober minds know when to stop, drunken ones do not.

I tried to avoid him, but that was nearly impossible. The place wasn't that large, and it was constantly being shuffled. I ran into him on the back porch, where I wanted to get some air and he was having a smoke.

"Oh, sorry, didn't realize anyone was out here," I said, trying to make my retreat.

He blew smoke away from me and waved his hand. "No worries. Stay. Please. It'll be good to have some company."

This was not good. This was not a situation I wanted to be in. And yet I could figure out no quick way to get out of it. Not in my current state.

“Sure, it’s nice out here for March.”

Mason looked up at the sky, squinting at the stars as if their very presence surprised him. When he spoke, there was mirth in his voice. “It’s not raining.”

I saw the glass of whiskey in his hand, mostly empty, and wondered how much he’d had, too.

“It’s not.”

He nodded. “So do we know each other? You kind of look familiar.”

I froze up inside. Had he seen me on Facebook? I tried to think if Nicole had posted any recent photos of us—and by recent, I meant the last three years. Probably, but had he seen those?

“I don’t think so,” I said.

“You waved earlier. Thought maybe you knew.”

I reached. “Um... I’ve heard of you more than know you.”

“Know of me, huh? How’s that?”

Good question. Wish I knew where I’d intended to go with that. Since I didn’t, I reached in another direction. “I met someone who works at the hospital.” His next question was who, and I was about to answer Nicole when I realized how stupid that would be. He’d figure out that I was Nicole’s ex and if anything was going on between them, things would get weird.

And if there were, did I really want to know about it? After the date and the new beginning and all the good stuff that was going on between us?

“This nurse named Fiona. She said you were one of the best.” I kept reaching and reaching, wondering when I’d finally fall over. “She said they respect you there. That I should...should get your support.”

Well, that could have been smoother.

Mason chuckled. “Fiona said that?”

Fuck, was there a beef between him and Fiona? Was I busted already?

Might as well stick to this lie, because it was the only one that I was going to be allowed. “Yes.”

Mason laughed. “So you know Fiona, huh?”

I’d seen her a handful of times, and only recently from across the room getting hit on by a guy who probably didn’t deserve her. Luckily, my story left it vague. “I wouldn’t say know her. We talked.”

“Just talked?”

Flushed from the alcohol and wanting to...I don't know, compete with this guy or something, I...smiled. Knowingly. Like I actually *knew* something.

"I thought so," Mason said with a brief laugh. "I don't blame you, of course. She can be very...tempting."

This felt illicit, learning a thing that I shouldn't know. I felt a rush that came with the forbidden. "So you've...?"

"It's hospital policy not to date any other employee without getting permission from human resources." He was quoting from the manual like he knew it by heart, which meant that he was very familiar with it.

"It's against policy not to *date*," I said.

Mason's smile wasn't in any way lascivious. He didn't come off as cocky, as much as I wanted him to. He was more disarming, and his smile was one of appreciation rather than a flex of machismo. "Spoken like a true politician."

I thought of something that Nicole had said, and it felt like ice had entered my veins. "Not much dating going on at the hospital, I bet, but plenty going on."

"Well, I can't speak for everyone, but sure, things happen. And I can only think of a few couples who've ever gone to HR."

"I take it that you're not one of them?"

"No, although I'd never say never."

I must have made a face, because he held up his hand and said, "Not Fiona. Don't worry. She's not the type to date, so don't worry. She's all yours for as long as you can manage her."

"Thanks," I said, but I was busy going over my conversations with Nicole. I'd asked her if she was dating anyone. She'd said no, not at the time. When I'd asked her again, she had dodged the question, but still could have told me that she wasn't according to hospital logic. It felt like my stomach was suddenly filled with rocks.

"What about you? I've read the Hill has some hot interns."

I forced myself back into the present. It was a slightly more comfortable place than my head. "Not much there, honestly. Some are definitely hot, but everyone's too busy working their asses off to have time for that." I thought of Cate, and how that felt like a lifetime ago. Even with her, we barely had time for one another. "You've probably got more downtime at the hospital to sneak away and..."

I hoped my flushed face was hidden by the dim light out here. I also hoped he didn't notice how fast I was breathing.

"Oh, no, that's not how it works," he said. "Well, not for me, anyway. I know the fantasy: empty examination room, hot, white nurses outfit, white stockings and lingerie, all that stuff. Reality isn't like that, not that it's a bad fantasy. There's just too much risk for the exam rooms, and you know the white uniforms are a thing of the past."

"Sure." Then, because I just couldn't help myself, I added, "So how does it work?"

He laughed. "Like any other job. We meet after work. We come here for drinks, or back to our places for more privacy. I've got a place on Mt. Rainier that we sometimes go to. In fact, I'm heading up there tomorrow morning."

"Bringing anyone special?" It was like I'd baited my line with my heart and cast it into the ocean. Out and out it went, only to snag painfully on the first thing.

"Working on it."

"Fiona?" I said, full of hope that it was, and hope that it wasn't.

"No, not her. Like I said, that one's all yours."

I swallowed, and found I had no saliva in my mouth. Not a drop. "So there are multiple hot nurses at the hospital? You sure this isn't some LA porn director's fantasy?"

Mason laughed, hearty and sincere. "I like you, man. I think I'm going to vote for your guy."

I offered him a sickly smile. It was the best I could do.

"Yeah, there are a few hot nurses, but this one's special, you know?" He slapped me on the back. "I'm going to take off a bit early to go pack. Need to get my rest, because if I can convince her to come out... Well, she wears me out."

"Good...luck."

He started to leave, then paused. "Oh, hey, but don't worry..."

Worry? I think my heart may have stopped beating for a full thirty seconds. Felt that way.

"I'll make sure to put in a good word with my staff for Phillips before I go."

I felt so stiff. I didn't even turn to look at him as he left. Just said, "Thanks."

Nicole couldn't meet on Sunday for some unknown reason. Was that because she was planning to meet Mason at his Mt. Rainier lodge? Did she not come out tonight because she was packing? I imagined her throwing tiny scraps of lingerie into a suitcase, along with a couple bikinis for the hot tub. I thought of the two of them shacked up in his chalet, naked and fucking on a bearskin rug.

The worst thing of all was that despite feeling like I'd had molten lead poured all over me, my cock was hard. Like, really fucking hard. Like, so hard that I needed to pace around the outdoor patio before I could safely enter the bar again, and even then, my head wasn't right.

I saw Fiona chatting with one of our interns, a glass of wine in her hand. The red-headed nurse looked hot as usual. Tonight, she'd dolled herself up, wearing a red satin dress that did just about everything it could to highlight her tits. Her hair fell around her face in shiny curls that bounced each time she made a point, or nodded at one that the intern did.

Without thinking about what I was doing, I crossed the room to them. "Fiona, how are you doing? I'm so glad you could make it."

She looked at me, confused for a moment as she tried to place me. Unlike Mason, she did. "Ethan, wow, it's been a long time."

"Over a year, yeah. Crazy how time flies. You look fantastic, by the way." I let my eyes linger in her cleavage, despite the gentleman in me wanting to avert at all costs. She'd worn this dress for a reason, and I might as well give in. When I did manage to make it back to her face, she'd lifted her brow in surprise.

"You look pretty good, yourself, Ethan. Keeping in shape, I see."

The intern quietly excused himself and disappeared into the crowd.

"So how long have you been here?" I asked.

Her hazel eyes moved as if reading the air between us. Then, slowly, she answered, "Long enough."

"Going to vote for Congressman Phillips?"

"Wasn't planning on voting, but for you? Sure."

I smiled. "Great." The next thing I never would have asked, and almost didn't, even with all the booze. But then I thought about Nicole again, with Mason in his ski chalet. I thought about all those photos he'd put on Facebook, of fancy meals at the ski resort, of him suited up in ski equipment that cost thousands of dollars, of what I realized only now was

his personal ski lodge that had a giant, stone fireplace practically designed to lower the panties of any woman he brought up there.

And he was bringing Nicole up there this weekend. He probably had before. What had he said? Something about a lot of hot nurses, but Nicole being the very best.

I thought about all of *that*, and even then, I almost didn't ask the next thing. But in the end, I did. "So you want to get out of here?"

Fiona gave *me* a once over, long and comprehensive. "You have a hotel room, I take it?"

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Fiona

We caught an Uber back to the Hilton, but Fiona didn't wait for us to get there. Her kisses were possessive in a way that Nicole couldn't quite achieve, even at her hardest. Maybe that was because, mixed in with her aggressive tongue and the way her lips parted so easily was this sense that all of this was one, giant mistake.

In the light of day, I'd probably know that it was. If I hadn't been drinking, I probably never would have approached Fiona. If I wasn't so blindingly jealous of Dr. Mason Mann fucking my wife before a crackling fire, I never would have invited Fiona back to my hotel room.

Or maybe I would have. Maybe this was fate. Maybe it wasn't so bad, after all. It was just sex, and if anything had taught me about casual sex, it was Nicole these past few months.

All of that tumbled through my head as we made out in the backseat of the car, then passed hurriedly through the hotel lobby on the way to my room. I felt the eyes judging me, but ignored them behind a curtain of inebriation. Those other thoughts, the guilty ones, the hypotheticals, they all played out in some part of my brain that was completely disconnected from the woman in the red, satin dress.

Fiona was hot, in all the ways that word implied. Her lips burned against mine. The skin beneath her dress felt like fire beneath my hands. And the way she pulled me into the room with such intent was unlike anyone I'd had before. She knew what she wanted, and she had the confidence to know that she was entitled to it.

She pulled me down the hall to my room, reaching into my pocket to fish out my keycard—and a not-so-subtle grope. “Very nice, Ethan. Nicole told me you were large, but I guess I didn't believe her.”

Mention of my wife should have been snapped me out of this downward spiral. In any other situation, it probably would have. Instead, the thought of Nicole talking about dick sizes with this woman set me off even more.

“Let's not talk about her,” I growled as the hotel door beeped open.

Fiona shrugged, flung open the door, and pulled me in. “Fine by me. I'll just have to see for myself.”

She kissed me one last time before dropping to her knees and working swiftly at my belt. I leaned against the door, unstable in my state, and looked down into her large, hazel eyes as she fished my cock out. Her deep cleavage rose and fell with her excitement, and I detected a slight flush in her skin that could have been more than just the booze.

Somehow, I found my voice and the new self that I'd carved from the old. I wasn't Nicole's husband here. I was my own man, single and having a meaningless liaison in a hotel room far from home. "You've wanted to do this for a while, haven't you?"

Fiona ran her tongue languidly along the base of my shaft. "Mmm hmm. A looong time."

She swallowed the very tip, swirling her tongue, before returning back to licking the outside.

"You're a bad girl, wanting your friend's husband." I'm not sure where this was coming from, but I went with it.

"I'm very bad," she agreed.

I placed my hand on the back of her head and nudged her closer. "Let's see how much you can take."

Her smile was enough that I could have come from that alone. Again, I had the booze to thank, most likely. She took me up on the challenge, swallowing me about three quarters of the way in her first dip.

I splayed the fingers of my free hand behind me for stabilization as she pulled back slowly, then dove back in. Her eyes cut up at me. *Like that?* they implied.

"More," I said.

Fiona took more, deeper and deeper. I was in her throat, being caressed by it as she controlled her gag and got me off. Nicole in a similar situation popped into my mind—Nicole who'd never deep throat me, also taking me into her throat—and like that, Fiona became my wife.

The hand that had sat passive on her head tightened, clutching at the soft, copper curls. Her eyes flared, but she didn't pull off. If anything, she sucked harder, faster. Her moan thrummed along my shaft like someone running their hands swiftly along the keys of a piano. I shut my eyes, fighting back the imminent orgasm.

And behind those closed eyes, Nicole greeted me, smiling up as she jerked me off with her throat. *You like that, lover? You like how bad I can be?* Only suddenly, it wasn't me she was blowing, but Mason Mann. I was

standing behind her, at a distance, watching her head bob, watching her on her knees in her nursing scrubs as he fisted her hair and forced her to work harder.

Fiona cried out. I rammed deep, to the root, until my pelvis pressed against her pretty, red lips, and I exploded down her throat.

Horror at what I'd done washed over me as my orgasm flowed. I wasn't like this. I didn't get this physical, this demanding. I'd never face-fucked a woman before, and as I watched my come ooze out the sides of Fiona's lips, the intense need to apologize rose up.

Fiona pulled back, wiping her mouth with her fingers and licking each like she'd just had a greasy meal. When she spoke, her voice was huskier than normal. "You're full of surprises, Ethan. Now I wish we'd done this a long time ago."

She rose to her feet, slinky and seductive, and finished undressing me. She ran her hands along my abs, my pecs, the sweep of my shoulders, appreciating me in a way that was both sexy yet objectifying. That touch said, *You're my toy tonight, and I'm going to use you until you break.*

She turned her shoulder to me, not quite turning fully around. "Unzip me?"

I can't do this, I almost said. A strong part of me actually didn't, no matter what Nicole might be doing with Dr. McDreamy. But I'd also just received a world class blowjob from this extremely attractive woman.

I unzipped her dress, and was treated to the dainty band of her red bra.

"Thanks," she said, shrugging out of the dress. Beneath, she wore a matching red thong, a red garter belt with nude colored stockings clipped to them.

She saw me looking at her lingerie, and wiggled her ass at me. "Was hoping to find a friend for the night," she said. "Didn't think he'd be you though."

I kissed her shoulder, right over the thin strap of her bra. "Disappointed?"

"Disappointed? No," she laughed. "Surprised? Very. I never figured you'd be so...rough." She leaned into me and offered her mouth. "I love it rough."

I kissed her hard, running my hands up the bare skin of her stomach. She had a pierced belly and a small tattoo up the inside of her ribs with

some kind of scripty text. She rubbed her ass against my flaccid cock, which was starting to stir again.

“Do you want to spank me?” she asked.

I had never before, but that’s not what this minx wanted to hear. “I would love to.”

“Of course you do.” She smiled slyly, her tongue out.

My gut churned. Why the *of course*? It wasn’t a kink of mine. Had Nicole told her it was a kink of hers? Had she explored that with McDreamy? Or was Fiona saying that because of my rough treatment earlier?

Didn’t matter to the here and now. She wanted it, and I’d provide. I pulled her in for a tight kiss, rubbed my hands over her ass—flatter and smaller than Nicole’s, but still amazing—and gave her a light smack.

She pulled back. “You should know that I’ve been very bad.”

“And what have you done?”

“I went down on a married man,” she said, her voice low and simpering. “And I really, *really* liked it.”

“That does sound naughty.” I turned her around and forced her to bend over the high mattress of my king-sized bed. “And do you know this man’s wife?”

What are you doing, man?

Even Fiona paused, looking back at me to make sure I was really taking it here. Seeing enough, she proceeded. “She’s one of my best friends.”

I looked down at her ass, bisected by the red of her thong. She wiggled it at me, and I gave it a light spank. Fiona gasped and moaned.

“So you’re sleeping with your best friend’s husband? That’s *really* bad.”

“Well, he started it,” she said.

Spank!

“He came onto me.”

Spank!

“His eyes wandered all over me.”

Spank!

“Ungh! Yes, spank me. Punish me.”

I said, “You didn’t have to be so easy.”

Spank!

“Uh!”

I paused to pull her thong over her garter belt and down her thighs. Her pussy glistened between her legs.

“I’d think you were used to easy women, based on who you’re married to.”

That...felt weird to hear. Unpleasant, certainly, but also powerfully erotic. Like someone had grabbed my balls and yanked.

“What’s that supposed to mean?” I demanded.

Fiona looked over her shoulder, and I saw worry on her face that she’d gone too far.

I grabbed her hips and flipped her over, spreading her legs open. She had a narrow landing strip to prove that she was a natural redhead, but was otherwise shaved.

“Are you saying my wife is easy?” I stroked my cock along the velvet softness of her lips. “Is that what you’re implying?”

Adjusting my angle, I thrust into her. We groaned together, experiencing the new and the exciting and the wrong. I wasn’t gentle. I didn’t let her adjust to me. I fucked her like I’d fucked her mouth, hard and rough and so not like me.

I wasn’t punishing Fiona. She was just a proxy for my “easy” wife.

“Oh, fuck me!” Fiona cried. “Hurt me!”

She wrapped her legs around my back and dug the points of her heels painfully into my lower back.

Our bodies rose and fell together. Each time I drew up, her hips followed, those heels biting into me. Each time, I fought back the pain a little more, rising higher, falling faster and harder. Our skin slapped. The bed shook, solid enough not to strike the wall, but only just so.

Fiona ran her fingernails along my back—a first for me. I hissed at the pain, but it only encouraged me to fuck her harder. So did her moans, loud and gasping and pornographic. The new Nicole was amazing because she was my wife, but Fiona fucked like she was born to.

My arms couldn’t hold out. My biceps burned from holding myself over her. I lowered myself to my elbows, pressing my body against her full tits and her eraser-tip nipples. She coiled beneath me like a spring, her head back, her hips and pussy up against mine, her nails drawing blood.

“Fuck. Me! Fuck me!” she screamed.

I held out as long as I could, pounding her, punishing her, feeling her wet pussy slide up and down my cock. But it was the thought of Nicole doing this very same thing, in Mason Mann's arms, that set me off. Fiona's pleas became Nicole's. Fiona's nails became my wife's. Fiona's pussy became my wife's, and with that thought, I lost it.

Reality returned. Fiona was back beneath me, her body slack, her breathing heavy. She pushed her hand through her damp hair, the sweat making it look more auburn than copper.

"Meow," she said. "We definitely should have done this sooner."

"Don't think that would have been possible," I said, collecting myself. I couldn't seem to roll off of her. I had nothing left in me.

"Oh, I wouldn't say that."

Something moved in my gut, too warm and anxious to be comfortable. "Why not?"

"We're talking about Nicole, right?"

I found enough strength to push up so I could look into her face. She met my eyes with an exhilaration that scared me. I didn't want to answer. I didn't want to know.

But I couldn't help myself.

"We are. What are you saying, Fiona? Spit it out."

"Just that I've learned how...open she really is."

I felt sick. I felt jittery. My vision began to narrow. I wondered if this was what a panic attack felt like.

Fiona's eyes went wide. "Oh, I felt that."

I was actually getting hard again. Or at least making an attempt to.

"It's okay, I'm not a jealous type. I'm fine with you getting excited thinking about your hot ex-wife."

She's still my wife, I wanted to say, but couldn't. I couldn't say anything.

Fiona went on, misinterpreting my thickening cock. "I know that you two get together when you're in town. She couldn't keep it a secret. Not with the way she bounced into work the morning after. For a woman who everyone thinks is this angel, she can be pretty naughty, can't she?"

I knew the question I wanted to ask next, the one I'd been trying to get out of Nicole herself. But it scared me. Like, really, really scared me. Once I knew, there was no way of unknowing. Once I asked and she answered, everything would change, one way or another.

I asked anyway.

“Does she do that often? The hookups?” I was standing at the edge of a cliff, looking down at my own demise, and was teetering on the edge.

“You mean with other guys?”

My body tightened, squeezing my heart, squeezing my lungs, squeezing my scrotum.

“Yeah, with other guys.”

Fiona’s smile spread across her face like something spilled, warming everything to uncomfortable levels. “I wouldn’t say she does it *often*.”

“But there are others.”

She bit her lip. “Uh huh. That turns you on.”

“No.” I shook my head, trying to convince myself.

“Your cock’s hard.”

“It’s...” Fuck, she was right. I pulled out of her, my incriminating erection popping free, and knelt up. My face was on fire. My head was a torch.

Fiona followed me up, wrapping her hand around my cock as she kissed my neck. I shivered. She whispered, “It’s okay. You’re not the first man to have this fantasy.”

“I don’t.”

She pumped my cock. “Really? Because something tells me you’re not telling the truth.”

The tangle of emotions knotted my tongue. I felt embarrassed, confused, upset, and, she was right, so fucking turned on.

“I’ve been her wing-woman on a few occasions. She’s no innocent. And that’s hot for you to hear, isn’t it?”

“Fiona...” It was, but I didn’t want to admit it.

“You’re not her only fuck buddy.”

I fucking twitched in her hand, and hated myself for it.

She purred against me, stroking me harder. “Mmm, this is so kinky. You want to know more? You want to hear about them?”

I did. I so did. But I couldn’t.

I put my hands on her shoulders and pushed her back. “Stop, please, Fiona. I can’t do this.”

“Sure you can.” She squeezed my cock, demonstrating that yes, it was still rock hard.

Somehow, I found the willpower to put a stop to this. I pushed her away. “Seriously, I can’t.” I looked around, realizing that we were in my hotel room. I couldn’t just leave. “Tonight was amazing, but...this is too much.”

Fiona must have seen the finality in my face. To her credit, she didn’t look upset or annoyed. She nodded, as if understanding exactly what was going on in my head—something that I wasn’t even sure of.

“I’m sorry if you didn’t want to hear all that,” she said, actually looking bashful for a change. Then, she looked back up at me and smiled. “But I think you did. Kind of.”

She slipped off the bed with grace. Feeling awkward, I considered going into the bathroom until she left. Instead, I grabbed my boxers and sat on the edge of the bed as she got dressed.

“If you want to talk more about it—or just want to get together again and not talk at all...” She grinned and scribbled something down on the hotel notepad. “There’s my number. Tonight was super fun. You’ve got a great cock, Ethan. I’d love to ride it some more.”

I think I said goodbye. I think I thanked her again. I’m not entirely sure. I sat there long after she’d gone, wrestling with the confusing mess going on in my head.

You’re not the first man to have this fantasy.

Fiona had played the good friend when Nicole saw a guy she liked out at a bar. I thought back to that evening when I’d watched her work with Fiona. How different that evening would have been if it was my wife who’d found someone to her liking first. And why did that idea turn me on so much?

I didn’t sleep well that night.

affairs

Friday dawned at some point. Life returned, and with it, other things to think about than Nicole and Mason Mann and Fiona and the mess that had become my life.

That first date at the Fig & Pear felt like a lifetime ago, and there was so much to do before the primary tomorrow. We had three different rallies in different parts of the district and were on the go from nearly the crack of dawn. I was tired, but feeling tired was better than feeling sorry for myself.

Not that I was able to keep my thoughts off of them. By calling my confusing emotions a *fantasy*, it was like Fiona had given them life. We went out to an organic farm in the more rural part of Hempstead, where Congressman Phillips gave a stump speech and I stood at his side.

The crowd was small and attentive, and I couldn't help myself from looking at some of the young farm hands and wondering if they'd been with Nicole. Until last night, I would have buried those uncomfortable thoughts, ashamed of them, even if no one knew what I was thinking.

But now, it was a *fantasy*, one that, according to Fiona, other men shared. That was comforting, if not exactly *comfortable*. As I stood there, clapping when others clapped, cheering when others cheered, my mind wandered to thoughts of Nicole sneaking away with one of these guys, laughing as he pulled her into a barn for some privacy.

Nicole had never lied. She'd certainly dodged the truth, but so had I. I hadn't owned up to dating Cate when I'd first come back to Hempstead, or any of the other random hookups I'd shared before that. I'd done that because I didn't want to hurt Nicole, and because I was guilty. It made sense that Nicole would feel the same way about her own hookups.

I considered just calling Nicole up and talking it out with her. That's what normal couples do in healthy relationships; they communicate and work out their feelings together. Only this wasn't a normal relationship. Hell, I wasn't even sure if this was a relationship at all.

The full day of musing about Nicole sneaking away again and again with the men of Hempstead County—which was populated by more good-looking guys than I could have imagined—had left me confused and horny.

I had Fiona's number, but I wasn't going to make that mistake twice, so the natural choice of who to call was, of course, Nicole.

She'd said that she wasn't free to go on a date Sunday night, and I had the unsettling—and equally arousing—thought that she was with Mason Mann at Mt. Rainier now, but I figured I'd try. Mason had said that he was working on convincing the woman, which meant that she hadn't accepted as of last night.

[Me]: Hey, are you free?

The workings of the booty call were still odd to me, especially since the call was to my wife, but it was still exciting. Maybe more exciting, though, was the idea of another man sending this very same text to her, with the very same intentions.

[Nicole]: Fiona not free tonight?

The text cut through my erotic speculation, turning it into ash.

[Nicole]: I'm sorry, not free tonight.

She may as well have said, *Go to hell*.

I shut my eyes and almost decided to shut the phone down as well go to bed. Then I remembered something. It was reckless and probably would only get me into more trouble, but at this point, I didn't have a whole lot to lose.

[Me]: Hey, don't be mad. You're the one who said a while back that I needed to thank her. ;)

I added the wink on to the end, held my breath, and sent it away. I watched the message get delivered, then read, then the typing indicator of Nicole's response. Still, I didn't release that breath until my phone buzzed with her reply.

[Nicole]: I did say that, didn't I?

I wasn't sure how to read that. I shifted uncomfortably before another text came in.

[Nicole]: From what she told me, she's the one who owes me now. Thanks for settling that debt. ;)

It was all just words on a screen, but it felt like I'd soothed things over.

[Nicole]: Goodnight, Ethan.

[Me]: Night, Nicole.

She didn't ask me to text her when I was back, and she hadn't forgiven me explicitly, but I felt like I was off the hook. It helped me sleep easier, which helped me deal with the long stretch of voting day tomorrow.

For a congressional primary, this one was getting national press because of the stakes. If Phillips lost to the Democratic challenger, then there was a good chance that the seat would pass into the hands of a Republican in November. Under all that scrutiny, Congressman Phillips ended up winning, although it was as close as predicted, and because the political media was rabid about making a news story, that closeness translated into vulnerability in the general election. Mitch Saffer and the rest of the campaign team didn't think there was much to worry about, but that didn't mean that we were going to ignore it.

It just meant that we needed to remain vigilant, which also meant more trips for me out to Washington State.

First, though, there was plenty of catchup to do back in DC. Congress was back in session, and despite it being an election year, the business of running the country remained.

I welcomed the work. Now that my eyes were open to the lifestyle that Nicole had back home—and how uncomfortable and aroused it made me—I needed something to keep me focused elsewhere. Keeping policy documents and schedules and position papers straight in my head required that kind of focus.

Not that I could completely shut it out. Now that I knew that this fantasy was a real thing, and not just a strange way for me to deal with my current situation, I went online to research it. I read about hotwifing and cuckolds. I read about guys who got off on watching their wives fool around, guys who got off on finding out that their wives were cheaters, and guys who got off on much darker things. There was a spectrum, like all things, from mild infatuation for watching a wife flirt to being humiliated by the wife's lover.

I decided that the humiliation part was a line that I couldn't cross. The idea of some alpha male rubbing in my face the fact that he'd slept with Nicole held no appeal, nor did the thought of Nicole doing the same—not that she would, unless the woman I knew had really changed.

But some things did appeal, and it was embarrassing, even to me, that they did. Like the cheating thing. As much as I hated the notion, there was

something profoundly erotic about the fact that Nicole was doing all of this behind my back—not that we were really a thing right now. We’d had one date, which hardly meant that we were a couple, but we had been, and we were still married, technically, and so it could be argued that she was having affairs.

Affairs. The word alone felt like I’d swallowed a ball of spiders and made me dizzy with horror, yet also so powerfully turned on. I thought about posting questions on an online forum, but was too ashamed to even type it out—like typing it would give it a weight that I wasn’t ready for.

I managed to get out of a couple trips to Hempstead. April passed into May and things in Washington, DC began to warm up. I walked down to see the Cherry Blossoms around the Tidal Basin, and thought about how Nicole would enjoy the sights. I did that a lot these days—doing things that were fun until I realized how much better they’d be with my wife.

About mid-May, I got a text out of the blue.

[Nicole]: Hey, are you free?

I was in my apartment on Capitol Hill, cleaning up the take-out dinner I’d ordered when it arrived. I even double checked the date stamp to make sure it wasn’t a delayed text from the last time I’d visited. It wasn’t.

[Me]: I am.

The weird thing was that the two of us didn’t communicate outside of my visits. We didn’t exchange email or texts. We didn’t even interact through social media. We lived our own, separate lives between visits.

[Nicole]: I’m in DC. What’s your address?

I stared at my screen like it was playing tricks on me. Once I realized that it wasn’t, and that she really had said that she was here, I shifted to wondering if this was some kind of dream.

[Nicole]: Or do you have company?

The text snapped me out of it. I couldn’t seem to type fast enough.

[Me]: No, no company. I’m alone. Just finished dinner. Are you really here?

[Nicole]: I can prove it to you.

A photo came through, of Fiona and Nicole taking a selfie in front of the Washington Monument. I studied the photo. They were smiling and happy, dressed in hoodies, their sunglasses pushed onto their heads. The sky behind them was cloudy, like today had been.

[Me]: Was that today?

[Nicole]: Yes, today. We took the redeye in. Arrived this morning.

[Me]: Why?

[Nicole]: Wedding. Gracie, one of the nurses who we used to work with, met some guy from here. We're actually bridesmaids.

I had so many questions, but before I could formulate any—

[Nicole]: So are you going to give me your address or what?

I gave her my address.

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DC

Part of me continued to think I was dreaming, right up to the moment when the call box downstairs rang my phone.

"I'm here," Nicole's tinny voice announced.

I buzzed her up, still half-expecting this to be some kind of elaborate joke. When I did open the door, though, it was Nicole, here in the flesh and looking as cripplingly beautiful as ever.

"Is this real?" I asked.

In the hoodie I'd seen in her selfie, a red zip-up that conformed enticingly to her full breasts and her hair pulled back into a ponytail, she made me think of more innocent times, back when we were in college. It was enough for me to forget about all the baggage we'd collected—both good and bad.

"I think so? I'm still trying to work out whether I'm here or not, too." She looked past me. "So this is your place?"

I stepped aside. "Oh, sorry. Come in, please." I ran my fingers through my hair and scanned my one-bedroom apartment. I'd always been the neater of the two of us, so it was easy to straighten up before she'd arrived, but I still worried that I'd missed something.

"It's nice," she said, looking around. She paused at my sectional, which was poised in front of the television. I had it set to CNN, with the volume on mute. "Here's the infamous black leather sofa," she said. "Very masculine, Ethan."

I'd forgotten about that conversation. God, that felt like an age ago. "There it is."

She smiled playfully. "You park your BMW on the street? I saw a bunch of them out there."

"No, I give the keys to my driver. He makes sure to polish it at night while I sleep."

Nicole fell into my arms, nuzzling close as she laughed. "So this is your life between visits."

It was funny to think about it that way, like the visits were more important than my real life, but I realized that it was how I saw it, too.

“I can’t believe you’re here,” I whispered. She smelled fresh, like soap and shampoo from the hotel. “You could have told me in advance.”

“I could have,” she agreed. “But I wanted you to taste your own medicine.”

“I deserve that.”

Nicole looked up at me, her blue eyes mischievous. “Are you going to show me the bedroom? Or do I have to go exploring on my own?”

She didn’t wait for a response. She backed away from me and unzipped her hooded sweatshirt. Beneath, she wore a baby tee that was even tighter on her. She pulled that over her head just as fast.

“Guess I’m exploring then.”

The picture of the halcyon days of our dating past collapsed as I stared into the cleavage created by her black, lacy bra. She was back to the woman who’d been waiting for me outside of the Tap Room after I’d chased her out. She was the woman who had slept with other men for fun, and probably would again when she returned.

That woman turned away from me and headed for the short hallway that led into the bedroom. As she moved, she shimmied her tight, black yoga leggings over her hips. Beneath, her thong matched her bra and made her already perfect ass look even more mouth-watering.

“I better not find black satin sheets in here,” she called over her shoulder. She looked almost cute as she kicked out of her leggings, stumbling in the process.

“No satin sheets,” I chuckled, finally remembering that I should follow. “High thread count Egyptian cotton though.”

“Mmm, my kind of man.”

And not the only man, I thought, my heart racing. I tore my shirt over my head as I crossed into my bedroom.

“You even made your bed. Always ready for company?” She laughed to herself, and I knew she was mostly joking, but not completely.

“I always make my bed,” I said.

“Yeah, I know.” She stopped before the foot of it and turned to face me. “Come on over here and let’s make it messy again.”

This time, when the cutesy innocence melted away, I didn’t wonder, *Who is this woman?* I knew who she was, and I imagined her playing this very act with other men.

Something awoke inside of me. Call it competitiveness. Call it machismo. Call it passion. Whatever it was, I rolled my shoulders back and advanced like a predator before prey. And this woman, this blonde that I recognized but did not, smiled and welcomed it.

We crashed to the bed, our lips swarming, our hands everywhere. She helped me out of my jeans and boxers. I grabbed her ass, kneading it as we kissed and rolled.

My back had mostly healed from where Fiona had clawed it, but Nicole felt the scabs. "Fiona?" she asked.

I flushed, feeling guilty, and nodded. "It won't happen again."

Nicole pulled back, eyeing me. She looked like she was about to speak, then simply nodded. That was all that needed to be said on that subject.

We kissed again, hungrier this time, as if both of us wanted to forget Fiona in our passion. I unhooked her bra and rolled her onto her back. "You came all this way," I said, opening her legs and moving down between her thighs. "Least I can do to show some hospitality."

"Good boy."

I grabbed her thong as she closed her knees together and lifted her ass. I dove in between her legs, drawing my tongue across the smooth skin. She moaned, lifting her hips into my face. I pressed her down with a palm against her bare mound and worked her clit with my thumb. She wriggled harder against me, twisting naked in my bed.

The louder Nicole moaned, the harder I worked her. My jaw and tongue ached, but still I ate her, driving home that I was the very best. She crested and came, pressing her hand against her forehead and squeezing her eyes shut.

"Wow, that's so good," she sighed as I rose up over her. She touched my chest, scratching her fingernails through the dark curls on my upper body. "Your body's so hard."

"In all kinds of ways," I said as I pressed my cock against her pussy.

Nicole rolled her eyes, her laugh shifting into a moan as I entered her. She was wet and tight and amazingly smooth. How many other men had been here? How many other men had felt her slippery embrace?

The questions spurred the predator inside of me again. I took her hands in mine and pinned them to the mattress, high above her head. Her eyes went wide with surprise, meeting mine as I began to fuck her hard. When

she didn't object, I bent down and kissed her through the thrusts. She melted into me, her fingers tightening in my own.

As I fucked her, I couldn't shake the thought of her doing this same thing with others, with the image of her pressing her fingers against another man and saying, *Your body is so hard*.

She stretched beneath me, opening her legs and spurring me on with her cries. Cries that other men had heard? Cries that other men had elicited?

"Oh, Nic!" I grunted as the world blurred.

"Fuck me, baby. Fuck me hard."

Behind my closed eyes, I saw her with Mason Mann, the two of them alone at his Mt. Rainier cabin, stretched out just like this, fucking each other just like this. The good doctor had felt her soft tits press against his chest. He'd felt her clean shaven pussy swallow up his driving cock. He'd kissed her mouth. He'd made her come.

"Ethan! Ah!"

I kissed her through her moans, her gasps, her cries, until she couldn't take it anymore and turned away.

"I want to feel you." Her voice was tight and high, a plea that I could imagine directed at Mason. "Come, baby. I want to feel you fill me."

I want to feel you fill me, Mason.

I exploded, white hot and bottomless. I drove hard and deep, sinking my toes into the mattress. I gave everything to the moment, the fantasy boiling away until all that was left was pure, eroticized jealousy, like the purest, most dangerous drug I'd ever tasted.

I fell into her, gasping and spent. Sex with Fiona had been amazing, but what I'd just experienced was the most erotic thing in my life.

We were covered in sweat, our naked bodies sliding together as we shifted into a spoon.

"Don't think I've had this much fun on a Friday night in a while," I said. "Definitely not while living here."

Nicole laughed softly. "That's kind of sad for you."

My heart skipped. Did she just imply that hers were more fun?

"You'll just need to stay here, I'm afraid."

Nicole nuzzled back into me. "I think Gracie will be sad when one of her bridesmaids doesn't show up."

"So a wedding, huh? I don't think I remember Gracie."

“She was the nurse who trained me when I first got there. Bubbly Asian woman? Maybe shorter than five feet?”

Maybe I could recall someone like that, but I couldn't remember. It spoke volumes of who I was when we were married, and I felt bad for that. Nicole could probably name everyone that I worked with at the time.

“So who's your date?” The question just spilled out before I could stop it.

Nicole took an extra second to answer, and I wondered what it was she had to consider. “Fiona, I guess. At least I hear she puts out.”

She wiggled her ass against me suggestively. I winced. “Sorry again.”

Nicole twisted in my arms until we were both on our sides, facing one another. “You ever think this is where we'd end up, way back when you sat down next to me on that plane?”

“Of course not.”

“Life's strange, isn't it? This guy that Gracie is marrying, she met him in the ER after he'd been in an accident.”

“I bet that happens a lot.”

“Yeah, it does,” Nicole said. I hadn't considered that possibility. I studied her, trying to puzzle out whether she'd met anyone that way. I could almost imagine what it would be like for a patient in the hospital to be attended to by a woman who looked like Nicole. She went on before I could get deeper. “But this guy, he was married at the time. Was traveling out of Seattle, doing a wine tour, when his tour van was hit. He almost died. Made him reassess his life.”

I followed where this was headed. “So he fell in love with his nurse, left his wife, and now here you are celebrating his second marriage?”

“That would be too easy.” She touched my face, looking sad. “His wife was also in the tour van. She didn't make it.”

I didn't know what to say, so I tried humor. “Thanks for killing the mood.”

Nicole shook her head. “I didn't mean it like that. I mean, it's very sad, but...you should see them now. He's happy, and Gracie is happy, and neither of them could have predicted that they'd be out here now, getting married.” She kissed me. “They're making the most of life. It's...inspirational.”

It was, and this time, when no words came, I didn't force it. Fortunately, Nicole came with the humor this time.

She rubbed her nose against mine and said, "So that's why you can't keep me as a sex slave in your apartment."

I laughed, and she laughed, and it felt good. I almost told her that I loved her. I wanted to, but I hesitated a fraction of a second and suddenly couldn't.

"So when do you head back?" I said instead.

"Sunday at noon."

"Ah."

She smiled. "Aw, don't be like that. We still have tonight. And if you're up for it, I can probably get back here after the wedding reception."

I wanted that, but a darker thought worked its way through me, settling in between my legs. "No, you don't have to do that. Stay, have fun with your friends. I'll be back in your area in a couple weeks."

Stay and have fun. Flirt with other guys. Be single. I was hard again, just imagining what might be.

When I refocused on Nicole, she was studying me closely. Did she have any idea what I was thinking? There was no way. I was only coming to understand my fantasy now. But I flushed like she could.

"Okay," she said, although she didn't sound certain. Had I said the wrong thing? Should I have insisted she come over for late night sex? Probably. Then, she seemed to let it go. "Someone needs to keep an eye on Fiona. That girl can get herself into a lot of trouble."

"Send me pics when she does."

She slapped me light on the shoulder. "You'd like that, wouldn't you?"

"Better if she got into trouble with you."

Nicole laughed, but was that an extra twinkle in her eye? "Every man's fantasy, right?" She leaned in and kissed me sweetly. "She's hot. You know I can't really hold it against you."

My eyes must have flown open, because Nicole actually giggled. "Ready for round two? Or do you want to think a little more about me and Fiona stripping out of our bridesmaids dresses?"

Her hand slid in between us and found my cock hard. That seemed to please her.

She stroked my cock, running her soft hands up and down my length. "You like thinking about that, don't you? You like thinking about our lips slowly coming together, touching for the first time. Her tongue would press

against my mouth. I'd resist...for a moment. And then I'd give in, parting my lips, accepting her wet, playful tongue with my own..."

I groaned. It was such a sexy image, but that wasn't what got my blood pumping so hard. What got me going was that Nicole was teasing me with this idea at all. She was caressing me with her words as much as her hand.

"She has nice breasts," Nicole said. "Don't you think?"

"Yours are better." It was true, but I was so turned on it came out as almost a squeak. I cleared my throat and tried again. "Yours are so perfect, I bet Fiona wouldn't be able to resist doing this."

I leaned in and ran my tongue along the swell of her tits, teasing out the hard tip of her nipple. Nicole shivered. I knew she was just playing with me, but two could play this game.

"I can see it now. You two, tipsy from the reception, stumbling into your hotel room. One thing leads to another, and your dresses are on the floor and Fiona's lips..." I kissed her other nipple. "...are all over these beautiful swells..."

I pressed my hand down between her legs.

"And her fingers..." I continued, pressing my fingertips against the opening of her sex. "...find your pussy nice and wet."

"Oh, Ethan," she moaned.

"Fiona," I whisper.

She shook her head. "Right now, I need Ethan." She pushed me onto my back and mounted me. "But I will make you a deal. If I end up falling into bed with Fiona tomorrow night, I'll make sure to send you pictures."

With that, she lowered her hips and took me back inside of her.

"You wouldn't really, would you?" I asked.

"What? Fall into bed with Fiona? Or take pictures of it?" Nicole asked coyly.

I held her hips and lifted my knees as she began to ride me. "You're such a tease, Nicole."

"And you love it."

"I do." *And I love you.* I quashed that thought by throwing myself into the sex. She may have been riding me, but I was determined to take control. I held her hips and helped her bounce on me, thrusting up each time she came down. My arms began to burn, but we found a rhythm that I didn't want to stop.

I watched her over me. Her eyes were closed, her head pitched slightly to one side. Her hair partially escaped her ponytail, falling damp and messy across her face. It was still shorter than I was used to, but I liked it. It fit the new her.

The new her who fucked other men.

The new her who teased me with a lesbian fantasy.

The new her who flew all the way out to DC and showed up on my doorstep on her first day.

There was something there. Something important. But I couldn't grasp it. Not anymore. I felt it all slipping away, replaced by the roar of my orgasm that came from somewhere deep.

"Ah, Nicole," I gasped.

"Ethan," she said, her breath equally short. "Ethan!"

"Yes, Nicole. Yes!"

We came together, still hard, still intense, but more tender than our first. She arched over me, leaning back until she could grab my ankles and thrust her tits high. Then, shifting, she bent the other way until our foreheads touched and she breathed the last of her orgasm into a deep, soft kiss.

When I opened my eyes, she did, too. We were no more than an inch away from one another, and even though I couldn't see her lips, I knew she was smiling.

"So how much of that was true?" I asked.

"Truthfully? I don't think I could sleep with another woman."

I knew that, but still felt disappointment. "Didn't think so."

"But the other part? The one about the pictures? That could be sexy." She pulled back enough that I could see the red flood her cheeks.

"Really?" I asked. We'd never done something like that—take photos, record us having sex.

"I mean, it could be hot. I guess," she said, glancing away, biting her lip, then looking back at me.

"I think it's a hot idea." I kissed her.

"Another time, then," she said, then crawled off of me and headed into the bathroom.

I laid back in my own bed, staring at the ceiling that I'd become so familiar with over the last year and a half. I'd spent many a sleepless night in this bed. At first, when I'd come to DC, I'd wondered what I was doing

in this strange city with a wife at home and no friends to speak of. Lately, I'd started thinking about Nicole again, only this time, in a very different way. Now here she was, in my bathroom, in my space, and it was amazing.

When she emerged, I was disappointed to see that she'd dressed. When had she grabbed her things?

"Going so soon?" I asked.

"I've got a bridal breakfast tomorrow, then a morning full of makeup," she said. "Plus, I don't think Gracie will want one of her bridesmaids falling asleep at the altar."

"Probably not."

Nicole came over to me and sat at the edge of the bed. "I had fun tonight." She looked around at my place. "You've got a nice apartment here. It suits you."

"Thanks."

"Think about what I said, Ethan. Make the most of what you've got here. I don't want to tell you to live in the moment, but...live in the moment. You never know what life will throw at you next. This is what we've got, right here, right now."

"Oh...kay." How did this get so philosophical.

Nicole laughed, leaned down, and kissed me one last time. "And if I do end up hooking up with Fiona tomorrow night, I'll definitely send you pics."

"Have fun tomorrow."

"I will. Good night, Ethan."

I watched her leave, listening to the front door open and close. Even then, I kept lying there, staring up at the ceiling. *Live in the moment*, she said. Is that what she's been doing? I suppose she was, and I was happy for her.

At last, I dragged myself out of bed and into the bathroom to brush my teeth and get ready for bed. Walking into the bathroom, I noticed that the medicine cabinet was open just a crack. Instinctively, I went to close it when something stopped me. Why was it even open?

I saw myself in the reflection, smiling, happy, punch drunk on sex. I would have preferred it if Nicole had stayed with me all night—and then for the rest of our lives—but she was right, we had only these moments. We needed to make sure we lived them when we can.

Pulling open the medicine door, that's when I saw what Nicole must have seen. Sitting on the second shelf was Cate's old makeup kit. She'd left it here when she used to stay over, and after we broke up—months ago—she'd never asked for it back. I'm not sure why I kept it at all, but I had.

And now Nicole thought that I was seeing someone else.

So that's what her comment was all about.

Slowly, I shut the medicine cabinet door. That smiling, happy guy was gone. In his place, someone who'd realized he'd just run over the neighbor's family pet. I wanted to text her right away, to explain...to explain what? That it was an old girlfriend's? A girlfriend that I'd never told her about?

"Fuck," I swore. I ground my teeth, made a fist, and pounded the porcelain countertop of my sink. My knuckles came away red and raw.

Thing was, Nicole didn't leave upset or angry or even jealous. She'd come out and told me that she'd had fun. She'd kissed me. And she'd told me to live my life.

I was very confused.

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wedding party

When I grew up, my parents raised me as a devout Presbyterian. Well, as devout as Presbyterians got. We went to church every Sunday, and observed Holy Days. I went to Sunday School when I was a kid. I was baptized, went through confirmation, all that stuff. It was no where near what Nicole and her Catholic family believed, but it was enough that we'd bonded over it.

When I went to college, though, I stopped going to church, and eventually stopped believing all together. I consider myself a spiritual man, rather than a religious one, and I'm pretty sure that my parents know this about me. They love me, they're proud of me, and we get along great, but we don't talk about religion anymore. That I've lost my faith goes unspoken, and because it is, it's not a problem.

In a way, I wondered if that's what Nicole was offering me, too. She thought I was seeing someone enough that that someone left her makeup in my bathroom. She didn't say anything about it. She never accused me of cheating. She just hadn't said anything...and because of that, maybe it wasn't a problem.

Or maybe, she hadn't touched the medicine cabinet at all, and it had just been open the last time I was in there.

Either way, it was done, and I couldn't undo it, one way or another. I also wasn't about to make the mistake of calling her up and trying to explain the truth. For one, if she hadn't seen the makeup, then now she would. For another, in order to explain to her that I was no longer seeing Cate, and I'd have to explain that I'd seen her in the first place, and I didn't want to go there. So, like my estrangement from the Presbyterian Church, I said nothing.

I wanted to offer her the same respect, but of course I already knew too much. I knew for a fact that she'd "stopped going to church." I couldn't unlearn it, and I didn't want to. Not with my fantasy. Not anymore.

Nicole posted photos on Facebook and Instagram during the wedding preparation. I had a few things to do at the office—even on a Saturday—but not enough to keep me off of social media.

Early, there were photos of the bridesmaids gathered around a table drinking mimosas. When I saw her, I recognized Gracie, although I

remembered her for her thick, plastic rimmed glasses, which she no longer wore. In addition to Fiona and Nicole, Gracie had four other bridesmaids. Six bridesmaids total, plus the bride. I wondered how large this wedding was going to be.

The next few photos to come in were from the hair and makeup portion of the morning and early afternoon. They were mostly selfies of Nicole with her golden hair in curlers, sitting in a chair with a white robe on. She always looked like she was on the verge of laughter, and that made me smile.

Over the day, I watched her transform from the pretty girl-next-door who'd shown up on my doorstep last night in a hoodie, to a glammed up supermodel, the likes of which I hadn't met even on our own wedding day. When had she grown so sophisticated?

The bridesmaids' dresses helped. The long, flowy strapless dresses would have made a woman in clown makeup look elegant, and these were soft pink, a color that looked naturally good on Nicole. The hair and makeup certainly lent to the transformation—lips painted a slightly darker shade of soft pink, dark mascara, kohl eyeliner, pinkish eyeshadow. Even her brows looked lined somehow, manicured into perfect arches.

I actually preferred the woman who'd come over last night. She was much more real. But as a fantasy, bridesmaid Nicole was amazing.

She posted a photo of herself pulling the hem of the long dress up to reveal her feet and the ridiculously tall heels she wore. Again, not a style I associated with Nicole, but one that was hot because of that.

Then were the photos of the bridesmaids out and about around the city, posing in front of monuments and parks. These weren't the professional photos, of course, but photos of the photographer taking photos of them. Still, it looked like the group was having fun together. I did notice a champagne glass being held in more than a few of them.

I lived the day with her vicariously, getting excited for the potential of the night every time there was a photo of Fiona and Nicole on the feed. She'd been teasing me, of course, but it was a sexy thought regardless. She'd teased me, after all, and she'd also had her eyes shut as I'd sucked her breasts and teased her back. Maybe, if everything lined up just right...

I had to laugh. How different was this from a couple years ago, when Nicole and I had settled into a rut and barely had sex once a month. Here I

was, wondering how plausible it was that she'd hook up with another woman.

There was a lull in the photos during the actual wedding, which was at 5 o'clock. From the few I did see, though, it was a huge affair, worthy of the large wedding party. I didn't recognize the church, but it was filled to capacity. There were a few photos of the bride and groom kissing, looking happy, even a short video of them leaving the church as bubbles fluttered around them.

I pressed play, hearing Nicole laugh as she followed the new couple along the walkway. That made me smile. Opposite them, everyone seemed to be blowing bubbles and clapping. In the very last frame, after the couple got into the limo and the moment had passed, Nicole shifted the camera before hitting end. It was jarring. It froze. And in that final frame, I saw the man at her side—Mason Mann.

I watched it again and again, that last frame hitting me like a sucker punch each and every time. I mean, it could have meant nothing. Probably did. He was wearing a tux with a brocaded vest that matched the bridesmaid dresses, which meant he was probably a groomsman.

The idea that he could be Nicole's date, though, was too white hot for me not to consider. She hadn't asked me to go with her, despite being in my area. She hadn't even told me that she was visiting until she was here. Was yesterday's visit a spontaneous one, when she realized that she had an evening open? Maybe Mason had flown in this morning rather than yesterday, thus freeing up her night for me. He was a doctor, after all, with a demanding schedule that could have meant that he couldn't make it until the day of...

I paid an obsessive amount of attention to the feeds after that. I even started checking Fiona's just for a new perspective, searching for Nicole with Mason. My heart rate seemed stuck at a blistering pace, and I was hard enough that I had to call it a day and go home before someone noticed.

The reception looked as elegant and expensive as the rest of the wedding. It wasn't at a traditional reception venue, but it looked more like they'd rented out a restaurant. In the background, large windows looked out over the Potomac River, where the sun was setting, silhouetting the triangular shapes of moored sailboats.

I knew where this was. The Congressman had held a fundraiser here. It was across the river in Virginia, in Old Town. It specialized in receptions

like this with a large, private space that could be rented out without having to close the rest of the restaurant to the public.

That's when the idea hit me like lightning. It was a bad idea. A really, really bad idea.

I couldn't stop myself. I was already changing into something dressier. I was going to crash this wedding.

*

This was one of few times that I wished I had a car. This was a precision operation. I needed to be able to get in and out without being seen, because if I was recognized, I had no plausible excuse to be there. It wasn't close to my house, I'd be alone, and my wife was potentially there with another man.

"Jesus," I muttered under my breath. My heart continued to pound like it was determined to break through my ribcage.

"What's that, man?" the cab driver asked in front of me.

"Sorry, nothing. Just...thinking." Thinking that I should tell him to turn around and bring me home. I kept silent after that.

Old Town Alexandria was quaint in an East Coast way with its brick-lined streets and historic storefronts. On a Saturday night, it was bustling. Gracie had lucked out on the weather, and it was mild enough that a jacket wasn't required beyond my sport coat.

The restaurant, the Moorings, was on the water just off the main street. The restaurant was crowded with a long wait list, but the bar was open enough for me to find a spot. This worked out perfectly for me, though, because the bar gave me a better view into the private side of the restaurant.

The entrance to the Moorings was on the second story—which was the original building. The tables up here were intimate, placed along the windows with views of the river. The bar was up here as well, along with the portion of the restaurant that was open to those with reservations.

The addition more than doubled the size of the restaurant. One of the walls had been completely removed, and the new portion vaulted high and open all along the river. The bar, a glass partition, and a short flight of stairs separated the two spaces, but if I sat in just the right spot, I could see through the back of the bar and down into the wedding reception.

I scanned the bar, making sure that none of the guests had spilled up here. I didn't think any had—at least no one I recognized—so I settled in and ordered a beer, then changed my mind to a bourbon. It was that kind of night.

The bridesmaids were easy to spot. The wedding party was all sitting together at a head table, which I had a pretty clear view of. Nicole was sitting near the end, laughing at something that Fiona said to her. The seat beside her was currently empty.

It looked like they'd just finished the meal. The bride and groom were making their way to the dance floor and the band—a band, not a DJ—was beginning to play a jazzy version of *It Had to Be You*.

The chatter died down as the couple started their first dance. I watched them spin and sway, weaving in and out of visibility behind the bottles of liquor and spirits that lined the back of the bar.

It all made me think of my own wedding, and how magical that night had been. I remember thinking, *This is it. From here on out, I now have a partner in life.*

When I looked back downstairs, the wedding party was on their feet, going to join the couple on the parquet floor. They coupled up naturally, like it had been prearranged. I couldn't see who Nicole was with until I did. Of course it was Mason Mann sweeping her into his arms and pulling her against his tall body.

I sucked in sharply, so much that the bartender looked over at me, checking my glass. "Another?" he asked.

"Sure, why not."

I waited for him to turn and reach for the bottle before looking back down at the wedding party. Mason was dancing with Nicole, holding her close as they swayed to the sweet, romantic music. The band didn't have a singer, but I heard the words to the famous song anyway.

It had to be you

It had to be you

I wandered around, and finally found the somebody who

Could make me be blue

Could make me be true

And even be glad, just to be sad, thinking of you...

I felt those lyrics in my soul, pushing me down at the corners, at the edges, until I was all bent lines. It was true. All of it. Nicole was the one, her, and I was happy thinking of her, even when it made me sad—especially when it made me jealous. And looking down there, watching her stare up into Mason's eyes, as blue as her own, I was...happy for her.

I knew I was witnessing a moment, and I was powerless to stop it.

No, not powerless. I could have done something. I could have walked down there, made a scene, fought for her like she was a prize to be won. But that wasn't fair. This was no more the time to fight than she was an object to fight over. After all...

For nobody else, gave me a thrill - with all your faults, I love you still

It had to be you, wonderful you

It had to be you...

The song ended, transitioning into something faster, peppier. The bride invited the rest of the onlookers onto the floor, and the couples broke up, including Mason and Nicole. I did watch them closely, though, and definitely caught Fiona whisper something into Nicole's ear that made my wife blush and bite her lip.

I should have left. Any other sane man would have. But this was an opportunity that may never come around again, and the part of me with the fantasy Fiona had given light to was just too enraptured to leave. I wondered if this is how moths felt when approaching a flame.

I ended up ordering a meal at the bar, because as little an appetite as I had, throwing back whiskey on an empty stomach while watching my ex-wife flirt with another man was a sure fire way to get into trouble.

And they really did flirt. Until this moment, whenever I'd imagined Nicole with another man, it had been in a sexual way—tearing their clothes off, kissing, fingering, fucking. Thing was, watching Nicole laugh at something Mason said as she reached out and touched his arm was so much more erotic than imagining her on her knees, sucking his cock. I can't explain it, and it probably did have something to do with seeing it versus thinking it, but the non-verbal connection they had did intense things to my insides.

Towards the end of the evening, they moved outside, onto the wide patio that looked out over the water. The older part of the restaurant had a

similar patio, only about a half story up. And right now, it was empty.

“Can I take my drink out there? I need some fresh air.”

“Sure thing,” the bartender said. “You finished with your dinner?”

I’d had about half of it, but my stomach was too raw to try for more.

“Yeah, I’m done.”

“Cool. I’ll just clear it away for you.”

“Thanks, man.” I was already out of my seat and headed for the deck myself.

The first thing I heard, upon stepping out into the cool night air, was Nicole’s laughter. “Oh, stop,” she said.

Mason laughed with her. I heard the metal clink of a lighter. “I’m serious. This is one of the best nights of my life.” I heard the rough brush of flint on metal, followed shortly by the smell of cigarette smoke.

I could hear the embarrassment in her voice when Nicole said, “Gracie looks so happy.”

“Yeah, they’re great together, aren’t they?” Mason said.

I heard the scratch of the lighter again. That puzzled me. Against my better judgement, I moved closer to the side-railing and peeked over the edge. Nicole was resting her arms on balustrade, staring out over the river. She had a glass of wine in one hand, and was just pulling her cigarette away from her lips.

“I’m going to regret this in the morning,” she said, looking at the cigarette.

Mason was leaning with his back against the railing, right next to her. “Hey, you took it from me,” he protested with a laugh.

She turned her head to him, smiling. Her hair had been done up elaborately, and a couple coils had been left free to fall around her face. In this setting, under the glow of the moon against the water, she looked as close to a princess as I’d ever seen her—minus the cigarette.

And I wasn’t her prince.

“I couldn’t resist. Not tonight, with the drinking and the party and the celebration. This feels like college.”

Mason put his hand on the small of her back, half turning to her. “You smoked cigarettes back in college?”

“Socially, I guess. And only when I was drinking.”

I didn’t know that. But I also didn’t know her in her undergrad years, when we got all of that out of our system.

“I bet you were fun back then.”

Nicole laughed quickly. “Implying that I’m not fun now?”

“You know that’s not what I meant,” Mason said. It sounded like this wasn’t the first time they’d had this kind of playful banter. “Just that it would be nice to have known you back then. Before...life.”

Before me?

He turned fully toward her, and I saw exactly what he was doing. He was about to make his move; and all I could do was stand there and watch, sporting the most uncomfortable erection I’d ever had.

Nicole took another drag on her cigarette. Why was that so sexy? “Well, you should know that I was a big nerd back then. And kind of a wallflower.”

Mason laughed. “Now I know you’re messing with me.”

Nicole stood up off the rail, laughing with him. “I’m serious! I stayed with my high school boyfriend all through Freshman year. Who does that? Trust me, Mason, I’m a lot more fun now.”

Mason was close to her, and when he spoke, I could just barely hear it. “Which is why tonight really is one of the best nights of my life.”

My heart raced. I stared as they stared into one another’s eyes.

At last, Nicole spoke, although her intended playfulness didn’t make it into her words. “You’re just trying to get into my panties.”

From the base of my cock all the way up through my body, I tensed. I heard the words. I watched their lips. I read the body language. I knew what came next, and it tore me in two. I felt her slipping away from me, but I didn’t want to stop it.

“No,” Mason whispered. “That’s just a happy side effect.”

And then, because this was really happening, I watched their lips come together. Nicole smiled unconsciously as she accepted him. When he pressed harder, she accepted that, too, taking his tongue deep into her mouth as she explored him with her own. He pinned her to the railing over the water, kissing her like a fucking romance hero.

Only it wasn’t my romance.

And I’d never been so thoroughly, deeply turned on.

When their kiss ended, neither of them was in a rush to separate. They stayed close, holding one another, staring at one another. Even in her ridiculous heels, Nicole looked short next to the tall stature of Mason Mann.

He whispered something that I couldn't hear, but made her blush. She nodded, said: "Let me just go around and say goodnight to everyone."

He kissed her again. "I'll meet you back in the room then."

I gasped, but luckily they were so into each other that they didn't hear.

"Leave the tux on, please," she said, playfulness back in her voice. She touched his tie and looked up at him. I had the sudden, vivid image of her on her knees, taking his cock out. She said, "It's very sexy."

I looked away. She was right, it *was* very sexy. I finished off my drink and turned away, heading back into the restaurant. "Enough," I said to myself. It was time to move on.

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the graveyard shift

I was a wreck right after the wedding. It's kind of funny, but I hadn't mourned the end of my marriage when I'd first moved out to DC, or even when we'd agreed upon a trial separation. Guess that says something poorly about me, but I'd been so caught up in all the new things I was seeing and experiencing here, and Nicole and life in Hempstead seemed so far away.

But after the wedding, almost a year and a half after I'd moved out here, I finally heard the death knell. All I needed to do was close my eyes and see Nicole kiss Mason, and I knew that whatever we'd had before, we didn't have now.

I even called up my lawyer to draw up divorce papers, but I didn't send them. I recognized the act of self-pity for what it was. I wanted to feel sorry for myself, so holding the official documents of The End while drinking straight from a bottle of bourbon satisfied it. I know, I needed to talk to someone, but I had no one.

So instead, I pretended like nothing had changed. Like I hadn't gone to spy on Nicole at the wedding. Like I didn't know she'd agreed to meet Dr. Mason Mann in his hotel room.

Well, maybe that wasn't quite right. Deep down, I thought a lot about that moment. I relived it. I obsessed over it. And as crazy as it seemed, it made me want Nicole more.

When I visited Hempstead again, three weeks later, I texted her. I didn't even consider not texting her. I'd been doing everything that I could *not* to think about what must have happened between Mason and Nicole in that hotel room that I was wound up and ready to snap.

[Me]: I'll be out your way next week. Want to get together?

I didn't get an immediate response. In fact, I didn't get a response from her for an entire day—long enough that I started assigning all kinds of reasons for her non-response. Was she with Mason, spending the day naked in his bed? Was she bored with me? Or more frightening, had things progressed enough with Mason that she wanted something more exclusive?

I finally got a response the next morning.

[Nicole]: Sorry, busy day yesterday. Just got this. I think I can get away. What days?

After all the paranoia, her seemingly upbeat response caught me by surprise. Her follow-up text was even more confusing.

[Nicole]: And if not me, then I'm sure Fiona can get away. She keeps asking me for a repeat, like I'm keeping your sex calendar or something. LOL

It was supposed to be funny. I wanted to laugh, and be thankful that she was treating this whole thing so casually, but...but then I thought about how she'd looked into Mason's eyes at the wedding, at all the emotion that had passed between them, and realized that as much fun as I'd had with Nicole, I wanted more. I wanted that.

But saying all that over text wasn't right. So instead, I went with a joke.

[Me]: Great. I'll be there next Thursday through Sunday. And you could always invite Fiona along. ;)

[Nicole]: Keep dreaming, buddy. Let's do Saturday evening. I work the night shift, but have no plans until 10:30.

I didn't know what to expect leading up to Saturday night. I wanted it to be like any of the other hookups we'd had over the last couple months. It wasn't serious, we were just two friends having a good time. Nothing more.

But it was *more* than that now. I wanted more.

*

"You like that, Ethan?"

"Yes," I said, short on breath and close to coming.

"You like fucking my tits?"

She stared up at me from the floor of the shower stall. She held her soft breasts around my cock, rubbing them up and down my length with the aid of soap and my excitement. It was amazing, but even sexier was the fact that she'd probably done this same thing with Mason. When we'd gotten into the shower—after an initial round of fucking—she'd dropped to her knees, soaped up her tits, and wrapped them around me without asking if I wanted it.

I reached down, intending to caress her cheek. She interpreted the gesture differently, turning to suck on my fingers.

“You’re so naughty,” I said.

“So naughty,” she agreed. “You love it.”

“Get up here, naughty girl.” I pulled her to her feet before she got me off with her big tits. Kissing her, I pressed her against the wall and grabbed her ass. I lifted her, pushing my hips forward. My cock danced across her smoothly shaved pussy. “Isn’t this what you really want?”

She reached between us and positioned my cock against her. “Give it to me.”

I thrust forward, obliging her.

Mason had done this before. Maybe even in this very bathroom. I wondered if he worked late tonight, too. Fiona had said that employees didn’t hook up at the hospital, but I was determined to get her so close that she wouldn’t be able to help herself.

Pinned against the shower wall, hot water spraying us, rivulets washing down our undulating bodies, we fucked. She ran her fingers through my hair—marveling in the difference between me and Mason’s bald head? I fucked her harder, torturing myself with my rivalry. I kissed her neck, working the secret areas that only I knew.

I read her body, backing off when she was close, working harder when she wasn’t. “Please, don’t stop,” she pleaded. “I need to...”

I backed away again, although I knew I wouldn’t be able to last much longer.

“Need to what?” I said.

“Come,” she hissed.

I kissed her, but she was too gone to return it. Her eyes were shut tight and she’d wrapped her arms around my neck so she could bounce hard along my shaft. She was about to come, and if I lost it now, she’d quickly join me.

So instead, before I could think about the consequences, I pulled out of her, set her on the floor of the shower, and shoved my cock into her mouth.

Her eyes flew open a moment before I exploded down her throat. She stared up at me, surprise and frustration turning into something dirtier. I had no idea what it was, but I came a little harder because of it.

“You’re an asshole,” she said, but with a smile.

“You’ve got work really soon, and I didn’t want you to have to clean up again,” I said. “No time.”

“How thoughtful of you,” she said sarcastically.

“You know me, always thoughtful.”

Her smile fell a little at the corners. “Yeah, I do.”

Getting to her feet, she kissed me lightly on the lips.

“In that case, time to get out and let me get ready.” She reached for her shaving gel. “Out, I need space.”

“Okay,” I laughed. “I’ll get you some water.”

“Thanks.”

The last thing I saw before exiting was her lathering the shaving foam beneath her arms and over her pussy. I shuddered, wondering why she needed to touch that up, and then knowing exactly why.

I was dressed and had her water ready for her when she exited the steamy bathroom, a towel wrapped around her.

“I can’t believe you’re going to leave me like this,” she said. As if to prove something to me, she dropped the towel well before going to her dresser and let me drink in her nudity. She looked so clean, from the round teardrops of her buoyant tits that she’d just used on me, to the glossy rise and fall of her freshly shaved mound, to her long, runner-hewn legs.

“I’m sure you can take care of yourself,” I said.

She went into her underwear drawer and stepped into a black g-string. A *g-string*. I’d never seen her in one of those. Okay, she was definitely making a point.

“You’re right,” she said. Her bra came next, lacy, black, and plunging. She turned to show off her body in all its pinup glory. “I can.”

I almost lost my resolve and took her on her dresser. The only thing that stopped me was the thought of her going to work all keyed up and horny, and the off-chance that Mason Mann was also working.

“Your water?”

“Asshole!” She laughed. “Thanks.”

She took a deep gulp of it, stretching her barely clad body for me to admire before handing the empty glass back to me. It was like everything she did was infused with something sexual. Even watching her step into her aqua blue scrubs and watching the g-string disappear from sight made me think of a potential later, when Mason would push the scrubs off and discover the tiny panties.

“Next time, I plan on leaving you with some blue balls,” she promised, giving me a kiss. “Come on, I’ll drive you back to your hotel.”

Back in my hotel, I couldn’t sleep. I kept tossing and turning, thinking about what could be happening at the hospital. I even came up with this harebrained scheme to check myself in at the ER on the off-chance that I’d see...something.

Instead, I did something almost as stupid. I texted Fiona.

[Me]: If I asked you something, could you keep it between the two of us?

She responded almost immediately.

[Fiona]: Who is this?

Right, she didn’t have my number. I shouldn’t have had hers, either, but I’d kept it after our one-night stand. “And why did you do that, Ethan?” I asked myself. In truth, the answer had less to do with a Fiona booty call and more to do with what I was doing right now.

I should have just left it at that. I could have ignored the question, deleted her number, and she would have just figured it was a wrong number. I didn’t do that.

[Me]: Ethan.

[Fiona]: Well, hellllo there. What do you want to ask me? :)

Yea, this was definitely a bad idea.

[Me]: I was wondering if Mason Mann was working tonight.

It was hard to send that message, but my curiosity got the better of me.

[Fiona]: ...

[Fiona]: Not the question I thought you were going to ask.

Oh, shit, she thought I was calling her to play.

[Me]: Sorry. Nevermind.

I set the phone down, intending to try to sleep some more. I couldn’t, and a minute later, Fiona wouldn’t let me, either.

[Fiona]: As a matter of fact, he is. And, you know what? Nicole’s also here.

Oh, great, she was there, too. I had one panicked moment where I imagined Fiona showing these texts to Nicole.

I didn't pick up the phone. Just stared down at it on my nightstand, keeping my distance like it was a snake.

[Fiona]: Good night to pick the graveyard shift. I'll keep a special eye on them. Want me to keep you updated?

I didn't, but I did.

But I didn't.

[Fiona]: That's okay, you don't have to say anything. I'm going to send you updates anyway. ;)

I groaned, but was secretly happy. I switched my phone's volume to on—as if I was going to get any sleep—and got ready for bed.

I buzzed with nervous energy, like I'd polished off a pot of coffee on an empty stomach. My teeth chattered as I rinsed the toothpaste out of my mouth, and my stomach teetered on the edge of nausea. I was nervous, yes, but more than that, I was excited by all the anticipation. To the point where I could barely think.

I felt disappointed when I checked my phone and found no more messages, then worried that maybe Fiona had given up on me since I'd never responded. I picked it up, began to type something to prompt her, then stopped myself.

If she wanted to tease me, then so be it. If not...then maybe I wasn't meant to know.

Luckily, Fiona wanted to tease me. An agonizing hour later, she sent a cryptic message my way.

[Fiona]: Quiet night. Not much to do but sit around and talk...

When I didn't bite, she sent me another.

[Fiona]: And Nicole and Dr. Mann have been doing a lot of...talking.

I groaned. I'd been trying to do work, but nothing was sinking in. I stopped all together and picked up my phone. A photo came through as I did, and I nearly dropped it.

It was innocent enough—taken from behind the nursing desk at the hospital, where Nicole and Mason Mann were sitting side by side. Nicole

had her head resting on her arm, which was propped up on the desk. She was smiling, enjoying whatever it was that Mason was in the middle of telling her. She looked sleepy, but beautiful.

[Fiona]: Make you jealous?

I relented.

[Me]: No.

It was easier to lie over text.

[Fiona]: Excited then.

She didn't attach a question mark to the message—not that I would have answered it anyway.

I waited another half hour before receiving my next text. I was more on edge now than I had been while waiting for the votes to be counted in March's primary. Talk about pins and needles.

[Fiona]: She just asked me to cover for her. Says she needs to lie down, and I haven't seen the good doctor around for a while now. I stalled. What should I tell her?

The only reason that Fiona would be asking this of me is if "lie down" was code for "sneaking away and fuck her boyfriend." Fiona was giving me an opportunity to intervene, if only indirectly. She probably also knew what kind of sweet cruelty that was for me.

[Me]: Tell her whatever you want.

[Fiona]: Fine. Telling her I'll cover and to take all the time she needs. :P

I got out of bed and went to the portable coffee machine. If I was going to feel this jittery, I might as well actually benefit from the caffeine.

[Me]: Has she asked you to cover for her before?

Fiona's response didn't come for another five minutes. I imagined her talking with Nicole, telling her that she'd cover for her, watching my wife blush and avert her eyes under Fiona's knowing smile.

[Fiona]: At the hospital? This is a first. I told you, this kind of thing doesn't normally happen. At least not with Nicole.

Meaning that leaving her in her state of arousal had made her reckless. I felt bad for that, but it paled in comparison to how excited I was.

[Fiona]: I have covered a shift or two for her, though. I believe you were the reason for one of them.

But not all, I thought, filling in the blanks.

[Fiona]: But if you're asking me if this is the first time she's fucked Mason... well, I think you know that it's not. You wouldn't have texted me asking specifically for him, would you? As discrete as those two have been, he's definitely her go-to fuck buddy.

Oh, God... She seemed to know exactly what to say to get me. It was uncanny. And relentless.

[Fiona]: But at work, she's usually so professional. Something must have gotten her worked up...

I could practically see her mind work through the problem.

[Fiona]: It was you! Tell me you two were together before she came on her shift. Please, please, please!

My heart fluttered. I typed.

[Me]: It's possible...

[Fiona]: Wow! Nicole with two guys in one night! I'm so proud of her.

[Me]: You're a terrible influence on your friends, you know that?

[Fiona]: Am not. I have a high emotional IQ, and this side of Nicole has been dying to get out.

What have I just done?

[Fiona]: God, this is making me horny. When do you leave?

[Me]: No, Fiona. We're not going there.

I was proud of myself for turning her down, and happy that I could do it via text message. I was in a fragile state at the moment. I wouldn't have been a hard conquest. As it was, she didn't make it easier.

[Fiona]: Invite me over and I'll tell you a story.

I felt like I was making a deal with a devil, and she made it so hard to resist. Especially when she sent me a photo with the caption: *It involves*

this.

The photo was dark, and at first, I wasn't sure what I was looking at. It was something indoors, in a bar or club. People on a dance floor, women in short dresses and guys in collared shirts and designer jeans. I looked closer, seeing what I was meant to see—Mason holding Nicole, who wore a short and tight black dress, their heads pressed together, eyes devouring one another in that moment that came just before their passion boiled over. The next frame would have been them kissing.

[Fiona]: I can be there at six in the morning. Tell me what your room number is and I'll show you some more photos from that night.

I wanted to. I almost did. If she could have come over immediately, I probably would have made the big mistake. The delayed gratification saved me.

[Me]: I don't think so. Keep your photos.

[Fiona]: Party pooper. Fine, no photos for you.

[Fiona]: But I did find out where they're shacked up. How about some audio?

The next message came with an audio clip. I'd never received an audio clip before, and now that I had, I wasn't sure what to do. My finger hovered over the screen, half worried that I'd delete it by accident, half worried I'd have a heart attack once I heard it.

I grabbed my headphone first, plugged them in, and hit play.

The first thing I heard was the sound of heavy breathing. A woman's breathing. And a man's. Then a moan, quickly stifled, but clearly Nicole's.

"Oh, yes..." Nicole whispered, her breath catching in a gasp.

I gasped right along with her. They sounded so close. I wondered how the hell Fiona got this. How close was she?

Louder this time: "Oh, yes. There..." Quiet again. "There..."

I heard kissing, the sound of fabric rubbing. Metal scraped across the floor once, then stopped abruptly. Nicole giggled. So did the man. Mason.

"I can't believe we're doing this at work," she whispered.

"You mean, why haven't we done it sooner?"

"Because it's too dangerous," Nicole said.

Mason chuckled. “Says the woman who went scouting for an empty room as soon as she got on shift.”

“I... couldn’t wait.” She kissed him to cover her embarrassment. Then made me reconsider whether she was embarrassed at all. “I needed to feel your big dick inside of me.”

“You should have come over before we came on. You know where my big dick lives.”

Nicole laughed, forgetting to be quiet for a moment. “I’ll keep that in mind next time. Now let’s stop talking and fuck me.”

The audio ended. I frowned, wanting to hear more.

[Fiona]: Had to get out of there. She started looking around. But I think it’s pretty good, isn’t it?

[Me]: You did well.

[Fiona]: Reconsider my offer?

[Me]: I’m going to try and sleep some. Thanks for sharing that.

[Fiona]: Hope you have a restless night! :P

[Fiona]: But any time. That was fuuuun!

My eyes hurt. My body was tired. All the excitement and anxiety was catching up to me, and I’d been up way too long. I set my phone on Do Not Disturb, rolled into my bed, and miraculously, I found sleep.

It was, as Fiona had hoped, very restless.

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hiatus

After June, Congress went into an early summer recess that would last until September. Congressman Phillips went home to campaign with his team, and literally ordered his aides to take long vacations.

“I need you all rested and ready for the final push before the election,” he’d explained.

During last summer’s recess, which hadn’t been quite so long, I’d gone to visit my parents. I wasn’t going to do that again. I had no desire to be treated like a college kid home for summer break again. I was turning thirty in October. I was too old to be yelled at by my mother when I slept in too long.

So instead, I decided to take my first European vacation ever. Using my savings and the frequent flier miles I’d accrued, I booked a six-week trip to London and Paris, with no real itinerary. A little sightseeing and city hopping was just what I needed to clear my head of my crazy life.

Before I left, though, I had my lawyer send Nicole the divorce papers. I didn’t blame her for finding someone new. After all, it had been over a year and a half since the separation. I wasn’t upset with her. She’d moved on, and it was time for reality to reflect that.

That’s what the totally logical side of me argued. The side with the wife-sharing fantasy—the one unbound by rational thought—wanted to give her the green light to play. She was doing it already, so I figured she might as well have my tacit blessing.

I know, how noble of me of, right? I realized how self-serving I was being. I did it anyway.

I uninstalled all social media apps, all my email accounts (except for the one I kept for work), and didn’t buy an international SIM card. I cut myself off as much as possible. I wanted to be a tourist and completely unplug.

The trip itself was amazing. Being in London with all of its rich history put a lot of American history and American politics into perspective. I sat in the gallery and watched the UK Parliament debate an issue around farm subsidies. I drank pints in pubs, wandered through Leicester Square, and rode on the top floor of a double decker bus just to experience it.

Of course, as much as I could unplug technologically, I wasn't so successful within my own head. Everywhere I looked seemed to be a reminder of Nicole, or the future that we could have had if I hadn't left. I'd see couples touring the Tower of London together. And young families herding their children across the wide green space of Regent's Park, headed for the zoo. I'd see these things, and wonder if that would have been us.

I also still had my phone, and while it wasn't receiving anything new, there were still plenty of things on it that I should have deleted, but could not.

Like the audio file, and Nicole saying to another man, *I needed to feel your big dick inside of me*. How big was it? I prided myself on being above average, but wouldn't consider myself "big." I listened to her moan as he fucked her, and imagined him packing a pornstar-sized cock that scrambled her brains and made her do things like fuck him at work.

Only no, *I'd* made her do that—indirectly, of course, but if I'd only let her come, then maybe she wouldn't have scouted out an empty room in the middle of the night at the hospital.

On the other hand, she wouldn't have fucked him that night, but she still would have fucked him. After all, he was, according to Fiona, Nicole's "go-to fuck buddy."

I read those texts over, too, reliving the hospital moment over and over again. When I'd woken up, I'd received a few more updates that made me wish that I'd stayed up, but glad that I had not. At least for my sanity.

[Fiona]: Are you still awake?

[Fiona]: I think they're at it again. They both disappeared and I can't find them anywhere.

[Fiona]: Okay, yeah, they did it again. You should see how satisfied she looks. She's very pretty when she's flushed.

[Fiona]: She must really like that big cock of his. Having experienced it, I don't blame her.

[Fiona]: Although TBH, yours felt better. ;)

I wasn't sure if she was trying to make me feel better or not. It was flattering, of course, but it was hard not to feel inadequate in the competition of the man who two women claimed was large.

From what I'd read, that was part of the fantasy. Guys who get off on their wives with other men typically also get excited if those other men had larger cocks. On paper like that, it sounded like something that should have repulsed me, more in the humiliation column than the sexually adventurous one, but I couldn't deny that it turned me on. Not when I got hard each time I listened to Nicole say that she needed to feel Mason's big dick inside of her. It was hot.

At the same time, I didn't want it rubbed in my face. Ever. Fiona came close with her texts. If Nicole had said the same thing—or worse, if Mason had—I don't think I could have spoken to her again.

There was an interesting implication buried in all my European navel-gazing—I imagined a life with Nicole after I returned. I imagined remaining friends with her, and depending on my mood, friends with benefits. And if I was feeling particularly sappy and vulnerable, I could see us finding one another again—not rekindling the old, but forging something new.

Paris was the worst for this. The movies were not wrong to equate this city with romance. It seemed woven into the very fabric of the place—the food, the music, the cute cafes where couples sat outside and held hands. Nicole had wanted to come here for our honeymoon, but we were both facing huge student loans, so we ended up going to Sonoma instead. She would have loved it here. I could just imagine her walking down a boulevard, her blond hair loose and billowing around her, wearing oversized sunglasses and carrying a load of shopping bags. And smiling. And laughing. And having fun.

The longer I stayed in Paris, the more I realized how much I'd lost when we split up. The separation had never felt as real as it did now, and I'd gone ahead and sent her papers that would make it permanent. What the hell was I thinking?

I wasn't. Not with my head. The fantasy was real and it was powerful. Not only that, but I wasn't sure how much I wanted it to stop. She'd fucked Mason Mann only a couple hours after she'd fucked me, and she'd done it *because* of me. I could imagine a life where that kind of thing happened more often, where we shared in it, where she'd come home in the morning and tell me just how naughty she'd been.

Seemed like an unlikely dream, but just a year ago, it would have seemed impossible.

On one of my last nights in Paris, I had dinner in a restaurant in Montmartre that reminded me a lot of the Fig & Pear. The small tables were lit by little tea candles and the place was filled mostly by couples. Someone even proposed to his date about halfway through my meal.

I spent all night thinking about the one date Nicole and I had had after the separation. She'd called it a *first* date, despite all of our history. Date number one "for you and me. Those others? They were shared between different people. That was then. This is now, and that's the best we can do."

She'd said, "That couple didn't work, so why would we want to try to be them again?"

It made me sad, but it also gave me hope. That couple had not worked. Maybe this one would?

When I got back, it was time to find out if it would. Time to lay it all on the line, my feelings for her, my hopes, even my uncomfortable fantasy and the things I'd done to feed its flames.

Little did I know that by the time I got home, it would be too late.

status change

As soon as I touched down on U.S. soil, I turned my phone on and was flooded with all the texts and emails that I'd been avoiding over the last six weeks. It was overwhelming.

Fiona had sent me the most texts, and the last one was alarming enough that I scrolled all the way to the top before the plane had finishing taxiing to our gate.

[Fiona]: Call me if you want to talk about it...

It? What was *it*? I did not like the sound of that.

Scrolling all the way up to the last text I read before I'd left—*Although TBH, yours felt better. ;)*—I skimmed through the string of messages faster than I could process them.

[Fiona]: Divorce? Seriously?

[Fiona]: Hello? You there, asshole?

[Fiona]: Man, you really are an asshole. You send her divorce papers and don't even answer her calls?

[Fiona]: Ethan, you need to call her. She's in a bad place.

[Fiona]: You went to Paris? She must be someone really special.

[Fiona]: Well, can't say you don't deserve this. Not after this last month. You should know that it IS all on you, though. She never would have been this vulnerable had you not left like that.

And finally...

[Fiona]: Call me if you want to talk about it...

Most of the plane had deboarded by the time I looked up from my phone. My heart was racing. My skin crawled.

I had five new voicemails. Two were junk calls. One was from my mom. One from Michael. The last from Nicole. I skipped the first four, listening to the one from my ex-wife.

"Got the divorce papers. Just wanted to talk first. Call me when you get this."

I gathered my bags and made my slow way to the baggage claim, listening to the other voicemails with only half an ear. My mom said she'd heard that things were final and to call her to talk. Michael didn't leave much of a message at all, just gave his name before awkwardly hanging up.

It was Nicole's voicemail that I listened to, trying to glean some knowledge in those three simple sentences. She sounded sad, but not surprised. She didn't yell. She didn't sound relieved or happy. She just sounded...neutral. Painfully neutral.

I walked into my apartment, the musty smell of disuse hitting me like cracking the seal of a tomb. I kicked a note that had been slid under my door, and when I picked it up, my heart ached. I recognized the handwriting immediately. It was Nicole's.

Flew out here, but it looks like you're away. Stupid me, I should have called first. Or at least waited for you to call me back. I wanted to talk to you in person first, to do this right. Sorry that it ended this way, but I guess we both knew that it had to happen some day. Your lawyer will have my signed copies later this week.

I still love you, and always will.

Your ex-wife,

Nicole Meadows

Her maiden name. There was no date. This could have happened the day I'd left, or yesterday. Based on the date of her voicemail, I guessed it was early on.

I neatly folded the note, placed it on my kitchen table, and sat on my sofa in the dark, staring at the black screen of my television. I didn't cry—I don't cry—but my vision grew cloudy with emotion.

At some point, I pulled out my laptop, intending to go through all the emails that had built up. Instead, I found myself on Facebook. Because of my mood, I expected my feed to be filled with sad looking people doing sad things in a sad world.

I was not prepared for the photo of Mason Mann and Nicole at the very top of my newsfeed, a selfie of the two of them at a Mariners game. They were leaning together, wearing matching Mariners jerseys, Mariners hats, and happy smiles. Nicole had her hand wrapped around Mason's arm.

The air went out of my body. I loaded her timeline up, and there, stretched out before me, was my waking nightmare...and my deepest fantasy. I paged through the posts and photos like a flagellant wielding a cat o' nine tails. I couldn't stop.

Mason with his arm draped over Nicole as they held wine glasses before them and toasted the photographer.

Mason holding Nicole as he made a funny face at the camera and she looked up and laughed.

Nicole snuggling up against Mason, wearing an oversized sweatshirt that must have been his.

The two of them skiing together.

The two of them laughing together.

The two of them kissing each other.

Even the innocuous ones cut straight to the bone. Photos of well presented food suggested dates at fancy restaurants. Photos of beautiful sunsets insinuated a couple enjoying them.

I came to the end of the torturous photos—or the beginning. It was dated almost one month ago. The photo was a simple one of Mason Mann in his doctor's scrubs and a white doctor's coat. The caption read: *My man* :)

And before that, a simple status change: *In a relationship with Mason Mann.*

I felt like vomiting. I didn't. Instead, I kept reading.

The posts prior to her status change were a lot more sobering, although a lot more sparse. Most were sad quotes about moving on and starting over. I remember her going through a spout of these when we had first agreed to separate.

It put everything after into perspective. Mason Mann and Nicole were the love story. I was the tragedy. I was just part of the opening credits. I'd been the jerk of a husband who'd left. I'd hurt her, not once, but two times, and in the end, she'd cut me loose.

I just couldn't seem to do the same with her, despite initiating the divorce.

I followed her Facebook and Instagram feeds religiously. I checked Mason's without adding him as a friend. His photo feed was filled with pictures of Nicole—close-ups of her smiling into the camera, shots of her lounging outside on the Hempstead green or in a hot tub at Mason's cabin.

There was even a few of her stretching out on her stomach beside a pool wearing a maroon bikini and the beginnings of a tan.

Mason was proud of his new girlfriend, and while I didn't blame him, I certainly envied him.

I went back into the office, despite Congress being away. A few of the other aides were back from their own personal breaks, including Cate.

After Cate and I broke up last year, things had never been great between us. She was a professional, so never brought it up, but I could feel the tension simmer between us when things quieted down and we didn't have work to fill in the noise.

She'd gone to Florida to visit her folks, and came back with a face full of freckles, her thick, brown hair a couple shades lighter, and her whole body more relaxed than I'd ever seen.

"How was your trip?" she asked that first morning back. "You went to London, right?"

"And Paris," I said.

"How romantic. You bring anyone special?" The question was a probing one, but unlike times in the past, I didn't hear the bite of sarcasm.

In the past, I would have done my best to avoid answering this in anyway that left an opening for her. We'd tried our thing, and it had been fun, but I wasn't interested any more. Now, I let my guard down. What did I have to lose? "No, just me, all alone."

"What happened? I thought you were seeing someone in Hempstead."

She knew about that? That was interesting. I certainly hadn't told anyone that I worked with. "Uh... that didn't work out."

I immediately regretted saying that. Cate didn't get where she was by being passive. When she saw an opening, she went for it decisively. It's what makes her so great at what she does here, and how we first ended up in bed. I looked up at her, expecting to see her calculating the best way to rekindle something between us. Instead, I saw sympathy. Genuine sympathy.

"I'm sorry, Ethan. That's always hard." When she reached out, I half expected her to make a move, to pull me close, to kiss me, to tell me that she was here. Instead, she just squeezed my arm and walked away.

Huh, not what I was expecting. Worse, a part of me wished that she *had* made a move. At least that would have helped me forget about Nicole and Mason. At least for a little bit.

I know, horrible of me.

I found out later that Cate had met someone while in Florida, an old boyfriend, and he was now talking about moving to Washington, DC for her. Unfairly, I was jealous of Cate and her happiness. Everytime I saw her smile at something on her phone, I felt the lead weight in my gut grow bigger.

It wasn't so much that I wanted her back. I didn't, and I was happy that she found someone that made her smile. I was more envious of the *idea* that she'd found someone, and the reminder that so had Nicole. I was shut out, coast-to-coast. I'd planned on trying to get out of every trip back to Hempstead. Now, it didn't matter either way.

I ended up texting Fiona. She'd looked out for Nicole early on, and then tried to warn me after. I wasn't expecting much, but at least I hoped to get some information.

[Me]: So Nicole's dating the doctor?

I didn't get an immediately response, which was strange for Fiona. Was she working? Was she trying to decide if she wanted to engage in The Asshole, as I imagined she thought of me now. A couple hours later, my phone buzzed.

[Fiona]: She is.

There was a finality in her statement that none of the pictures had conveyed. Not even the status change on Facebook. This was third party confirmation. This was it.

[Fiona]: Facebook?

[Me]: Yeah.

[Fiona]: How do you feel?

That was surprising. Sympathy for the man who had divorced her friend and broken her heart? Who'd literally left the country to avoid dealing with this problem head on.

I decided to go with the version of my feelings that I wanted to believe—ambivalence.

[Me]: I'm fine. Just surprised. Thought there was a hospital rule.

[Fiona]: Oh, they're official. HR knows.

Thud. I read the text like a fist pounding me in the sternum.

[Me]: Ah.

[Fiona]: You sure you're okay?

[Me]: Yeah, I am.

I was, right? No, I wasn't.

[Fiona]: OK.

She didn't tease me like I was expecting she would. That made me feel worse. It implied a seriousness to their relationship that I was still trying to wrap my head around.

[Fiona]: Are you in town? Let's talk.

[Me]: I'm not there now.

[Fiona]: When you are, let me know.

[Me]: Okay.

Fiona, I realized, had had a full month to get used to the new paradigm of Nicole's life. I'd had a couple days.

Time did help, though. I mellowed through July and into August until the ache from losing Nicole dulled. I still kept up with the goings-on in Hempstead through social media, but it hurt less.

Nicole's posts were infrequent, although when she did post, they came all at once, intense and uncomfortable. When I returned to Hempstead in late August for the first time after my break, she hadn't posted in over a week. The day after, though, she and Mason went on a sailing trip up the Puget Sound. It made me ache to see her so happy, so beautiful. She still kept her hair short, not quite to her shoulders, and it blew around her in the wind. On that sailing boat, in her loose, striped tops and white shorts, she looked like an Abercrombie ad, and I longed to be the man at her side.

I tried to hate the way Mason made her smile. I was certainly jealous enough to. But I couldn't. Not as much as I wanted to, anyway. She was happy, and strangely, so was I.

I didn't call Fiona when I was there, justifying the reluctance by telling myself that there was no time.

I minimized my trips after that. I took early flights in and red eyes home. I didn't go out with the team, claiming jetlag and exhaustion. No one

thought that much of it, and I avoided running into Nicole or Mason.

Fiona eventually found me, despite everything I could do to avoid her. She came right into the campaign headquarters when I was there, commanding the attention of every man present.

“Can I help you?” Emory asked hopefully.

Fiona looked intimidatingly attractive. Amidst the policy and campaign wonks in this office, she looked like she’d taken a wrong turn and was trying to figure out how she ended up here. Only, she wasn’t scanning the space out of confusion. She was looking for me.

“Ethan, we need to talk.”

All eyes swung from the beautiful redhead to me as they puzzled out our relationship. I could see the question on everyone’s mind: was this the woman I’d been seeing before the summer recess?

“Fiona, hey.” I rose. In her ankle boots, she was almost as tall as I was. “Come on, let’s grab a coffee around the corner.”

She waved at the rest of the team, as if seeing them for the first time. “Nice to meet you all.” She turned and left. I followed.

When we’d settled into a table at Sofie’s Cafe, Fiona turned on me. “You never called.”

“Sorry. Busy.”

Her eyes narrowed. She lifted her coffee mug to her lips, which were painted a devastating shade of red, but didn’t take her eyes off me.

“Are you done feeling sorry for yourself?” she asked once her mug was safely back in its saucer.

I gaped at her blunt question before deciding to get defensive. “I’m not feeling sorry for myself.”

She cocked a brow. “Then look me in the eyes and tell me you haven’t been checking Nicole’s Facebook feed multiple times a day.”

I suddenly got worried that there was some way to track that, and that Nicole had seen how obsessive I was being. Worse, that her boyfriend knew.

“Fine, maybe I’m feeling a little sorry for myself.”

Fiona sighed, softening. “Why did you leave like that?”

“I needed space,” I said. “And time to think about things.”

Fiona was shaking her head before I’d finished. “Not what I meant. You divorced her before you ran away. You know she flew out to DC to see you, when you wouldn’t answer her calls?”

Shame burned up the back of my neck. “I do, yeah. I’m...I’m sorry about that.”

“You should be sorry!” Fiona blew out a breath of air, trying to calm her frustration. “I shouldn’t have sent you those texts. That was a mistake. I thought you were into that sort of thing.”

The graveyard shift. The audio. The way she’d casually informed me that Mason was her go-to hookup. My chest tightened as it all came back. I couldn’t speak.

“If I’d known you would have gone nuclear, I never would have teased you.”

“Doesn’t change the fact that all of that happened,” I said.

“True, true. But come on, Ethan. It’s not like you’re all innocent. Remember who you’re talking about, and what happened between us.”

“That was a mistake. A one time thing—”

“And Nicole told me about the makeup kit in your bathroom.”

I grimaced. “That’s not what it looked like.”

Fiona’s eyebrows went up. “So you’re a crossdresser now?”

“No, I mean—”

“At some point, you were seeing someone enough that she needed to leave her things at your place. It’s fine. Nicole was *fine* with it. She understands that you’ve got a life in DC, just like she has a life here. But she still had feelings for you, Ethan. She was still trying to figure out where you guys stood. Maybe she still is.”

“Doesn’t look that way to me,” I said. “Remember, I check Facebook multiple times a day.”

Fiona rolled her eyes. “Oh, please, don’t read too much into that. You should know more than anyone that public personas are different than real ones.”

I wished she looked as confident as she sounded, but I saw her fingers fidget with the mug. It was fine. I’d come to terms with the way things were going. Nicole was never mine to lose. She was always her own person.

Fiona said, “Have you talked to her yet? Since you left?”

“No.”

“You should.”

I sighed. I resisted the urge to tell her what she wanted to hear and end this conversation. Instead, I thought long and hard before answering. “I shouldn’t, Fiona. She’s happy, and I’m...happy for her, too.”

Fiona started shaking her head. I ignored her, continuing.

“And I’ve hurt her enough. She needs this. She needs me out of her life. It’s why I sent her those papers. It’s why I left. If I could have gotten out of these trips, I would have. After November, I’ll be gone for good—”

“Stop, Ethan.” Fiona groaned in frustration. She wanted to say something, but couldn’t form the words. Instead, she just said, “You two are the most frustrating people I’ve ever met.” She stood. “Talk to her.”

“I’ll think about it.”

“Do that,” she said. “And do it soon.”

She left me alone in the coffee shop, confused. I didn’t know what to make of that conversation. I didn’t want to try to understand. I went back to the campaign office, then back to the hotel, then back to DC. I kept ignoring the problem until I couldn’t avoid it.

The Congressman was holding a fundraiser with the hospital board and its largest donors. I tried getting out of it, but I wasn’t allowed to. I was his most trusted aide, and I needed to be there. When I packed for the black tie event, I melodramatically thought of it as my funeral. I wasn’t entirely wrong.

fundraiser

At least I had advanced notice. It wasn't much. I was already in Hempstead, but the fundraising event was still a couple days away when I got her text.

[Nicole]: Are you going to the hospital fundraiser?

There was only one good explanation for a question like that, especially from a woman who I had not spoken to for almost three months. She'd somehow been invited. Still, there was only one answer I could give.

[Me]: I am.

[Nicole]: Okay, cool.

I knew Nicole well enough to know what her next move was: to get out of the night. Part of her reason, like mine, was to avoid me and put off that uncomfortable confrontation. The other half, though, came out of a selflessness that she always had. It's what made her such a good nurse. She was a natural caregiver. It's what would make her a fantastic mother.

That one hit me particularly hard. She'd be a fantastic mother for Mason's children. Not mine.

Anyway, the idea of her sacrificing her night because of me didn't make me feel great.

[Me]: You going?

Or maybe that messed up part of me wanted to see her and Mason in action.

[Nicole]: Nah. Just heard about it through some friends.

It was a white lie, so that I wouldn't feel guilty. Because I knew that, I felt even more guilty.

[Me]: You should come. Bring your new guy. I'd like to meet him.

My thumb hovered a long time over the send button before I pressed it. Reading it sounded so casual. If only she could have seen my hands shaking as I'd typed it.

She didn't answer for the longest time. Was she consulting with him right now? I imagined her frowning, shaking her head before Mason

collected her in his strong arms and kissed her forehead. *It'll be okay, I'll be there*, he'd say.

I shivered and felt something that I hadn't since I'd come back from Europe—jealousy changing into brooding excitement, like milk churning into butter.

[Nicole]: I'll talk to him.

Which meant yes, because I was pretty sure now that he'd been invited. Made sense. Just wish I'd known before.

That was the thing, right? I just needed time to prepare my mind for the inevitable. I could be the better man here. We'd had our fun, and I'd had my chance. I'd fucked it up beyond recovery, whatever Fiona thought, but that didn't mean we couldn't be civil.

The election would be in the fall, and after that, I'd be out of her hair forever.

*

The fundraiser was held in the ballroom of our hotel. The architecture of the room was borderline gaudy—crystal chandeliers hanging from a high, coffered ceiling, marble columns, marble statues, marble floors. It suited the purposes of the evening, though. This was the best—if not the only—place that could accommodate a string quartet and a bunch of rich people in black tie attire in all of Hempstead County.

I was there early, helping coordinate things ahead of the Congressman's arrival, trying to do my best not to soil my tuxedo. Gave me a chance to reflect some more on my life and where I was now.

The Ethan Shaw who'd left this small town in this quaint county outside of Seattle was a different Ethan Shaw. I rode the Metro to work now. I worked in the seat of government for arguably the most powerful country in the world. I owned a tuxedo.

And this Ethan, in his bow tie, knew that he'd been right to move on. From Hempstead. From his old life. From Nicole. She'd been able to, after all.

Even in my own thoughts, I sounded petulant. I went and got a club soda. Don't lose it now, buddy boy.

My job was to act as an extension of the Congressman, but to do so unobtrusively. To be seen and heard only when Phillips wasn't there, and

then disappear when he was. It was going to require being alert, so I laid off the booze, despite really wanting a drink. I already had a bottle of Jack in my room, ready for night's end.

As people began to arrive, I tried my best to keep my mind on task, but there were some serious worlds colliding tonight. Compared to tonight, the rally when I'd first met Mason felt like a middle school dance. I kept looking toward the doors, waiting for the couple of the hour to arrive, and finding myself simultaneously disappointed and annoyed when they didn't.

Remarkably, it was Dr. Mason Mann that I spotted first. His bald head caught the lights as he stepped through the entrance, and his tuxedo transformed him from the friendly neighborhood doctor into the villain I'd been trying so hard to deny. He'd grown his beard out, so that it ended where his sideburns would have been had he not shaved his head. I knew from obsessing over his posted photos that he'd developed some gray in that beard, and got teased about it mercilessly by both Nicole and his sisters.

And yes, I shouldn't know that, but I did.

I felt my claws come out, my jealousy rising like hackles along my back. Again, I wished that I had a drink just so I could pound it and feel that rush of alcohol.

Then I saw Nicole, and I couldn't stop looking at her. She was as beautiful and as glamorous as she'd been on our wedding day, only instead of wearing a lacy, strapless white wedding gown, she wore a sleek black halter dress that left her shoulders bare. In that evening dress and her dark, maroon stilettos, she looked tall and slender in a way that felt new. Or maybe the newness was because of the man she clung to and how good they looked together—a Bond girl to his Bond villain.

Her blond hair was combed back and twisted into an updo, leaving her neck bare and emphasizing the silver filigree earrings that I didn't recognize. I could practically see Nicole opening the rich, velvet box that held them, thanking Mason, and throwing her arms around his neck.

She was searching the ballroom as they entered, looking for me. I was torn by the desire to wave at her and to run and hide. I ended up doing neither, instead turning to the conversation that I was on the periphery of, and pretending to be intensely interested. I'm pretty sure they were talking about taxes, but I'm not sure which side of the issue this guy fell on. I shut everything out and focused. Now was not the time to let things slip.

When I did look over to where they were, they'd moved on. A quick sweep of the room didn't turn them up anywhere. It was unsettling, like knowing an ambush was up ahead, but unable to see it. I felt tense everywhere, so much so that when Mitch put a hand on my shoulder, I jumped.

"Hey, man, you feeling okay?" the campaign manager asked.

"Uh, yeah. Sorry, just...feeling weird is all." I might as well be honest, at least partially. "My ex-wife is here with her new boyfriend."

The words caught in my throat, trying to deny the truth of them.

Mitch nodded in understanding. He squeezed my shoulder, his mouth turned down. "I feel for you, man. I've got a couple ex-wives of my own. This life," he looked around, "isn't great for having families."

I took a deep breath, clearing out the lingering emotion. "Thanks, Mitch."

"If you want to take off—"

"No, I'm good." I forced a laugh. "If I can't deal with my ex, how will I deal with upset constituents?"

Mitch nodded his approval. "So that's the plan? To have constituents of your own?"

He made it sound like we were talking about having children. It made my laugh less forced.

"One day, I'd like to."

"You should. You've got a way with people. You could even start here."

"Olympia?" I asked. It was such a ridiculous thought. I couldn't even handle my ex-wife and my marriage well. I'd left Nicole, divorced her, then fled rather than deal with her reaction. How would I be able to weather the tough choices that a state senator had to make?

Mitch pressed on. "You could try. Senator Davis is probably set to retire soon. But I was thinking more local. Hempstead is a great place, and could use someone like you."

As he spoke, the crowd parted just so, and there was Nicole again, looking radiant with a flute of champagne in her hand and an older man who was paying more attention to her chest than what she was saying.

"State and Federal is high profile, but it's at the local levels that you can make the most immediate impact."

I agreed with everything he said, except that there was no way in hell I was going to stay here any longer than I had to. The crowd shifted more, and there was Mason, making her laugh. *Definitely* wouldn't be staying here.

"Thanks," I said to Mitch. "I'll...I'll definitely keep it in mind."

"That her?" he asked, following my eyes.

"Yeah. The blonde."

"Wow," he said, then realizing who he was talking about, added, "Sorry."

"No worries. I'm thinking the same thing." I pulled my attention back to Mitch. "I should probably talk to her. Clear the air."

Mitch grabbed a flute of champagne and handed it to me. "Drink this first. Trust me, I've been here before. It'll help."

"Thanks."

"Have a good night, Ethan. And if you decide to run for something, let me know. I can get you in touch with the right people."

I nodded...I think. He wandered away, but I barely took notice. I was getting tunnel vision, the way I used to in the moments shortly before a public speaking engagement. The world narrowed to nothing other than Nicole. I didn't even see Mason, or who she was talking to, or where she was. I just saw her, smiling, laughing, being happy.

The jealousy would have eaten me alive were I not...happy for her. I held on to that thought.

"Ethan," Nicole said, her infection turning up at the end like a half-formed question.

"Evening, Nicole." I held up my flute, surprised to see it nearly empty.

She tipped hers against mine, the glass chiming pleasantly. With it, the world returned, along with my sense of decorum. I glanced around, surprised to find that we were alone.

Nicole noticed. "He's outside, taking a smoke break."

"A smoking doctor," I said. I meant it as a joke, but it came out as a snipe.

Nicole took it in stride. "Terrible, isn't it? I'm trying to get him to stop. But you know how habits are."

I remembered the cigarette that she'd had with him outside at the wedding. That seemed like ages ago.

"Yeah," I said.

We stood there, staring at one another awkwardly.

I took a deep breath. "I'm...sorry about how things ended." Then, realizing the multiple meanings of that apology, I added, "I shouldn't have just sent the papers, but I was in a rush and had a plane to catch."

I tried to read Nicole, but couldn't. When she spoke, she sounded more neutral than upset. "Yeah, you could have handled that better."

Time had a way of softening even that, it seemed.

Mason joined us before I could figure out what the hell to say. He put a hand on the small of her back and smiled at me. "I know you."

I swallowed. Here we go. "Yeah."

"You work with Phillips. We met at some rally back in March."

"Good memory," I said. My heart was racing. "I'm also Nicole's husband. *Ex*-husband," I quickly corrected.

"Well..." His hand dropped away from Nicole. "Okay..."

This was about as awkward as possible. Time to be the bigger man.

"I'm sorry, where are my manners? I'm Ethan Shaw. Pleased to meet you."

I held out my hand, and he accepted it like a life preserver. "Mason Mann."

"It's nice to finally meet you, Mason. Nicole's said some great things about you," I lied.

"Thanks..." He sounded uncertain, looking at Nicole. Clearly she hadn't mentioned me at all. That stung a bit, but I hadn't expected her to anyway.

To Nicole, I said, "She's happy, so I'm happy."

Her eyes went watery as she smiled, and because of that, so did mine. I cleared my head and turned back to Mason. "When we met last, you said that she was special. I didn't know that you were talking about Nicole at the time, but now it all makes sense."

I forced a laugh, and Mason was more than willing to join in. I also saw him go a little queasy as he played that conversation over. He'd also said something about her wearing him out in bed. Well, if he felt a little uncomfortable, I wasn't going to lose sleep over it.

Mason smiled at Nicole. "Yeah, she's a special one."

It wasn't a statement meant for me, or even for me to overhear. I tasted copper, finished off the champagne, and swapped it out for a fresh one. This was going to be my last, I promised myself.

“To Nicole,” I said, raising my glass. Then, because it felt like the right thing to say, I added, “To the both of you.”

They looked away from one another. *Thank you*, Nicole mouthed as we clinked glasses. I put on my most supportive face and nodded, and hoped that it didn’t look as fake as it felt.

“I should get going,” I said. “Mason, nice meeting you. Hope you donate loads of money. Trust me when I say that we’re lucky to have Congressman Phillips. There aren’t many like him back in Washington.”

“Nice to meet you, too, Ethan.” We shook hands again, and when I turned to Nicole, I was surprised to see her step close and kiss me on the cheek.

“You look good in a tuxedo,” she whispered.

And stepping back, she linked her arms into Mason’s and they strolled away.

I kept an eye on them as the night wore on. When we got close enough to pass, we’d nod politely, but otherwise, everyone pretended to be nice and polite, even as it ate me up inside. Not that they were overly affectionate with one another. If anything, after that meeting, Mason seemed to be considerate of me. He barely touched her, even when I wasn’t looking, and the two could almost be mistaken as acquaintances to the casual observer. I respected him for that.

Weird to think that about respecting this man, though. I didn’t want to. I wanted to hold on to my self-pity just a little longer, but I found that I couldn’t, and every time I tried, I imagined Fiona glaring at me.

Fiona had asked me to talk to her, and now I had. Check one more thing off the list.

So why did I feel so unfulfilled?

I found Mitch. “I’m taking off. Not feeling so great after all.”

“Hang in there, man. I’ll tell Phillips.”

“Thanks.”

When I went to leave, I saw Nicole and Mason ahead of me, getting their coats from the coat closet. Apparently they’d had enough of dodging me and playing nice, too. Or maybe they were just ready to go back to his place and get naked.

It was a spiteful thing to think, yet it did a curious thing: it made me hard. I hung back because I didn’t want to have to sneak past them, and I didn’t want to confront them again. Mason pulled her close as they waited,

and she gripped his arms, looking up at him, all smiles. She leaned close and whispered something into his ear, pulling away and blushing.

My pants tightened even more. Here I was, observing this secret thing between my wife and her lover, and it soaked in like rocket fuel.

They got their coats, kissed, then headed out toward the hotel lobby.

I followed at a close distance, expecting them to take the escalator down to the main lobby and leave me in peace. Instead, with a hushed laugh from Nicole, she pulled Mason down a side hallway, headed back toward the smaller breakout meeting rooms of the hotel.

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watching

I followed after without thinking, thankful for the thick carpet and the winding halls. The lights were all on back here, despite it being empty and unused, and Nicole and Mason flitted like a pair of shadows ahead of me, always just around a corner.

They ducked into one of the larger conference halls. We'd looked into using it over the ballroom, but it lacked the extravagance that we were looking for. I did know that this room could be partitioned into three, though, and hoped that it had been. I waited for the door to shut behind them before sneaking by it, moving on to the second door.

I jumped as the lock clicked on their door as I passed. *What are you doing?* I asked as my heart calmed back to something normal-ish. The answer to that question assured that my heart would never settle back fully.

The second door stood open, the interior dark but for the emergency lights high above. I crept up to it, got low, and peeked in. The partitions were up, separating this room from the one that Nicole was in. I tiptoed inside and carefully, quietly, shut the door behind me.

My heartbeat pulsed, loud as thunder, between my ears. My palms were sweaty. My skin felt electrified as I crept into the dark room like a ghost, listening for what was happening next door.

When I heard Nicole's laugh, muffled as it was through the partition, all those feelings grew more intense. My pulse quickened, my body shook, my chest tightened. I moved closer to the partition, willing my ears wider.

"Shh, shh..." Nicole whispered, loud enough that I could hear.

"We're alone," Mason said, less quiet. "And besides, isn't that your thing? The risk of getting caught?"

I swallowed. That was Nicole's thing? She had a thing?

I heard nothing in response, so I moved even closer. Were they kissing? Were they doing more?

The accordion partitions were constructed of large, pillowed panels meant to absorb sound as much as they could. They were designed to separate this large conference room into three smaller ones if need be. As my eyes adjusted to the dark, I noticed that this particular room had already

been set. A screen had been erected at the back, a podium to its side, and then row after row of chairs before it.

I didn't care about any of that. What I focused on was the little door in the partition, way at the back, in the shadow of the projection screen. I moved down the wall, careful to avoid the chairs and any wiring that had been taped to the floor.

"So you're okay?" Mason asked. His voice sounded louder, closer to the back.

"I'm okay," Nicole said. "Are you?"

"I'm fine, but I wasn't married to him."

They were talking about me. I skimmed my fingertips along the wall, feeling the rough fabric as I listened.

"You don't really want to have this conversation now, do you?" Nicole said. Even through the wall, I heard the throaty suggestion.

I arrived at the small door. It was designed to close with a small, metal latch inset into it. I pressed my ear against the door, trying to figure out where in the room they were.

When Mason spoke, he wasn't right next to the door, but it was hard to tell how far away he was. "Take off your dress."

I gasped. I needed to see it. Without thought of the consequences, I twisted the latch and pushed open the little door a hair. All I needed was enough to look through.

This room was slightly brighter than mine, the recessed lights high above were on, just set to low. It was set for a breakfast, it seemed, filled with rounds instead of as an auditorium, and a long, skirted table occupied one side of the room.

Mason was leaning on one of those long tables at about the middle of the room. Nicole stood before him, fiddling with the halter clasp behind her neck. She watched him watch her, the moment charged.

Releasing the clasp, she pulled the black dress away. It slithered like liquid around her, pooling around her ankles and leaving her clothed in black lingerie. She wore a strapless bra, a garter belt, and lace-topped black stockings that disappeared into her tall, maroon heels. She had no panties on.

"Very naughty," Mason said, reaching out to touch her between her legs.

Nicole gasped, her buttocks tightening as his fingers touched her bare sex.

He looked up at her. "You're so wet," he said. "You really do love sex in public places."

Nicole swooned, grabbing Mason's arm to steady herself. "Oh, Mason..."

He stood up, kissing her as he continued to press his hand down between her thighs. She broke the kiss, moaning. He went after her neck instead, left exposed because of her updo.

I watched, my stomach churning, my cock hard and uncomfortable inside my tight tuxedo pants. I shifted, adjusting as best as I could.

"Take it out," Mason said.

My breath caught for a confusing moment when I thought he was talking to me. When I realized that he was ordering Nicole to do it for him, it didn't get any easier to breathe.

She did as she was told, though, reaching behind his waist and detaching the cummerbund first, then working open his pants.

"Good girl," he said, pressing his fingers into her sharply enough that she rose up on her toes and gasped. "Now on your knees."

I never would have talked to Nicole like this. Not when we were married, anyway. I never would have dreamed that she'd want to be talked to like that, but there was no mistaking the way she shuddered at the order, or how happily she followed it.

Watching her sink to her knees didn't seem real. I must be imagining this, right? This was a crazy dream, one from which I didn't want to wake.

When I saw Mason's cock come into view, held at the base by Nicole's slender fingers, I knew this couldn't be real. Even from where I hid, he looked huge. He looked as shaved as his head, the shaft curving slightly upward like it had been designed to fuck.

Nicole stared up at him, her eyes locked on his as she stroked the thick dick. She reached behind her, unclasping her bra, and let her tits spill into view. Mason lost his concentration as he drank in her chest. Nicole laughed softly, dipped down, and swallowed the bulbous tip of his cock.

Mason groaned. I held my breath, gripping the doorframe until my knuckles turned white.

I'd imagined this moment plenty of times over the last few months, wondering how I'd feel to actually watch Nicole fool around with another

man. I knew she'd done it, of course. I'd seen her kiss Mason. I'd listened to her fuck. But actually *seeing* it hit me harder than I was prepared for—and turned me on even more.

Mason was careful not to mess up Nicole's hair, leaning back on the table and gripping its edge just to keep his hands away. Nicole wrapped both hands around the base of his cock, pumping and twisting as she worked more and more of him into her mouth, down her throat.

So this is how she had learned to deepthroat. She'd practiced on this man and his large endowment, and taken those lessons into our own bedroom. What else had she learned from him? What other things had she done first with Mason? I thought of all the possibilities: talking dirty, shaving her pussy, fucking me with her tits. Knowing that he came first made each of those situations even hotter in retrospect.

Nicole took more and more of his cock into her throat, gagging and pulling back as she worked him. "You look so fucking hot, baby," he said. "All dolled up and gagging on me."

Nicole pulled back, releasing his cock with a wet pop. "You look pretty good yourself," she said, tugging at the tails of his tuxedo shirt. She licked down his shaft, pressing it against his stomach as she lapped at his balls. I groaned.

"Suck those balls, Nicky baby. Feel how full you make them."

She swallowed them into her mouth. Mason stiffened, groaning loudly. She smiled up at him, stroked his spit-covered cock as she continued to tease his scrotum.

"They feel very full," Nicole purred. "Let's see if we can do something about that."

She took his cock back into her mouth, swallowing it nearly to the root before slurping back. She bobbed slowly, dragging her lips along his shaft until he was right up against the edge. Sensing the immediacy of his orgasm, Nicole began to work him faster. I could hear her sucks from across the room and could just make out the sheen of perspiration on her bare back.

"That's it, baby. Suck my cock. Take it deep. Show me how much you want my come."

I couldn't believe anyone was talking to Nicole like that, and she was putting up with it. But she was. Not only that, she seemed spurred on by the

things he was saying. Like she really did want to take him deep. Like she really did want to show him how much she wanted his come.

“Ah, fuck, Nicky.”

She took him deep, nearly to the root, and began jerking her head in short jerks. She was using her throat to work his glans. To push him over the edge. He gripped the table, thrusting deeper into her. She gagged, adjusted, and finished the job.

Mason grunted, throwing his head back and looking upwards into the dim lights as he came. Nicole swallowed, drinking another man's come as I watched. As I grew so hard that I couldn't help myself.

I ran my fingers along my cock through my tuxedo pants. I was close. On edge. I didn't dare do more than a brush.

Mason pulled Nicole up to him and into a deep, heavy kiss. Apparently he didn't have any qualms about tasting himself. Her fingers fell naturally into place around his cock, which had only lost a little of its firmness.

“That was fun,” Mason said. “But I bet you want more.”

“Oh, yes,” Nicole said, breathily.

“Does it turn you on, knowing that all those people are just down the hall?”

I tensed.

“Yes,” Nicole sighed.

Mason positioned her against the table, facing away from me, and bent her over until her hands lay flat. “Did it turn you on, chatting and socializing with the boss of our bosses, knowing you weren't wearing panties?”

“Oh, Mason...”

“What do you think the board of the hospital would think about that?” He stepped into place behind her, his cock once again full and primed, and ran his finger up the back of her leg, tracing her black garter. “What do you think the Congressman would do if he knew what you wore beneath your dress?”

He pulled the garter, then released it. It snapped against her skin, and she let out a soft moan. “Please, Mason.”

I gritted my teeth. If he said my name... if he said anything about “Nicole's husband...”

“Stop teasing me and fuck me,” Nicole pleaded.

He pressed his cockhead against her pussy. “But you love being teased. You wouldn’t have handed me your panties before we arrived if you didn’t.”

Mason pushed into her, covering her mouth with his hand to stifle her moan. It only halfway worked. He was huge, and even from where I stood, I could see how much he stretched her. It was a hard thing to watch, and yet like everything else about this crazy fantasy, it was so hot.

He fucked her slowly at first, letting her get used to him before kicking it up a notch. I watched, riveted, unable to look away. Unable to fully banish my insecurities. I’d always thought I had the edge on any other man. I knew the manual that was Nicole. But I didn’t have a cock like that. I didn’t reach the places Mason no doubt did. I didn’t stretch her the way he must have.

“Yes, Nicole,” he replied, his voice just as tight.

I remembered what Fiona had said after the incident during the night shift: *She must really like that big cock of his. Having experienced it, I don’t blame her.*

Now I knew. Now I understood.

Nicole’s moans grew louder, seething out around Mason’s hand. His other hand held onto her hip, steadying himself as he fucked her ever faster.

“Every man in there wanted to fuck your brains out,” Mason said. “I saw them looking. *You* saw them looking. And that turned you on, didn’t it?”

She nodded rapidly. She was close.

“You like the attention. You like being wanted.”

She moaned something that could have been an affirmative.

“You liked that *he* wanted you, didn’t you?”

I froze.

She shook her head.

“It turned you on, talking to him as he undressed you in his head—”

She twisted her head until his mouth slipped away. “No. Mason, I swear—”

“Did you pick this dress out for him?” He was...jealous? Of me?

“Mason, no—”

“Did you spend all that time on your hair and makeup because *he’d* be here?”

“No, baby. It’s all for you. All of it’s for you.”

Mason was pounding her hard, drilling his thick shaft deep. He pressed her down, flattening her out on the table. He grabbed the meat of her buttocks in one hand, squeezing her, and reached out and wrapped his other hand around her throat.

I actually took a step into the room before I realized that he wasn't murdering her. He was punishing her. She moaned, thrusting her hips against his cock, wanting more, begging for more.

"That's right," he growled. "All of this is for me."

"Yes!"

"Tell me, Nicky. Tell me whose pussy this is."

"Yours."

"Whose cock do you crave?"

"Yours!"

"All those men want to fuck you. The chairman of the board. The Congressman. Your ex-husband."

I gasped, like his words had physical weight behind them.

Mason rammed her hard, deep, squeezing her ass, her neck.

"And the only one who gets this cunt is me," he snarled. He threw his head back, his lips peeled back. He was a man who wanted to roar, but knew that he could not. Instead, he unleashed that frustration on Nicole, and that pushed her over the edge.

She gripped the edge of the table, opposite Mason. Turning her head, I saw the passion in her face, in the way she shut her eyes so tightly that she looked in pain. Her cunt was his, and she willingly gave it to him.

Watching the two of them come together, to share that moment of bliss, was what did me in for that night. It was like watching fireworks on television, knowing how much better the real thing was.

And yet I stayed. Too long, probably, but I couldn't just leave it alone. I watched them gather themselves. To kiss. To get dressed.

To hear Nicole say, "You don't have to worry about anyone else."

And, "You don't have to worry about him."

And, "It's over between us."

And with that, at last, I left.

*

It was over between us. I'd left her—twice. I'd *divorced* her. I needed to move on. It wasn't fair of me not to. And yet...

Tell me whose pussy this is.

Yours.

Whose cock do you crave.

Yours.

...I just couldn't stop thinking about her.

The only one who gets this cunt is me.

It was that statement that made me hate Mason Mann. He wanted to own her. He needed her to want him. While I was busy giving her freedom and trying to let her go, Mason was doing the opposite.

But it was no longer my business, right? Right. Mason didn't have to worry about me, and so I shouldn't have to worry about Mason. Or Nicole. Or the choices she made. She clearly enjoyed fucking him. He seemed to have unlocked an exhibitionist side of her that I'd never known about. Good for her. Good for the two of them.

Mason was in, I was out. End of story.

I tried to honor that. I really did. Even when Fiona texted me.

[Fiona]: I heard you saw Nicole. With Mason. How was that for you?

I ignored her. I closed my phone and didn't respond, but Fiona wasn't one to give up so easily.

[Fiona]: Did it live up to your fantasy?

I read it, took a deep breath, and read it again.

[Me]: I thought we were past that now. Aren't you afraid I'm going to go nuclear again?

[Fiona]: But it did get you excited...

It did, but how did she know? My heart seized as I considered a frightening possibility.

[Me]: Did Nicole say something?

[Fiona]: LOL. It did!

[Me]: Fiona...

[Fiona]: No, she didn't. All she said was that she saw you there, and that you looked like you were doing well. Nothing about getting an erection watching her hold Mason's hand.

This woman didn't know when to leave well enough alone.

[Me]: I'm not having this conversation.

[Fiona]: Scroll up, dear. You are.

[Me]: Why are you bringing this up? Why can't you leave me alone?

[Fiona]: Call me a romantic, and I want to see a happy ending.

[Me]: I think she's already got one with Mason.

[Fiona]: Mason? Oh, please. I told you already, Ethan, they're having fun, but that's not long-term.

[Me]: She told him that it was over between us.

I pressed send before realizing that I shouldn't have heard that conversation, that she'd said it to Mason when they'd been alone in the meeting room. Quickly, I wrote a flurry of messages, hoping to bury the one before she thought too much about it.

[Me]: If not this guy, then there will be someone else.

[Me]: Nicole's too special to be alone for long.

[Me]: And I've broken her heart twice now.

[Me]: She deserves better than me.

I stared at the screen, my heart racing. I watched her begin to type a number of times, but no message came for the longest time. At last, she responded, short and sweet.

[Fiona]: You're an idiot.

And that was that. For about a month, anyway.

thirty

Time is a strange thing. It could slip by like rain water down a spout, or stand still like water in a barrel. It was easy to imagine life as a series of disconnected events and forget about all the time between them. The fundraiser felt like a million years ago at times. At others, it felt like yesterday.

But of course, the same could be said for every other huge event in my life—college felt like yesterday, my wedding, my separation. I could still remember that moment on the plane, when I met Nicole for the very first time. I could remember it better than the entirety of my trip to Europe. Funny how life does that to you.

The last thirty years slid by like that—a slide show of events that marked my life, none of them related, yet all of them me. I was a boy, celebrating an early birthday. I was a young man sleeping on my own in a dorm room at college for the first time in my life. I was a man sleeping alone in my apartment as my wife slept thousands of miles away.

As my thirtieth birthday approached, I thought long and hard on the nature of these events. I never could have predicted what came next. I still had no idea. And that left me feeling very sorry for myself when my thirtieth finally arrived.

*

“The day is done. We’re going out.” Mitch was standing behind me, his hand on the back of my chair.

I turned, ready to pass, just as I had since getting here. It was October and I was back in Hempstead for the long-haul—all the way through November 8. Election Day.

“Step away from the laptop,” Ken said.

“It’s your birthday,” Trish added. “Thirty years, old man. Come on, let’s get you trashed.”

I turned and they were all there: Mitch, Trish, Ken, Emory, even Cate and the rest of the aides who were here, working to get the good Congressman re-elected.

“You’re not going to bail on us, are you?”

I made a big show of sighing, of closing my laptop slowly. Inside, I felt like crying. I hadn't felt this connected to people in ages.

"I guess I can take an evening off."

"Come on then. Let's get this party started."

They whisked me to Martha's Kitchen, a deli that turned into a bar at night. Apparently this had become a favorite of the campaign team, no doubt because it was just a block away from headquarters.

When I got there, I was surprised to see Michael waiting at the bar for me. My old neighbor stood, approached, and threw his arms around me.

"Long fucking time," my old neighbor said. "You look like shit."

I had to laugh. "Thanks. So do you, but that's normal."

"Fucker."

"So you left your house. Big step."

Mitch stepped up next to Michael. "He actually let us know about your big birthday."

Michael nodded. "Figured you'd try to be all stoic about it, so I paid a visit to your friends here." He nudged me. "Besides, I do leave the house, you know. Especially when drinks are involved."

Drinks were definitely involved. It seemed like everyone was out to get me hammered. People from my past kept showing up. People that I'd worked with, people who'd been acquaintances back in my Hempstead days. Apparently I knew more people than I thought I did.

The one person I kept waiting for—with both dread and giddy excitement—never showed up. I kept looking to the door. Michael kept trying to distract me.

"Your coworkers are alright," he said when we had a moment alone. "They almost made me wish I had some coworkers of my own."

"Yeah, they're not bad, are they?"

"But then I remembered that I fucking can't stand people and quickly got over that crazy idea."

I laughed.

"But Ethan, what are you doing, working for some politico when *you* should be that politico?"

I looked around, making sure none of the team overheard.

"Not that simple. I need to put in my time. Work up through the ranks."

“Shoving a thumb up your ass for some Congressional a-hole isn’t my idea of putting in time.” He managed to deliver his assessment with the least amount of malice that was possible, considering the words he actually used. “You should run for office yourself, man.”

“In time.”

“No time like the present.”

I glanced at Mitch, and thought of his offer. I couldn’t do it. Not now, definitely not here. Maybe if things had gone differently with us. But they hadn’t.

“Hey, I’m sorry for riding you,” he said. “It’s just that I see a lot of potential in you, and you aren’t harnessing it.”

“It’s not that. I mean, it is, and I appreciate you kicking my ass about that, but, it’s... Nicole.”

The large man nodded. “Sorry about that whole...thing.”

I shrugged. “No reason to be sorry. Shit happens, and life isn’t a fairytale.”

“No, it’s just filled with fucking aphorisms,” he said. “Just sucks because it seemed like you two were...um...getting along so well for a while there.”

How did he know that? I hadn’t spoken to him since the first time he set me up with her. “Wait a second, have you been spying on us?”

“No, not exactly.” But his face was turning a particularly bright shade of red. “I’m up late, and the neighborhood is dead at night. I notice when a black Uber car shows up is all.”

My stomach fluttered.

He misinterpreted my silence. “I see how all of this could seem a bit stalkerish, but I swear, it’s not like that.”

“So there have been other...late night visitors?”

He looked like a cornered animal. “I don’t know. Maybe.”

“You don’t know?”

Michael glowered. “Fine, you really want to know?”

It was a rhetorical question. He was going to tell me now, no matter what, but for a second, I considered his question. Did I want to know? The fluttering grew more intense. Yes, I did. Very much so.

“There have been a few others. Not many, and it’s just been one guy recently.”

“Bald, goatee?”

“Yeah, that’s him.” Michael scratched the back of his neck.

“When?”

It was weird seeing Michael looking sheepish. “I don’t know. It’s been the doctor for a while now.”

The doctor. He even knew that.

“And you didn’t tell me?”

“You never called, sweetheart.” There was the sarcastic man that I knew.

All of this would have felt like a trap door had opened under me at one point, but that day was a long time ago.

“How often is he there?”

“I don’t keep a log of it.”

“Guess.”

“A few times a week. Sometimes she’s not home, though, so I guess she’s at his place, too.”

I released a slow, quiet breath. I didn’t know what to say. I looked at Michael, who was looking...past me. At someone else. My heart skipped.

I turned, expecting to see Nicole standing there, listening to me probe into her sex life. Maybe I was even hoping for that. When I saw Fiona standing behind me, her arms crossed, a knowing smirk on her face, I felt crushing disappointment.

“Fiona,” I said.

“Happy birthday, Ethan. Get your things, we’re leaving.”

“It’s only 10:30.”

The others around, Michael included, suddenly found whatever was on television riveting.

Fiona was still dressed in her scrubs and a short, denim jacket, but she was still stunning. No one in their right mind would turn down this offer.

But I wasn’t in my right mind. I hadn’t been for a long time.

“I don’t think so—” I began.

Fiona rolled her eyes and grabbed my hand, pulling. “Ethan, come with me. You only turn thirty once and I plan on making it a memorable one.”

I could feel the guys around me exchange smirks. I blushed, preparing to tell her no again.

Fiona leaned in, close enough that she could whisper something that only I could hear. “Want to watch Nicole fool around?”

I was past this, right? The past was the past. Thirty marked the end of that life, and the beginning of a new one. One more month and I'd be gone. I could hold out that much longer, right? I could resist the temptation that was my ex-wife just a little longer.

“So you coming?” Fiona asked.

“Yes.”

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threesome

Once we were out in the night air, I must have sobered up some, because this whole thing seemed a lot worse than when I'd stood up. "Maybe I should go back to the hotel room."

"But then you'll miss all the fun."

"That's kind of the point. It's fun that I should be missing because it's not mine."

Fiona stepped close. "So you don't think it'll be fun to watch Nicole have sex with another woman for the first time?"

My eyes flew open. When I spoke, it felt like my jaw had rusted shut. "What are you talking about?"

Fiona pressed herself close and ran her hand down between my legs. "Oh, did I neglect to tell you that part?"

"You and her? I thought--"

"You thought that we were going to watch her fuck Mason, right?"

This conversation was making me dizzy. "Yeah."

Fiona smiled, leaning close. She kissed my jaw and squeezed my cock. I should have pushed her away, but it was impossible. "Well, you get to see that, too. But tonight, she invited me to join them."

"Haaa..." I breathed, wavering.

"I know, right? Pretty hot."

"Why?"

Fiona shrugged. "Because she's bi-curious? Because she wants to treat her boyfriend to something special?" She purred. "Someone likes that idea. Is it the bi-curious thing? Or the fact that I mentioned *boyfriend*."

"Fiona," I warned, trying to step back.

"Interesting, *boyfriend* gets you hotter than the idea of her making it with another girl. Well, luckily for you, you get both tonight."

She led us to her car, parked on the street. "Where are we going?" I asked.

"Mason's."

Faced with the prospect of actually confronting the man, of coming face to face and having him know that I was getting off on the idea of him fucking my wife, I found my resolve. I put my hand on the top of her car

and shook my head. "I'm not going. Not there. I have no desire to talk to him. He can fuck her for as long as she wants him, and yes, I'll probably get a confusing thrill out of it, but if I never meet him again, it'll be too soon."

Fiona's eyes flashed. "So dramatic. I like it, but don't worry, you're not going to meet him."

"I thought we were going to his house."

"We are, and you'll be sneaking around back. I doubt he's got any more love for Nicole's ex-husband than you do of her lover."

She laughed at whatever face I must have made at the last term.

"Now come on, Ethan. Let's get your kinky voyeur on."

We didn't go straight to Mason Mann's house. First, we swung by Fiona's townhouse so that she could change. "You're welcome to come in and help me pick out something to wear."

"I, um, think I'm fine waiting in the car."

"Suit yourself." She parked, hopped out, and disappeared into the house.

I could have left. I had my chance. She was close enough to town that I could have walked back to the hotel. I didn't. I let myself sit in the car and stew until my insides were nice and soft.

Fiona exited her townhouse like a different person. Gone was the nurse, pretty yet understated. In her place was a woman of glamour. She'd exchanged her scrubs for a tight, short gray dress designed to show off every curve and sinuous line of her body, and judging from the way her breasts moved, I wasn't sure she was wearing a bra.

She wore her hair up in a shimmering clip and had vamped up her makeup, extending her lashes and darkening her eyes until I swore I saw wisps of smoke rise from the corners. Her lipstick was dark red, her cleavage was bountiful, and I'm pretty sure my mouth hung open until she said something about it.

"We could always skip the threesome and go back into my place. It's been too long since someone has spanked me. I've even got handcuffs."

"Um...no. I'm...this is good."

"Suit yourself."

"So are we going out somewhere?" I asked, eyeing the way her dress slid up her thigh.

"No, we're going to Mason's house. But you have to understand, scratching another woman's bi side comes along about as often as a thirtieth

birthday. And when it's someone like Nicole? Well, that just doesn't happen. So I'm going all out to make sure that it does."

Well that was a thrilling thought.

Trying to get a handle on the situation, I said, "Would you be upset if I told you I kind of liked the other version of you?"

Fiona looked over at me in disbelief. With her face made up like that, she pulled off the model-stare-of-death effortlessly. Then she burst out laughing. Throwing her car into reverse, she gunned it backward. My stomach lurched. "You are too cute."

*

Mason's house was in the cedar woods on the north side of town. The houses were newer up here, more spread out, and larger. So much larger.

Fiona dropped me off on an empty stretch of road flanked by cedar trees and dense, shadowy foliage.

"Well, this isn't sketchy," I said.

"You'll be fine. Mason's house is just down that hill. He's got this amazing deck out back with a jacuzzi and Japanese lanterns and that kind of thing. You'll know it when you see it."

"Okay."

She reached into the back of her car and handed me something. "And here, take this. You'll thank me later."

"Binoculars?"

Fiona smiled. "I believe that's what they're called. You're a smart one, Ethan. Now go. See you in a few...or you'll see me, anyway."

I got out of the car, then stopped, turning back to her before shutting the door. "How do I leave?"

"I'll come get you. I don't plan on staying the night."

"And what if I want to leave early?"

Fiona paused long enough to pretend to think about the question, then said, "Guess you can't. Bye now."

She started to pull away before I could close the door. I swung it shut, stood back, and watched her disappear into the night. I looked up into the starry night, laughed, then made my way down the sloping embankment. This was going to be interesting, to say the least.

I picked my way carefully through the underbrush. Tripping and falling would be bad enough, but I could just imagine what people would say if the neighbors found me unconscious in the morning with a pair of binoculars around my neck, and how poorly that would reflect on the Congressman and his touchy re-election campaign.

I pushed on anyway because with my ride gone, there was literally no going back.

A few minutes down the hill, I heard the music filtering softly through the dark—light electronica like I was stumbling into the lounge of a club. Instead, it was Dr. Mason Mann's private residence.

It wasn't a bloated McMansion, like so much of the new construction in this part of town, but more understated. The wooden, single-story ranch seemed built into the wooded landscape around it, spreading out beneath the sleepy canopy like a pseudo-Frank Lloyd Wright design.

There was the deck that Fiona had mentioned, wide and low, flanked on one side by the part of the house that was the bedroom. I could tell because the entire back of the house was like a fish bowl, constructed of tall, wide windows that, when the lights were on, hid nothing inside. It also appeared that Mason wasn't a fan of curtains or shades.

I found them easily, Nicole and Mason, standing close to one another in the kitchen. She was leaning on the counter, her hand resting on his hip, and he nuzzled against her neck, whispering something to her. The intimacy between the two of them was electrifying.

Nicole wore a tight, maroon dress that, while longer than Fiona's, scooped low enough to present her full breasts in what must have been an aggressive bra. Her hair was down, brushed out in golden waves.

Mason pulled away enough to meet her eyes. Her hair had fallen over one eye, and unconsciously he reached up and brushed it back over her ear. He said something, Nicole nodded, and the two kissed.

She was nervous. Even from where I crouched, far enough away that I couldn't see many details, I could tell. It was in her body language. It was in the way she could barely meet his eyes when he pulled back again. I didn't need to see her blush to know that she was blushing.

They turned together, looking toward the front door. Fiona had arrived. Mason spoke, Nicole took a deep breath and nodded, and he left her to answer the door.

She went to the cabinets and retrieved three wine glasses—it didn't escape me that she knew exactly where those glasses were—setting each carefully on the granite countertop. She stared for a long moment at the three, seeing more than just glasses in the odd number.

She turned, looking out the windows, looking in my direction. My heart skipped a beat. I ducked back behind a tree before realizing that she couldn't see me. She couldn't see through the glass. She was looking at herself, at her reflection. She tugged at the hem of her dress, adjusted her breasts in her bra, took one more breath, and got her game face on just as Fiona strolled into the room with a grinning Mason right behind her.

I was beginning to put together what was going on here. Nicole wasn't doing this to explore a secret bi-curious side; she was doing this for Mason. The realization fell into my stomach like a block of ice. How far could he push her? How much could he get her to do? And why did that turn me on so much?

To Nicole's credit, she hid her nervousness well. To Mason and Fiona's, they didn't push things. Not immediately. First, they just talked. Mason poured them each a glass of red wine and they seemed to talk like they were standing around the nurses' station.

I couldn't hear anything that they were saying, of course, but I could read body language. Mason drove most of the conversation, asking the questions, telling the stories, making Fiona and Nicole laugh. I watched Nicole slowly relax, let go of her nervousness, at least for a moment, and be one with the moment.

Mason then made a suggestion that had the two women looking outside. That compulsion to duck and hide seized me again. This time, I resisted. They weren't looking for a man hiding in the tree line; they were looking at the jacuzzi.

Fiona took Nicole's hand and pulled her toward the sliding doors. She flipped a switch on the wall and the hot tub, which had been built into the deck, filled with warm, watery light. Mason hung back, opening another bottle of wine as he watched the women pour out into the night and begin to strip.

I watched that, too. It was all I could focus on. They moved up to the tub before stopping. "It's kind of cold out here," Nicole said.

Fiona moved behind her, producing a phone from out of nowhere. "Say cheese," I saw Fiona mouth more than actually heard. Then she held it

in front of them and snapped a selfie. With her free hand, Fiona grabbed Nicole by the breast. Nicole gasped, scandalized, and snap, another selfie.

“Still cold?” Fiona asked. She put the phone away and stepped back, reaching for the zipper of Nicole’s maroon dress. “Let’s get in the hot tub quickly.”

Nicole went with it, shrugging her shoulders as she worked out of the dress. The bra that created her cleavage truly was magnificent, constructed of fine, black lace that lifted and squeezed. Beneath, she wore matching boyshort panties that looked great on her hips.

Fiona drank her in as hungrily as I did. She had to shake her head slightly to snap out of it. “We wouldn’t want to ruin this expensive lace,” she said, running her finger down Nicole’s spine and stopping at the clasp of her bra. “May I?”

“Um... okay.”

Fiona laughed lightly. “Nicole, it’s me. Relax.”

Nicole nodded, but she still didn’t look sure. Fiona twisted her bra open, but stepped close and wrapped her arms around Nicole before the bra could fall. She whispered something into Nicole’s ear that I couldn’t make out, but whatever it was made Nicole smile and spin away.

“You’re a bitch, you know that,” Nicole laughed. The bra fell away. Her back was to me, and I strained to see her breasts. It’s funny, that. I’d seen them so many times before, yet I was once again seeing her in a new light.

“God, I hate how perfect your tits are,” Fiona said. “And you didn’t pay a penny for them.”

The redhead grabbed the bottom of her short, gray dress and peeled it over her head. As I’d suspected, she wasn’t wearing a bra. What I wasn’t expecting was that she wore *nothing* beneath the dress. Her body was just as amazing as it had been back in May—slender and tight with full tits, with her pierced belly button, with her tattooed script up the side of her ribs, with her narrow landing strip of red hair.

Fiona palmed her tits and squeezed. “Mine? I paid some pennies, you could say.”

“Yours are...”

“Yes. Worth every penny, too.”

“Wow, I had no idea.”

Fiona laughed. "Don't look so shocked. I know that many people would judge me, but it was worth it *to me*. You should have known me before. Such a wallflower."

Nicole swept her eyes along Fiona's naked body. "That's...hard to believe."

Fiona closed the distance between them in a single step. Nicole stiffened, her shoulders growing tight. Fiona put her hands on Nicole's waist, and for a heavy moment, I thought they were going to kiss.

"Believe it," she said, then pushed Nicole's panties over her hips. "Come on, let's get into the tub before we freeze to death."

Nicole released a breath and followed Fiona into the roiling water. Mason, who'd been watching them from the door, finally joined them, holding the three empty glasses in one hand and the bottle of wine in the other. He'd stripped down to his boxer-briefs, but the show had gotten him just as hard as it had me.

"Someone's excited about having two naked nurses in his jacuzzi," Fiona said.

Mason laughed confidently. "What can I say? I'm a weak man."

"Doesn't look that way to me," Fiona said. To Nicole, she asked, "Can I see all of him?"

Nicole laughed. That was good. She was relaxing. "Mason, stop being shy and get naked."

He lowered himself to the edge of the hot tub, dipping his feet in as he set out the three glasses of wine. "Help me out."

Nicole rolled her eyes at Fiona, then waded in between his legs. All eyes were on her as she looked up at her boyfriend, took hold of his boxers, and pulled on them. They caught on his cock before he lifted his butt. She pulled harder and suddenly, his large erection sprang free.

"Mmm, I'd forgotten how big he was," Fiona said. She filled their wine glasses.

Nicole pretended to be scandalized. "Fiona, you have no filter!" She wrapped her hand around Mason's erection and pumped it, her eyes never wavering from his. "And he doesn't need his ego pumped up anymore. I'm sure he's sick and tired of girls only seeing him for his size."

"I doubt that. Guys never get tired about hearing how big their cocks are."

Nicole jacked him a little faster. "Is that true, Mason?"

Mason reached down, brushing her hair from her face. "It's not the worst thing to hear."

"You like hearing me say how much I love this big, hard cock?" She leaned forward and kissed the tip. "How I can't wait to feel it inside of me later?"

"I do," he said, a rumble in his voice.

"Or how much I like the way it feels in my mouth?" she teased.

Mason shifted his hand from her face to the back of her neck. The message was clear. I didn't have a great view, but there was no mistaking the way Nicole leaned forward and swallowed his cock.

Mason leaned back on his arms like a king in his realm, one woman sucking his cock while another handed him a glass of wine. He nodded thanks and took a sip before setting it down.

Fiona chanced a look out into the woods, and while she couldn't see me, she smiled as if she could, set her glass next to Mason's, and immersed herself in the water. She waded up to Nicole, who was bobbing efficiently, and put a hand on the blonde's back.

Nicole pulled off and looked back at her friend. "Hey there," she said. She shifted to the side and aimed Mason's cock toward Fiona.

Nicole's back was to me, so I couldn't gauge her reaction, whether she was excited or jealous or confused, watching another woman give a blowjob to her boyfriend. She just sat back, watching, her hand stroking the outside of Mason's thigh.

"You could help her," Mason said at last.

Nicole took in a deep breath, let it out slowly, and dipped her head in. Fiona made way, passing the cock to Nicole as Fiona dropped lower, focusing on the man's shaved balls. He placed his hands on their heads, moaning at the intensity of what he must have been feeling.

I tried to imagine that, to imagine two wet mouths working me at the same time, to feel their soft hands touching and stroking and squeezing in unison. I didn't think I'd be able to hold out very long. Mason wasn't able to, either.

Fiona had just taken him into her mouth when he leaned back and groaned loudly, thrusting his hips against her face. Fiona choked, but got him under control in time to accept his come and swallow.

He sank down into the water, where Nicole was all over him, kissing him even before he'd fully recovered. Watching that would never get easy,

but it was now manageable. We'd entered a hypersexual context. It was easier to think of Nicole as performer and pornstar than my ex-wife.

Thing was, she was *also* my ex-wife, bashful, considerate, thoughtful. I saw it in the way she averted her eyes when Mason turned his head and kissed a waiting Fiona, deep and long and passionately. I saw it in the way she hesitated when Mason drew back and put his hand on the backs of their heads, gently nudging them closer. She laughed softly, breathily, but didn't resist.

When Fiona's eyes closed and her lips touched against Nicole's, I remembered the binoculars. I fumbled with them, my hands shaking, then had a hard time finding the jacuzzi under all the magnification. When I did, Nicole and Fiona were deep into their girl-on-girl kiss. Their mouths were open, their tongues were diving, and if there was any more hesitancy of Nicole's part, I'd completely missed it. She'd even reached out to swirl her fingers on the back of Fiona's neck, where some of her red hair had escaped the clip.

Nicole moaned, breaking the kiss for a moment to gasp. I pulled the binoculars away, seeing that Fiona's hand had disappeared beneath the water and down between Nicole's legs.

Mason got into the action, rising up beside Nicole to kiss her neck as Fiona reclaimed her mouth. He whispered things to Nicole, things I couldn't hear but desperately wished that I could. She broke the kiss, moaning and nodding at whatever he'd asked. She bit her lip, eyes closed, as Fiona's arm began to move faster. Fiona and Mason kissed next, coming to some unspoken agreement to move down to Nicole's tits after.

Nicole shifted back, supporting herself against the sensory onslaught. They didn't relent. They didn't release her. They kept working her nipples, swirling and nipping and teasing as Fiona fingered her faster and faster beneath the water.

"Oh my... oh my!" Her brow crumbled. Her breath caught. And then, like a plug being pulled, she came in a loud, piercing moan. Fiona didn't stop working her until Nicole shook her head and lifted her hips onto the edge of the jacuzzi.

Mason followed her, kissing her deeply. Nicole kissed him back, harder than I've ever seen her before, like she was reaffirming something to herself.

"Did you like that?" he asked.

Nicole nodded, unable to find her voice.

“Want to head into the bedroom?” he asked.

I was disappointed, but while it was mild for October, it was still October in Washington and they were outside, naked and wet. I had a coat and hat on. Luckily for me, most of the bedroom was visible from my position, thanks to the large windows of Mason’s home, although I’d lose the aural stimulation.

They got out of the hot tub, three healthy, attractive naked people riding high on the promise of the night. It was easy to get caught up in that. They toweled off quickly, the girls full of giggles, Mason sporting that intimidatingly large erection of his. Towels wrapped around them, clothes in hand, they scurried into the warmth of the house.

I followed their route through the kitchen before they disappeared into the hall, through the interior of the house, and then emerged into the bedroom. They didn’t turn the lights on, but there was still enough light from the hall that I could make out their shapes, dark and still glossy from being wet.

Like what happened in the jacuzzi, at first Mason was the center of attention. The women led him to the center of the bed and crawled all over him. Fiona went down on him while Nicole lowered her pussy onto his face. They switched, only this time, Nicole sat on his cock, facing away from Mason—facing me.

There was just enough light that I’d catch flashes of Mason’s lubricated shaft disappearing inside Nicole’s hairless pussy. The sense of jealousy was still there, a low hum that underlaid everything else, like the cicadas in the trees or the fast beat of my heart. I was so riveted that I missed how Fiona leaned forward on Mason’s face to wrap her arms around Nicole’s body. She caressed the blonde’s tits with one hand as the other worked down between her legs.

Nicole arched back against the redhead, turning her head automatically to kiss Fiona over her shoulder. Mason kept hammering up into Nicole, hard enough that they had to stop kissing as she became unmoored by her own orgasm.

They held Nicole, supporting her as she rode through her storm, before laying her limp body onto the bed. She didn’t open her eyes, and if she hadn’t lifted a hand to her forehead, I would have thought she was

unconscious. Mason whispered something to Fiona, who nodded, glanced quickly out the window, then crawled in between Nicole's legs.

Nicole's mouth parted in a gasp at first touch. She pushed the hand on her forehead higher, raking it through her still-damp hair, while the other went down to the head between her legs.

When she touched Fiona's and the clip that held the other woman's red hair up, Nicole's eyes flew open in shock. Her body stiffened. Mason was there at her side, kissing her, whispering to her, soothing her.

I felt...bitter at that. Resentful. This went beyond jealousy. This treaded the dark waters of betrayal. Mason was where I should have been, acting the way I should have been acting. He'd become Nicole's rock, the solid thing that she could cling to when everything went crazy around her. Not me.

I watched her relax. I watched her let go and give into the softer touch of another woman. Mason watched it, too, caressing her face and breasts, making sure she was enjoying her time.

That only lasted so long, though. He left her in the end, moving down behind Fiona, cock in hand, and started fucking her. He was a man, and Fiona was a very willing and available woman. It was too dark to see whether Nicole minded, but Fiona apparently loved the new sensation.

The threesome fucked like that for what felt like hours, but was probably closer to minutes. I lost track of time. My eye sockets hurt from how hard I was pressing the binoculars against them. My balls felt like they were lead weights.

Nicole came. I didn't need to see much to know what that was. She crawled away from Fiona, then off the bed. Fiona and Mason didn't stop. If anything, now that they were alone, they fucked even harder. Nicole watched them for a moment, then disappeared into the bathroom.

I put the binoculars down and sat back against the tree. My surroundings returned. The wilderness, so different from the suburbs of my old home here or the city life back in DC. I took in the architecture of his home, his deck, his hot tub. Mason had a charmed life, and yet the only thing I really truly begrudged him for was Nicole, who I'd lost and he'd found.

My phone buzzed. I looked back into the dark bedroom. Fiona and Mason were still there, going at it like performers on set. Couldn't have been them. I checked my phone, and the text was an image.

Of Nicole and Fiona from earlier in the night. It was the second of the two selfies that Fiona had taken of the two of them, although I wasn't sure how it ended up on Nicole's phone. Up close, it was even hotter. Nicole's cleavage was monumental, especially when Fiona's hand pushed it higher. Nicole shot a look at Fiona over her shoulder, full of surprise, as Fiona returned it with raised eyebrows, as if to say, *Yeah, this is happening.*

The caption that came with it:

[Nicole]: Told you once I'd send you a photo if this ever happened. Happy birthday!

The intensity of emotion that rushed through me was akin to racing down a rollercoaster before I'd even known that I was on one. It caught me so off-guard. I read everything and nothing into it. I should have been upset with it. We weren't a couple anymore, so why was she bringing back these horrible emotions? But then she was, and I loved that she was, and I loved her.

I almost typed that. I had the message on my screen before I changed it.

[Me]: I would have loved to see that.

Nicole sent back a smiley face in response. And then:

[Nicole]: I bet.

As I tried to figure out how to respond, I saw movement in the bedroom again, light filling the room momentarily, then dark again. When my eyes adjusted, I saw Nicole climbing back into bed, next to Mason. She cupped her hands to his ear and whispered something.

Mason moved quickly, nodding, pulling out of Fiona. She seemed to whine before she understood what was going on, then moved as enthusiastically as Mason did. They repositioned themselves at the head of the bed, with Mason reclined against the headboard and Fiona sinking back into his lap.

Nicole's hesitation was gone. She showed no timidity as she crawled up to Fiona and kissed her. As she walked her lips down Fiona's neck, her shoulder, out along the slope of her too-perfect breasts.

Each breath I took felt deliberate, like if I didn't think about it and make myself breathe in and out, I'd forget, go light-headed, and pass out. I pressed the binoculars against my eyes until they hurt, watching Nicole's

blond head move lower and lower, watching as she stretched out on her stomach. She kissed Fiona's stomach, lower, her hip bones, the tops of her thighs.

Fiona leaned back, reclining into Mason as she opened her legs. I could just barely see her face, cloaked in shadow. I watched it now, carefully, as my ex-wife centered her head between the other woman's legs.

Ah! I saw Fiona moan, her lips parted, her head rocking back. A moment later, Mason stiffened, too, mouthing something loud and surprised.

My heart sped up. This was really happening? Nicole, sweet, sweet Nicole, was really going down on another woman and another man at the same time? I couldn't tell exactly what was happening, but I could see Nicole's hand raised to Fiona's pussy, her arm a blur. I could see the way her blond hair quivered. Could imagine her tongue dancing across Fiona's clit, the base of Mason's shaft, across his balls.

I wasn't sure how he was able to hold back. Fiona wasn't. Her mouth went wide in a silent scream—silent, I'm sure, only to me. She arched back, writhing like she'd been electrified. Mason reached around her, grabbing Nicole's hair and holding her securely between their legs.

My impulse to protect her triggered in me. I couldn't help her, though, and she probably didn't want to be helped. That became even more clear when Fiona crawled off of Mason, and Nicole grabbed his still erect cock and ran her tongue along the side of it like an ice cream cone. That, I could see in the dark—the way his shaft glistened with Fiona's come; the way Nicole held it by the base, so thick that she could barely wrap her fingers around it; the way Mason held her hair from her face so that when she did take it back into her mouth, both he and I got a clear view of the blowjob.

Nicole didn't suck him for long. She needed more. She needed to fuck. She crawled into his lap, grabbed his cock, and unceremoniously lowered herself onto it. They kissed when she had him to the hilt.

Fiona got up, leaving Nicole and Mason, and walked up to the windows. Her body was slick from her sweat, her hair darkened to auburn. In front of her, she flashed her hand, five fingers, then pointed away and up. *Meet you up there in five minutes.*

Then she pressed some mechanism that I couldn't see and lowered some blinds that had been invisible until they weren't.

I got one last glimpse of Nicole with Mason, kissing, his hand pressed between her legs. And then they were out of sight, and I was alone with my jealousy.

I made my way back up to the road, picking my way through the dark as I picked through my feelings. *No more*, I whispered to myself. It really was time to leave this be. I was happy that Nicole was having these adventures—even turned on that she was. But it was time for me to let her go.

All I needed to do was think of the last image that I had of her—cuddling with another man, kissing him, being held by him. It may get me hard just thinking about, but it wasn't healthy. It had no future, so I would give it no more present.

Fiona took closer to fifteen minutes to come get me, but she did. I wondered what I would have done had another car driven up this lonely street and found me huddled by the side of the road with a pair of binoculars and foliage stuck to my clothes.

"So that was wild," Fiona said as I pulled the door shut behind me. "You enjoy watching that?"

"That's not an easy question to answer."

Fiona looked at me, again surprising me with her empathy. "I suppose not." She drove in silence for a few minutes. "Do you wish I hadn't invited you out?"

I'd been giving the matter plenty of thought before she even asked, but I still wasn't confident in my answer. "No, I'm glad that you did."

"You were jealous, but turned on."

"Yeah. Both of those. In spades." I was both all over again. "It was intense."

"You want to go back to my place to work out that energy?" She put a hand on the inside of my thigh.

I was tempted. I really was. Nicole and I were over, and she clearly had no problem sharing her men, even if we weren't. There was also the fact that the redheaded nurse had just come from Mason, and still had the man's come buried in her pussy. It was a disturbingly erotic thought to think about reclaiming Fiona—even if she wasn't mine to reclaim.

"I don't think so," I said.

Fiona frowned. "You sure? I can tell you all about the things you may have missed while hiding."

Her hand moved higher. My cock grew stiffer. She drove a hard bargain, but—

“Really, no. It has nothing to do with you. I just...just need to be alone.”

Fiona nodded, letting it go. “You’re not going to book a flight to Asia next, are you?”

I laughed sardonically. “No. Not until after the election, anyway.”

She dropped me off at the hotel. I crawled into bed, and entered the final leg of my time in Hempstead.

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winning and losing

I lost myself in the election. I put in more time than was asked. I worked tirelessly to see the Congressman elected. I cold called. I went door-to-door. I got in touch with friends and acquaintances that I'd lost touch with, just to garner their support. I believed in this man and what he stood for.

I couldn't completely avoid Nicole, or the subject of her from the people we used to know as a couple. I'd be worried that they'd be upset with me. After all, I'd left—twice—and I'd divorced her. But it wasn't like that. No one blamed me. No one saw blame to be assigned. They were sad that we'd split up, but happy to see me again, and to hear that things were still friendly between us.

I'd seen her two times. The first had been at a bar when she was out with some girlfriends—not Fiona, but friends who I'd spoken to about the election. I'd waved, but let them be. Thankfully, Mason hasn't been there.

The second time was on Election Day, at the polls.

"Thanks for doing your civic duty," I said, handing her an "I Voted!" sticker.

She smiled, laughing. God, she was beautiful when she smiled. "You taught me to be a model citizen. This is your fault."

"Nah, it was there before we met. I just brought it out in you."

Much like Mason brought out a totally different side of her, one that has probably been buried in her as well. I hadn't tapped the potential. The man who "won" her had.

Winning and losing were things I'd been thinking of a lot recently. Obviously the election kept it top of mind—by the end of the day, there would be a slew of winners and losers, and the country would be changed because of that. These men and women would be the stewards of the country, chosen *by* the country. That's the way democracy worked. We got to choose, and we lived not just by the consequences, but all the good things that that candidate brought.

Nicole had chosen, and I'd lost. But that's the way this worked. A relationship was a two-sided thing, and I couldn't force her to pick me even if I'd campaigned as hard as I could. So instead, I didn't campaign at all. I'd walked out. I'd left.

I realized that Nicole was talking to me. “I’m sorry, what was that?”

She smiled patiently. “I was just asking how much longer you’ll be here. Or does it depend on the outcome?”

“I fly back Thursday, no matter what the outcome is. If he wins, we need to start working on the next two years. If he loses...well, we’ve got a few weeks before the lame duck session is over.”

“Thursday...” She said the word like it was language that she barely understood. “And that’s it?”

“That’s it,” I said.

Her eyebrows pinched and her mouth curved downward. “Come by. Tomorrow night.”

“I...” I heard desperation in her voice. “Why?”

“To talk. Just to talk. If you’re going to leave, we’re not going to leave things where they are now.”

She was right, we shouldn’t. But I wanted to. I felt the same pull that had sent me to Europe. Maybe Asia wasn’t such a bad idea after all.

“If he wins, then I might be back.”

Nicole grimaced at the ‘might’. “Eight o’clock. Please.”

I couldn’t say no. I shouldn’t. She was right, we needed to find closure. “Okay, eight.”

She reached out and touched my arm. I felt electricity, still, and judging by the way she looked up at me, her eyes sharp, her breath catching, she felt it, too.

“See you then.”

“Thank you for voting, ma’am.”

Nicole smiled and walked away.

*

That night, Congressman Phillips lost. It was close. So very, very close. Close enough that Mitch was talking about a recount. Phillips shut that down.

“The people have made their choice,” he told us. “Now it’s our opportunity to lose with grace.”

“But—”

He held up his hand. “It’s only for two years. Who knows, maybe we’ll be having another kind of conversation then. Thank you all for your hard

work. I could not have asked for a better, more dedicated team, both here in Hempstead and back in DC. You guys are awesome, and all have some very bright futures.”

When he looked at me, I felt an odd mixture of elation and sadness. This really was it. No more visits home. No more home. Where would I go next?

The night was somber, but certainly not sober. We hit up Martha’s Kitchen, which was pretty quiet for a Tuesday night. The television was on, but coverage was mostly on the presidential election and the results of the Senate races. A single Congressman losing would never make CNN.

It was nice to see Congressman Phillips, soon to be simply Jeffrey Phillips, citizen, as just a guy. I’d worked for him for almost two years, and until now, he’d been “the Congressman.”

“So what’s next for you?” he asked.

I took a sip of my beer, stalling. I didn’t know, and I didn’t want to tell this man that I didn’t. In the end, though, I still had nothing to say. “Probably take some time off in January. Travel some more.”

Phillips nodded. For the first time since I’d met him, he looked relaxed. “Me too. It’ll be nice to go through a week without having to make cold calls, begging for donor money.”

“I can imagine.”

“I can put a good word in for you with Congressman Stewart, if you’d like. I know he’s got some openings, and rumor has it he’ll be staying on the Ways and Means.”

“Thanks, I appreciate the offer.”

Phillips raised his brows. “Not staying in Washington?”

He meant Washington, DC, but even if he was referring the state, the answer was the same. “I’m not sure yet.”

“Don’t leave politics, Ethan. And don’t get jaded by it. Government needs more people like you if it’s ever going to get better.”

“Thanks, sir.”

I took a walk down Main Street after that. It was quiet. Tomorrow was a work day, so most people were already in bed. My breath made clouds in the cool air, but I barely felt the cold. I saw the town that I’d once imagined making a life in. I saw the town square where I’d imagined picnicking with my children, with Nicole. I saw restaurants and cafes that we’d already made memories in. I saw the life that I’d lost.

I eventually made it back to the hotel. Eventually went to sleep. I had one more day here. One last chapter to close on my time in Hempstead.
After that? The rest of my life.

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the last day

I packed my bags all day. Or that's what it felt like, anyway. I'd been here for almost a month, living out of my hotel room, and it was amazing how settled I'd become. I'd actually used the drawers that usually stayed empty. Going through and retrieving all of my things took much longer than unpacking, even for such a small space.

The other part, though, was that I knew what the packing signified. I was leaving, and chances were, I wasn't coming back. Ever again. If I went to work in another congressional office, there would be no excuse to come back here. I didn't have family in Hempstead. I'd moved here with Nicole years ago, and while I'd made friends, she was the only roots I'd put down.

So I took my damn time packing, and suddenly eight o'clock was upon me. I dreaded the moment and all of its finality, but I couldn't outrun it or ignore it or hide from it. Not anymore.

I showered. Shaved. Got ready to go over there like it was a date or a booty call or a funeral. All were appropriate. I put on a clean pair of jeans, a nice shirt that I left untucked, even a little bit of cologne, because why not.

Cabbing out there, I made sure to absorb everything I could—the town, the trees, the cute houses with their picket fences and nice lawns. It was dark by the time I was dropped off at Nicole's home—once my home, but that was long enough ago that I barely saw it that way. She'd added solar-powered lamps along the sidewalk, and a new, Japanese maple grew next to the mailbox.

The lights were on, warm yellow and inviting. I pretended that I was just another guest, and this was just another visit to Nicole's. I rang the bell, not believing it for a second.

For a panicked moment, I imagined Nicole opening the door with Mason standing behind her. They were the couple now; it made sense that he'd be here, now that I thought about it. The fear was so strong that I nearly bolted, but my ride was long gone.

I'd been running for too long. It was time to face this. It was time for the closure that the divorce had not brought.

When the door did open, Nicole was alone.

"You came," she said.

“Of course.”

“Come on in.”

I wondered if she'd fretted as much as I had over what to wear or how to look. Judging by her casual appearance, from the loose flannel shirt to the tight and fashionably torn jeans, I couldn't tell. She wore just enough makeup to bring out her eyes, and her hair was pulled back into a tight bun like a ballerina. Had she considered that? To wear it up or down? To wear it in a ponytail? To put it into a braid?

I followed her in, half expecting to find Mason sitting on the living room couch, waiting. He wasn't there.

“Can I get you anything to drink?” she asked. Before I could tell her I was fine, she added, “I just opened a bottle of Malbec, if you're interested in that.”

“Sounds great.”

She grabbed a second wine glass from a cabinet that I didn't recognize. The wine was already out on the coffee table.

Pouring, she began with small talk. “I'm sorry to hear about the election results. That sucks.”

“Yeah, not what we were hoping for.” I accepted the glass.

She took a seat on the sofa, perched on the very edge, her back straight. I mirrored her on the other end. She said, “I'm surprised you guys didn't ask for a recount.”

“Phillips knows when he's lost, and he knows how to take the loss graciously.”

Nicole held my eyes as she processed the statement, hearing all of its hidden meaning.

Guilt tightened around me. Before she could speak, I blurted, “I know I didn't do that with us. I probably handled...it all with the least grace possible.”

“You went off the grid after sending me divorce papers. Yes, I'd say you handled it without much grace.”

I winced.

She reached for a folder that I hadn't noticed, even though it was right next to the wine. She opened it, and I was surprised to see the divorce papers. “What's weird is that you never got in touch with me when you didn't receive these back.”

I blinked, confused. “You didn't sign them?”

She pulled out the thick sheet of paper. "I did. I was so pissed when I got them that I signed them right away." She leafed through the sheets until she got to the end, where her signature was on it, along with a notary's. "But before I sent them back to your lawyer, I made a decision. Unlike what you did to me, I wasn't going to do the same until we talked."

This was not the conversation I'd come here expecting, and while I wasn't sure I wanted to have it at all, I was glad she was forcing it.

"So tell me, Ethan, why are we getting divorced?"

"Because it's the right thing to do," I said. "You need to live your life."

"Correct me if I'm wrong, but I thought I was doing that without these papers."

"But it wasn't right." I was yelling. I recognized that without being able to stop it. "You wanted freedom! You wanted to be with Mason fucking Mann!"

Nicole wasn't cowed. She didn't flinch. She didn't look apologetic. Instead, she met me stare for stare, hands folded in her lap, calmly. Then, as calm as a conversation in church, she said, "And you didn't want that?"

A switch flipped inside of me, and suddenly the world went from black and white to full, frightening color. Until now, I figured my strange and uncomfortable desire to share her was my own secret. "You knew?"

"That you have a thing for me being with other men? I did, although I didn't really believe it, even after Fiona told me."

Fiona. Of course. "When did she do that?"

"Way back in...I'm not sure...the spring? Something like that. When the two of you hooked up."

I played that encounter back. It had been Fiona who'd ferreted out the fantasy, and of course she'd pass it on to Nicole. How could I have been so naive as to think that she wouldn't.

"Right," I said. And then, when I wasn't sure what else to say, I drained my glass of wine.

Nicole laughed softly. "Slow down there, Ethan. I want you sober when we talk about this."

"I don't," I said, but I put the empty glass on the table without refilling it. "Okay, so sure, maybe I've got...a weird fantasy...thing."

"Not really a fantasy though, is it?" Nicole said.

"Uh... I guess not."

"I didn't believe it until I saw you at Gracie's wedding reception."

My eyes went wide. "You did?"

"It was random chance. Saw you at the bar. Then later, out on the upper balcony."

My face grew hot. "I'm sorry. I shouldn't have done that."

I was surprised to see Nicole blushing, too, unable to meet my eyes. "You know, it...it turned me on." She was wringing her fingers together, realized that she was doing it, and forced herself to stop. She looked up at me. "When Fiona told me that you might actually get a thrill out of me and...and other guys... Well, first of all, I didn't believe her. But also, I didn't really think about what that meant. For me. But then, when I saw you there, watching... It was a rush, you know?"

"You like being watched," I said. "You've got an exhibitionist streak."

She smiled shyly. "You picked up on that, I see."

"Yeah. I didn't know until...you know."

"Until you watched me in the hotel during the fundraiser?"

She knew about that, too? My reaction gave me away.

"So that *was* you! You followed us." Her eyes glittered. "You watched us from the other room."

"How did you know?"

"I thought I heard someone, and you also told Fiona something that you shouldn't have known. Something I'd only ever shared with Mason."

I searched my memory for what that could be, then it came to me. I said, "The night of the fundraiser, you said that it was over between us."

She looked pained. "I did. I thought it was."

"You thought?" I knew I sounded hopeful, and knew that I shouldn't, but we were talking, so I might as well put it all on the table. "Has that changed?"

Nicole raised her head, her chin high, her pose elegant. "No more bullshit, Ethan. You've left me two times. I can't handle a third. I *won't* handle a third. But I...love you. And I'm still *in love* with you. Every time you text, my heart flutters. Every time we get together, it's the brightest thing of my week. When we went on that date and you took me out to the Fig & Pear, I felt like I was in high school all over again. I couldn't wait for a second one. And when you slept with Fiona, I was crushed."

I started to talk, but she raised her hand.

"No, I'm not upset at that. We were casual. I get that. I...I wasn't exactly innocent during that time, either, so it was unfair of me to hold you

to a different standard.”

“But you did.”

Nicole sighed. “I did. And I’m sorry.”

I took a deep breath. I had a feeling where this conversation was going, and I needed to head it off before more feelings were hurt. “I can’t go back to that, Nicole. It was fun. When we got together, it was some of the best sex in my life.”

Nicole, my ex-wife, actually blushed at that.

“But I need more. I want to have nights like at the Fig & Pear. I want to be able to attend a fundraiser with you on my arm—or on your arm. I want to have what Mason does, not to be the other man in this relationship.”

A smile slowly spread across Nicole’s face—not a purely mischievous one, although there was certainly mischief in her upturned lips. When the smile reached her eyes, they grew wet, glossy, wavering in the light.

“But you also want to keep watching me with Mason,” she said.

“I...” Be honest. “Yes. Maybe. I do, but I don’t.”

Her laugh came out as almost a sob. “You know I’m not sure what I’m supposed to do with that, right?”

“Sorry. It’s confusing to me, too.” I sighed. “But I’m also happy for you, and happy that you found Mason. He makes you...happy.” I groaned. How many times could I see that word?

“We broke up.”

“I’m sorry, what? I don’t think I heard that right.”

She wiped a tear from her eye and laughed. “We broke up. Right after your birthday.”

A light bulb went off. “You set that up. With Fiona. Not Fiona.”

“It was our collective idea. Mason had been hinting at a threesome, I wanted to get something special for your birthday, and that slut Fiona was only too happy to help out.”

“Wow. That’s...crazy. You’re the best girlfriend a guy could ask for.”

Nicole scooted closer to me, reached out, and took my hand. “It’s wife, dear, not girlfriend.”

“You mean—”

“The papers are yours. They’re signed. If you want to send them to our lawyers, I understand. But if you want to give this crazy thing one more try, and you promise not to bolt, but talk these things through, then I’d like to, too.”

I turned my hand over, accepting hers. Things went blurry before I realized that I was on the verge of crying, too. It made me laugh out loud. “Am I dreaming? I swear, this is a dream.”

“You’re not dreaming. After that night with Fiona, I kept going back to how exciting it was—and not for the reasons you’re probably hoping for. Fiona was fun, but I still don’t think I’m really into girls. Or, not *that* into them, anyway.” She laughed. “But what was really exciting was that I knew you were there, watching me. It made everything so much sexier. And then I started to imagine a life without you in it, and it felt empty. Alone. Mason was never a long-term solution.”

“You’d meet him one day, though,” I said, feeling self-pity. “The long-term solution I mean.”

“I know. But I also met him years ago, and then again this last year.”

“Are you sure?” I asked. Dare I really feel hope again? “This could be a rebound. You *did* just break up.”

“Mason was my rebound. Actually, I picked Mason specifically because I didn’t want *you* to be my rebound.”

“Does he know that?” I suddenly felt bad for the guy.

“He does now. And besides...it’s not like he and I can’t still have some fun.”

My pants tightened. My blood rushed. “You mean...”

She nodded. Now her smile was all mischief. “We’ve gotten together a couple times since we ‘broke up.’ But if you want that to stop...” She bit her lip. “If we get back together, all of that stops.”

In a weird way, it was sexier that she’d fucked Mason after the breakup.

“Do you love him?”

Nicole thought long and hard. “In a sense, I do. Love is...complicated. I care about him. It was really hard to break up with him. But...I wouldn’t say I love him. Not like I ever have loved you.”

It wasn’t a clean answer, but I knew that it was the best that I was going to get.

I wasn’t sure about the next thing I was about to say, but said it anyway. “If you got together with him again...” My heart surged. “Would you tell me about it?”

Nicole didn’t react, but she also didn’t immediately reply. She took a slow, deliberate breath, then said, “Would you like to watch?”

I swear my voice nearly cracked. “Yes.”

“He’s coming over. Tonight. To collect all the things he left here.” She gestured to a duffel bag beside the sofa.

“Tonight, huh? Seems pretty coincidental.”

Nicole flushed deeply, then laughed at her own bashfulness. “I mean, I didn’t know how tonight was going to go.”

I laughed with her. “So is this plan A or plan B?”

“I can give him the bag and kick him out. He’ll understand.”

“Or?” I asked, my heart beginning to chug faster.

“Or I could put the bag upstairs in the bedroom for when he comes, and you could hide in the closet.”

I liked where this was going, but I tried to think it through, even as the world kept trying to knock me off of my feet. “Would he spend the night?”

Nicole thought about it.

I said, “In the past, since your breakup, did he spend the night?”

Nicole looked nervous. “Yeah.”

“That’s so hot,” I muttered, then laughed. “Okay, so not the bedroom.”

“Okay. I can get rid of him.”

“Oh, no, let’s not waste this opportunity.” I looked around. “You two ever do it in here?”

“No, actually.”

I pulled out my phone. “We’ll use this to video conference. You still have that desktop in the office?”

Nicole lit up. “It’s the one room that I haven’t touched.”

I stood and went to the bookshelf, opposite the couch, and set my phone there, its back facing out. With a couple picture frames around it and the nondescript case, it would blend right in.

Excitement wound itself around my body. I said, “I’ll be watching from up there.”

“You’re sure about this?”

“As sure as I can be about any of this.”

friends with benefits

We'd turned the third bedroom into an office, and it was sweltering. The room wasn't large, and not only had Nicole not touched the space since I'd moved out, but I was pretty sure she had come in here only a couple times, too. It felt stuffy, which only added to the tightness I was feeling.

Or maybe that was just me. My heart was certainly pumping blood like I was on the last leg of a marathon. It was a fitting analogy, considering where we were and what had come before. We'd been just kids, then married, then separated, then broken up. And now, here we were. The only thing about the analogy that wasn't quite right was the final part. We'd gone through a lot, but I wasn't going to make the mistake of thinking that we'd have no more trials and hardships in the years to come. What was more important to me was that there were years to come at all.

I had the computer on and was logged into Skype as my phone broadcast the living room downstairs. The picture was crystal clear, showing a nervous Nicole pacing the room. She'd asked if I thought that she should change into something sexier. I'd told her I liked her just the way she was. If Mason wasn't attracted to *this* Nicole, then I'd be more than happy to step in when he left.

The front doorbell rang. On screen, Nicole stiffened, took a deep breath, and looked right into the camera. "Can you hear me?"

Of course, she couldn't hear me. We'd muted the speakers. I slipped out of the room and stuck my head down the top of the stairs. She was there, staring up, looking nervous. I gave her a thumbs up.

She mouthed, *I love you*, and my heart sang. I mouthed it back, then slipped out of sight. I didn't go back into the computer room immediately, though. I hung out at the top of the stairs, my back to the wall, listening.

The door opened. My gut churned. This was it.

"Hey, Mason." Nicole said softly.

"Hey, Nicky."

I cringed at the name. I never thought she liked being called that, but apparently to Mason, she was "Nicky."

"Come on in."

"Thanks."

So polite. I listened to them move into the room, the door shutting behind them. He wasn't leaving right away. This wasn't going to end right at the door. I was surprised that a part of me was hoping that it would—but it was a very small, very quiet part.

“You look good, Mason.”

Those were the first words I'd said to Nicole, way back when we first got together. I wonder if she'd done that on purpose, or was just nervous.

“And you always do, Nicky.”

Involuntarily, I gulped down air. My ears clogged with the beat of my heart and the roar of my breath. When they cleared, I heard him say, “...sorry, shouldn't have said that.”

“A girl can always take a compliment,” Nicole said.

I moved quietly down the hall, toward the home office. They were in the kitchen, which was in the background of the video feed and not ideally positioned. Nicole was filling a couple glasses of wine, polishing off the bottle of Malbec that we'd opened. There was probably symbology in that, but I didn't bother analyzing it.

Mason held his glass up. Nicole was leaning against the counter, studying him. The picture was clear enough that I could see desire etched in her pretty features.

He said, “So what are we toasting?”

“To remaining friends,” Nicole said.

“Always.” He tipped his glass against her, and when he lifted his glass to his lips, he watched her do the same.

He set the glass on the counter beside her, bringing him close. When he leaned down and kissed her, she didn't turn away.

I wished that they were standing closer, but was happy that they weren't. I could see the wide view of what was happening, like how she squeezed the edge of the counter as he pushed his tongue past her lips, and the way he lifted his hand to her breast.

“One more time, for the memories?” he asked.

“Mm, for the memories.” Nicole slipped her hand into his and led him to the sofa. Her eyes zeroed in on the camera, and I felt a jolt as I looked at her through the feed.

Releasing his hand, she started unbuttoning the flannel before she'd made it all the way to the couch.

Beneath, she wore a white bra, embroidered in fine lace. It was almost bridal, lifting and presenting her tits in a bountiful display of flesh.

Mason slid in behind her, encasing her in his arms. He went to work on her jeans, unsnapping the tight denim enough to open them.

She wore lace panties that matched her bra, white and pure and delicate. Mason pushed his fingers under the frilly hem, and Nicole arched back and moaned. He captured her mouth in an over-the-shoulder kiss, the transition so seamless I couldn't help but imagine that they'd done this many times before.

"You're soaking," Mason said. He withdrew his fingers, glistening with her excitement. "This pussy's going to miss me."

Nicole looked at the camera out of the corner of her eye. "Yes, I'm so wet."

When he pressed his fingers against Nicole's lips, she opened them, sucking on them like a cock. With her free hands, she wiggled out of her tight jeans, revealing her white panties to be a wide-banded thong.

Mason stepped back, "Fuck, I'm going to miss you."

Nicole spun away, releasing his fingers, and threw herself onto the couch. "Show me how much you're going to miss me."

Mason whipped his shirt off, revealing his toned upper body. Nicole's eyes danced over the hard ripples of his lean muscles, from his thick arms to his six-pack abs to the barrel of his lean chest. I felt envy, jealousy, and a dash of insecurity. How could I compete with this stallion of a man?

He unbuckled his jeans, dropping them along with his boxers. With his back to me, I couldn't see his cock, but I could see Nicole's reaction to it. Her eyelids grew heavy, her pupils dilating. She bit her lower lip with her upper teeth, smiling with excitement.

"This evidence enough?" he asked.

Nicole unfastened her bra, releasing her tits, which were capped by hard, swollen nipples. "Close, but I've always believed that it's not how big it is, but how you use it."

Mason laughed. "I'm going to fuck you so hard, Nicky. Take off your panties."

Her nostrils flared as she obeyed, bringing her knees together as she pulled the thong off.

"Touch yourself," he ordered. Judging from the movement of his arm, I guessed he was stroking himself for her, getting it nice and large. "I want

to watch you get off one last time.”

“Mmmkay,” she said. With a glance in my direction, she slowly walked her right hand down between her thighs, sliding her fingertips across her bald and glistening mound.

“That’s it,” Mason said. “Feel how wet you are. You like it when I watch, don’t you?”

Nicole continued to chew her lower lip. She nodded. “I like being watched.”

“Use both hands,” he said. “Finger yourself as you play with your clit.”

I winced at his order, but Nicole didn’t hesitate. Her left hand joined her right, and she immediately buried two fingers into her pussy. She played to the visual, making sure that her arms pressed her tits together, and we could see her smear her pussy juice across her sex.

“Look at you, baby. So wet. So fucking hot. I wonder if anyone else knows how dirty you can be. You’re so hard working, so responsible, so innocent...”

“Yes,” Nicole hissed.

“But you’re not innocent, are you?”

“No.” Nicole kept working her clit.

“No, you’re not. You like to have sex, don’t you?”

“Yes.”

“You like to fuck in dangerous places.”

“Uh, huh...” Her eyelids fell, clouding with memory.

“Remember when you dragged me into that empty meeting room after that political fundraiser? Couldn’t even wait to get home.”

She closed her eyes completely. She nodded.

“Or when I fingered you at that club in Seattle?”

Nicole fingered herself faster, reliving it.

“Or when we fucked in the bathroom at Gracie’s wedding reception. God, I couldn’t believe how horny you were that night.”

“Ngh!”

With her fingers working a flurry between her legs, the light danced across her rings—the Celtic knot on her thumb, the crimson stone on her middle finger, and our engagement ring on her left hand. My own breath caught. She’d put it back on. She’d put it back on and I hadn’t noticed.

She arched back, pointing her toes and thrusting her chest out as she came.

“Now it’s my turn,” Mason said. He climbed on the sofa, planting a knee between her legs. She opened her eyes, her breath catching at the sight of him. “Feel how hard you made me.”

Nicole reached out. I couldn’t see her hand, but that made it all sexier. “I’m going to miss this,” she said.

“You don’t have to, you know. I make a good friend-with-benefits.”

Nicole’s laugh was delightful. “I bet you do.”

“Isn’t that what we were at first?” He lowered himself over her, lining his pelvis up with Nicole’s.

“You mean when we got drunk at the Christmas party and ended up back at your place to ‘listen to some records’?”

I had a feeling the over-exposition was for me, to tease me, to make me jealous. It worked. She even chanced a glance at the camera over Mason’s shoulder.

Mason said, “Pretty transparent, when you put it that way.”

“Don’t worry, I wanted it just as much as you.”

He rocked his hips forward and she gasped. “Uh, you feel good,” he said.

“And you feel—” Her breath caught. “*So good*,” she finished in a hurry. “So...big.”

“Time to show you that it’s not just size that matters, but how you use it,” Mason said.

When he lifted his ass, I saw the penetration, crystal clear on the high def monitor: Nicole’s clean shaven pussy stretched around Mason’s cock bottle thick cock. It looked obscene. It looked impossible. It looked so lewdly beautiful.

He thrust forward, clenching his ass, driving all of that hard meat into her. She shuddered beneath him, her feet finding purchase on the edge of the sofa. Athletically, she pushed up with his next thrust, meeting his hips. His balls swung, slapping against her buttocks. He took her harder, faster, merciless.

“Yes, yes, yes!” she cried beneath the onslaught. She clung to his arms, taut with gym-hewn muscle.

I watched his cock drill again and again into my wife’s pussy, listened to her sharp groans, her high sighs. I wanted to unbuckle my pants and take

care of myself, but resisted. When she came upstairs, I wanted her to feel exactly what this did to me. No more hiding. No more doubt.

“I’m close,” she gasped. “Are you, baby?”

Mason responded with a clipped ‘yes’.

“Ungh! Come, baby. Fill me up. I want to feel you fill me up!”

At that moment, she looked over Mason’s shoulder and opened her eyes. I knew she couldn’t see me, but it didn’t diminish the connection I felt with her. *I love you*, I mouthed to no one. Coincidentally, she did the same thing.

Then Mason rammed one last, hard time into her. He buried his face in her neck, grunting, coming, spilling himself into her one final time.

*

Mason left after that. Their parting was tender, but dignified.

He didn’t ask her to reconsider. He didn’t even offer the friends-with-benefits arrangement. He just collected her into his arms and said, “I had fun. Thanks for not throwing out all of my things.”

Nicole laughed. “Well, trash pickup is tomorrow, so you made it by a day.”

“You’re an amazing, sexy, smart woman, Nicky. Whoever you end up with better know that, or I’m going to come looking.”

Nicole wrapped her arms around his neck. “You too, Mason.”

“Eh, I’m still not looking for anyone to settle down with.” He said it, but when I saw the way he looked at my wife, I wasn’t sure how true the statement was.

“When you meet her, you’ll know,” Nicole said.

Mason’s smile was less than genuine, as toothy and proud as it was. “I’m sure I will.”

They kissed one last time, and while it still registered as exciting and nauseous, the confusing emotions were less potent.

“Goodbye, Nicky.”

“Goodbye, Mason.”

She led him to the door, out of sight of the camera. I heard it open and close. I thought I heard Nicole sigh. Then she was making her way up the stairs, up to me.

“Hey there,” she said from the doorway. She’d put her flannel shirt on, buttoning it just enough to close it around her breasts, but was naked underneath. It was a tasty sight. “You okay?”

I turned in the chair, slightly embarrassed by my erection. “I am. Are you?”

“Yeah, I am.”

“That wasn’t what I thought it would be,” I said. “I think he’s in love with you.”

Nicole colored. “No, that’s silly. Mason isn’t that kind of guy.”

I rose, crossing over to her. “Maybe not before he met you. And he may not have even realized it until just now. Trust me, I’ve got experience in the department of Realizing Things Only When They’re Gone.”

She lifted her chin. “Well, he can’t have me.”

I hugged her. “I love you so much, Nicole.”

“I know.” She led me into the bedroom, pulling off her flannel shirt in the process. I stripped quickly, finally freeing my erection. Seeing it, she said, “You really do like to watch.”

“And you like to *be* watched.”

She nodded. “Come here. Onto the bed.”

I joined her, lying on my back as she straddled me. Her pussy was swollen and pink with overuse. “Are you going to be sore?”

“I don’t care,” she said, positioning me against her pussy and letting her weight do the work. We groaned together. She felt different, after *him*. Wetter, obviously. Looser. “I need to feel you inside of me. If you could crawl right up under my skin, I’d want that.”

She reclined over me, pressing her breasts against my chest, trying to get as much of her skin on my skin. I ran my hands down her back, slick and sweaty, and palmed her ass.

“So he fingered you in a club, huh?”

“He did. It was very naughty.”

“And you fucked in the bathroom at that reception?”

Nicole nipped at my ear. “*After* I discovered you there. It got me so horny.” She stroked me with her hips, guiding them with more confidence than she’d had back when we were married. “You know what the hottest moment of tonight was?”

“Watching you getting pounded by Mason Mann?”

“That was the hottest thing for you? Yeah, that was fun. But for me...” Her hips picked up speed. “...for me, it was when I was playing with myself, knowing that both of you guys were watching me. Knowing that *you* were watching me.”

“We’ve never done that before,” I said. “The masturbation thing.”

“We haven’t, but we should.”

“You did that for Mason?” Adrenaline poured through my veins.

“I did.”

“Did you do anything with him? That...that we haven’t?”

Nicole pulled back so she could look me in the eye. “Well...” she said, a smile breaking across her face when she saw my lustful look. “I had sex with another woman, but you saw that.”

She must have felt me grow inside of her. “Yeah. That was amazing. Anything else?”

She caressed my cheek, tracing my features like she was exploring me for the first time. “You want there to be, don’t you?”

Yes? No? I didn’t know. “I’m not sure.”

She found her stride, fucking me faster, her eyes boring into mine. “You like thinking of me being naughty.”

“Yes,” I said, shortly.

“Good, because I want to be bad for you.”

She kissed me.

“Want to watch me play with another woman again?”

“Oh, Nicole...”

“Want to watch me play with another man?”

My breath caught. I felt my cock grow inside of her.

She kissed down my jaw and into the crook of my neck. “We could go into the city, out to a bar...”

I saw it. I imagined it. I was there.

“I could wear a tight little dress and go to the bar, alone.”

I imagined her in a little black dress, her hair down, leaning against a bar as every man in the place looked on.

“I did that, you know. After you left...the first time. I went out. Made myself available. Flirted.” She spoke in short, breathy sentences. She was close. I was close. “I was out with Fiona when these two guys approached us. Young, military guys.”

“Did you...” I couldn’t even say it. I grabbed her hips, helping her bounce in my lap as my mind filled with the dark image of two burly guys stepping up to Fiona and Nicole.

“Did I fuck one?”

“Did you?”

Her breathing was heavy and loud against my ear. “Yes.”

I grunted, the force of my climax catching me off guard. It had been building all night long, and now that it was here, it scrambled my brain. The burly guy was with Nicole. Alone. Naked. In the dark, their breathing heavy, their bodies covered in sweat and—

“Oh, Nicole!”

“Yes, Ethan. Come.” Nicole moaned, joining me, losing herself in me again. She rode me hard, slamming her hips until neither of us could take it any longer. “Yes, fuck me. Fill me up, Ethan, baby.”

I sought out her mouth. Finding it. Kissing it. Savoring it.

She came down hard, sweaty and limp and laughing at the intensity of our orgasm.

“Wow,” she sighed.

“Yeah.” I took a deep breath, but it just didn’t seem like enough. I brushed her hair, smoothing the sweaty bangs off her forehead. “So that really happened?”

I loved that despite everything, asking her if she really did have a one-night stand could make her blush. “Yeah. Happened, like, about six months after you’d moved to DC. I was feeling lonely, Fiona wanted to cheer me up, so we went out...”

“Anyone tell you that Fiona’s probably not the best influence?”

Nicole laughed. “Or totally the best, depending on your perspective.”

“So how many guys did you...you know.”

“Did I sleep with when we were separated? How many girls did you?”

My face lit up. I was tempted to deny. I didn’t. No more of that. “Five, including one woman who was pretty serious.”

“The makeup kit,” Nicole said.

“I’m sorry about that. We’d broken up when you found that.”

She said, “Don’t apologize. You don’t have to. I’m not naive. We weren’t together.” She kissed me. “Besides, including Mason and my military boy, I was with six.”

Despite my recent orgasm, I felt myself starting to stir again. “Wow. Impressive.”

“It was a weird time for me. I’ve never been like that. Ever.”

“Do you regret it?” I asked.

“No. I think I needed it. Some self-exploration, you could say. I learned a lot about myself.”

“Like that you like being watched?” I brushed her shoulder.

“Yeah. And I kind of liked being pursued. Before, that always led to these serious relationships, which I was fine with. But when we were out and those guys came up to us, I figured what the hell, and decided to go for it. Just for fun.” She rested her head on my shoulder. “And it was so much fun.”

“So do you...still want that? The freedom, I mean?”

Nicole looked up at me, but from my angle, I couldn’t look into her eyes. “I want to be with you, Ethan. I told you that.”

I shifted onto my side, so we were face-to-face. My heart began to race, my blood thick, as I pondered whether I should say this next thing. Then I stopped pondering. Time to lay it all out. “What if you could have both?”

Nicole smiled. “I thought you might say that.”

“And?” My face must have been so red, but it felt good to say, good to get it out in the open.

“And I suppose anything’s possible.”